

ECONOMIC INTELLIGENCE SERIES

U.S. Metro Economic Health Report

50 Metropolitan Statistical Areas

Percentile-Based Composite Scoring · 8 Metrics · BLS & FRED Data
85% Employment / 15% Housing · September 2026

TOP PERFORMERS

#1	A+	Raleigh	72.0
#2	A+	Salt Lake City	71.8
#3	A+	St. Louis	71.2
#4	A+	Kansas City	69.3
#5	A+	Cincinnati	68.4
#6	A	Hartford	67.7
#7	A	Austin	67.0

MARKETS UNDER PRESSURE

#50	D	Detroit	25.7
#49	C-	Louisville	27.0
#48	C-	Chicago	29.9
#47	C-	Jacksonville	30.6
#46	C-	Fresno	31.7
#45	C	Grand Rapids	32.1
#44	C	Indianapolis	32.8

GRADE DISTRIBUTION

A+ / A / A-	10 cities
B+ / B / B-	24 cities
C+ / C / C-	15 cities
D	1 cities

Data sources: U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics (BLS) · Federal Reserve Economic Data (FRED)
Unemployment, CLF Growth, Earnings, Employment, Weekly Hours sourced from BLS LAUS / SAE.
Building Permits from Census Bureau via FRED. Days on Market from Realtor.com / FRED.

Scoring methodology: percentile ranking across all 50 metros.
Full methodology: SCORING_README.md
Pipeline runs weekly via GitHub Actions.

Full Rankings

All 50 Metropolitan Statistical Areas · Sorted by composite score · September 2026

#	METRO	GRADE	SCORE	UNEMP.	WAGE YOY	EMP. YOY	CLF YOY	DOM
1	Raleigh Raleigh-Cary	A+	72.0	3.2%	+3.2%	+2.2%	+0.5%	59 days
2	Salt Lake City Salt Lake City-Murray	A+	71.8	3.5%	+4.5%	+2.5%	+1.1%	57 days
3	St. Louis St. Louis	A+	71.2	3.8%	+3.5%	+0.7%	+0.5%	45 days
4	Kansas City Kansas City	A+	69.3	3.8%	+7.3%	+0.7%	+0.3%	50 days
5	Cincinnati Cincinnati	A+	68.4	3.7%	+8.1%	+0.3%	-0.2%	42 days
6	Hartford Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford	A	67.7	2.7%	+5.3%	+1.9%	+2.8%	36 days
7	Austin Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos	A	67.0	4.0%	+5.1%	+1.2%	+0.8%	73 days
8	Charlotte Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia	A	66.9	3.7%	+4.2%	+1.5%	-0.7%	61 days
9	Las Vegas Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas	A	66.0	5.4%	+4.2%	+1.5%	+1.0%	58 days
10	Philadelphia Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington	A	65.2	4.2%	+2.1%	+0.8%	+1.4%	48 days
11	Dallas Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington	B+	58.3	4.6%	+4.0%	+1.0%	+0.8%	58 days
12	Pittsburgh Pittsburgh	B+	58.1	3.7%	+3.3%	-0.1%	+1.6%	53 days
13	Orlando Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford	B+	56.6	4.7%	+6.1%	+0.8%	+0.2%	75 days
14	Baltimore Baltimore-Columbia-Towson	B+	55.0	4.2%	+6.0%	-0.5%	-0.0%	44 days
15	Columbus Columbus	B	54.1	3.2%	+4.2%	+0.1%	-1.4%	44 days
16	San Francisco San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont	B	52.5	4.4%	+5.8%	+0.6%	-1.7%	38 days
17	Nashville Nashville-Davidson--Murfreesboro--Franklin	B	52.4	3.1%	+3.9%	+0.7%	-0.9%	60 days
18	Atlanta Atlanta-Sandy Springs-Roswell	B	52.3	3.2%	+3.1%	-0.5%	+0.9%	59 days
19	Cleveland Cleveland	B	52.0	3.4%	+0.9%	+0.6%	+1.8%	55 days
20	Seattle Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue	B	50.7	5.0%	+5.4%	+0.9%	-0.8%	45 days
21	Miami Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach	B	50.5	3.7%	+7.7%	+0.3%	-0.2%	85 days
22	Los Angeles Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim	B	50.3	5.0%	+3.4%	+1.8%	-2.2%	53 days
23	Tampa Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater	B	50.3	4.8%	+5.1%	+0.9%	-0.5%	74 days
24	Houston Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands	B-	47.8	5.1%	+1.2%	+1.3%	+0.3%	52 days

#	METRO	GRADE	SCORE	UNEMP.	WAGE YOY	EMP. YOY	CLF YOY	DOM
25	Washington DC Washington-Arlington-Alexandria	B-	47.3	4.0%	+5.8%	-2.0%	-2.2%	43 days
26	San Antonio San Antonio-New Braunfels	B-	46.6	4.7%	+3.7%	+0.5%	+0.1%	68 days
27	New York New York-Newark-Jersey City	B-	45.6	4.3%	+1.9%	+0.5%	+0.6%	56 days
28	Birmingham Birmingham	B-	45.6	3.5%	+0.0%	+0.9%	-1.1%	59 days
29	Phoenix Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler	B-	45.4	4.8%	+3.3%	+0.9%	-2.7%	67 days
30	Boston Boston-Cambridge-Newton	B-	45.4	3.9%	+2.9%	-0.1%	+2.9%	51 days
31	Denver Denver-Aurora-Centennial	B-	44.8	4.1%	+2.1%	+0.1%	-1.7%	57 days
32	San Jose San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara	B-	44.6	4.1%	-0.8%	+1.6%	-0.5%	36 days
33	Providence Providence-Warwick	B-	44.3	4.3%	+3.1%	+0.6%	+1.7%	39 days
34	Oklahoma City Oklahoma City	B-	44.2	4.3%	+4.2%	+0.7%	-0.5%	55 days
35	Portland Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro	C+	42.4	4.9%	+5.7%	-1.5%	-0.6%	61 days
36	San Diego San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad	C+	41.6	4.7%	+7.5%	+0.7%	-1.8%	45 days
37	Sacramento Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom	C+	40.2	5.0%	+2.0%	+0.8%	-1.9%	50 days
38	Memphis Memphis	C+	40.1	4.7%	+4.5%	-0.5%	-0.9%	68 days
39	Minneapolis Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington	C+	39.4	4.4%	+0.3%	+1.4%	-1.3%	39 days
40	Milwaukee Milwaukee-Waukesha	C+	39.2	3.8%	+0.5%	-0.2%	+0.8%	36 days
41	Virginia Beach Virginia Beach-Chesapeake-Norfolk	C	37.8	3.9%	+5.5%	-0.6%	-0.9%	40 days
42	Riverside Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario	C	34.2	5.7%	+5.5%	+0.8%	-1.8%	63 days
43	Richmond Richmond	C	33.8	3.8%	+2.4%	-0.8%	-0.9%	44 days
44	Indianapolis Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood	C	32.8	3.4%	+0.6%	-1.1%	-1.0%	51 days
45	Grand Rapids Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood	C	32.1	4.3%	+1.4%	+0.7%	-7.5%	38 days
46	Fresno Fresno	C-	31.7	7.7%	+4.5%	+0.8%	-1.4%	57 days
47	Jacksonville Jacksonville	C-	30.6	4.9%	+1.3%	+0.1%	-0.3%	65 days
48	Chicago Chicago-Naperville-Elgin	C-	29.9	4.9%	+3.3%	+0.2%	-2.5%	36 days
49	Louisville Louisville-Jefferson County	C-	27.0	4.8%	+1.7%	-0.1%	+0.2%	44 days
50	Detroit Detroit-Warren-Dearborn	D	25.7	6.0%	+1.5%	-0.2%	+0.7%	40 days

Raleigh

Raleigh-Cary

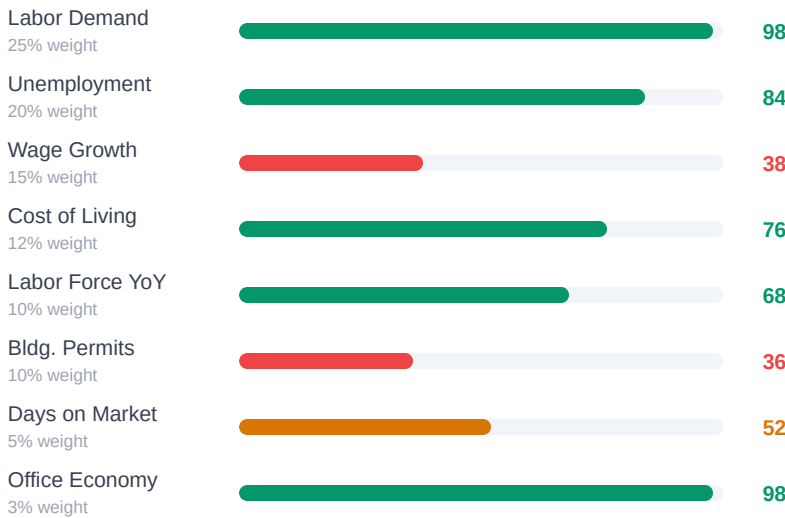
A+

EXCELLENT

72.0th percentile

Rank 1 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

3.2%
of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+3.2%
avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

+2.2%
nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE YOY

+0.5%
civilian labor force growth

BUILDING PERMITS

-5.7%
residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

59 days
median, +7.3% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Raleigh-Cary metro area has earned an overall grade of A+ with a composite score of 72.0th percentile, ranking it among the top US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its exceptional labor demand, with a composite score in the 98th percentile, and its strong office economy, also in the 98th percentile, with 4.54 out of 5 score in professional/office worker share. The labor demand is driven by a 2.23% year-over-year employment growth rate and a 1.207% deviation in weekly hours above its own trend.

Labor Demand

The Raleigh-Cary metro area exhibits a strong labor demand, with a 2.23% year-over-year employment growth rate and a 1.207% deviation in weekly hours above its own trend, signaling genuine demand expansion. This combination indicates that the city is experiencing a significant increase in job creation, with workers also putting in more hours, suggesting a thriving economy. The labor demand composite score of 8.63 further reinforces this, placing the city in the top tier.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Raleigh-Cary stands at 3.20%, which is in the top tier, ranking it in the 84th percentile. This low unemployment rate signifies a tight labor market, making it more challenging for businesses to hire new employees. As a result, companies may face upward pressure on wages to attract and retain top talent.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Raleigh-Cary is 3.16%, which is below average, ranking it in the 38th percentile. This moderate wage growth rate implies that labor costs for employers are increasing, but at a slower pace, and worker purchasing power is also growing, albeit not as rapidly as in other metros. This could be a consideration for businesses looking to manage labor expenses.

Cost of Living

Raleigh-Cary has a cost of living score that ranks it in the 76th percentile, with a price-to-salary ratio of \$215/sqft to \$38.60/hr, or 5.57. The fact that the PSF is falling by 2.3% year-over-year relative to wages makes the city more affordable compared to its peers. This affordability advantage can be a significant talent attraction factor, as businesses may not need to offer substantial wage premiums to compensate for a high cost of living.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Raleigh-Cary is growing at a rate of 0.48% year-over-year, which is above average, ranking it in the 68th percentile. This expansion in the labor force supply suggests that the city's hiring capacity is increasing, providing businesses with a larger pool of potential employees. However, the growth rate is not exceptionally high, indicating a moderate increase in workforce availability.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Raleigh-Cary has decreased by 5.68% year-over-year, which is below average, ranking it in the 36th percentile. This decline in residential building permits may signal a tightening of the housing supply, potentially leading to decreased affordability and increased competition for workforce accommodation in the future.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Raleigh-Cary is 59 days, with a year-over-year increase of 7.3%. This places the city near the median in terms of housing market speed, ranking it in the 52nd percentile. For workers relocating to this city, the market is relatively accessible, with homes not selling excessively quickly, providing a reasonable window for finding suitable housing.

Office Economy

Raleigh-Cary boasts a deep professional talent pool, with an office economy score ranking it in the 98th percentile. This makes the city an ideal location for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, which require a high concentration of specialized knowledge workers. Conversely, it may be less suited for industries with primarily industrial or logistics-oriented workforces.

The Raleigh-Cary metro area offers businesses a unique combination of strong labor demand, a deep professional talent pool, and relatively affordable cost of living, making it an attractive location for corporate investment. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers to consider is the potential tightening of the housing supply due to the decline in building permits, which could impact future affordability and workforce accommodation.

Salt Lake City

Salt Lake City-Murray

A+

EXCELLENT

71.8th percentile

Rank 2 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Salt Lake City-Murray metro area has earned an overall grade of A+ with a composite score of 71.8th percentile, ranking it among the top US metros. This city's economic character is largely defined by its strong labor demand, with a composite score in the 90th percentile, and its deep professional talent pool, ranking in the 92nd percentile. The combination of a 2.49% employment growth rate and a -0.398% weekly hours deviation signals genuine demand expansion.

Labor Demand

The Salt Lake City-Murray metro area has seen a 2.49% employment growth rate year-over-year, combined with a -0.398% deviation in weekly hours from its own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a genuine demand expansion, indicating that the city is adding jobs and workers are putting in slightly fewer hours, suggesting a healthy labor market. The labor demand composite score of 7.39 places the city in the top tier, with a 90th percentile rank.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Salt Lake City-Murray stands at 3.50%, placing it in the 72nd percentile. This indicates a relatively tight labor market, although not extremely so. For a business trying to hire in this city, the moderate unemployment rate means that while it may not be extremely difficult to find talent, there is still some competition for workers, and wages may be subject to upward pressure.

Wage Growth

The city has experienced a 4.49% year-over-year wage growth rate, ranking it in the 64th percentile. This moderate wage growth suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not extremely rapidly. At the same time, workers are seeing their purchasing power increase, which can have positive effects on local consumer demand.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of \$263/sqft to \$39.26/hr, resulting in a ratio of 6.70, Salt Lake City-Murray ranks in the 37th percentile for affordability. This means the city is relatively expensive compared to its peers. The modest affordability score implies that attracting talent may require wage premiums to offset the higher cost of living.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Salt Lake City-Murray has grown by 1.13% year-over-year, placing it in the 86th percentile. This positive growth rate indicates that the workforce supply is expanding, which is a favorable condition for businesses looking to hire, as it suggests a growing pool of potential employees.

Building Permits

The city has seen a 28.20% year-over-year increase in residential building permits, ranking it in the 84th percentile. This significant rise in permits suggests that housing supply is expanding, which can lead to improved affordability and a more accommodating environment for the workforce in the future.

Days on Market

Homes in Salt Lake City-Murray are currently selling in a median of 57 days, with a -1.7% year-over-year change, placing the city in the 22nd percentile. This relatively fast pace of home sales indicates a competitive market for relocating workers, potentially making it challenging for them to find and secure housing.

Office Economy

The city's professional and office worker share is ranked in the 92nd percentile, indicating a deep and talented pool of workers suited for tech, finance, consulting, and HQ decisions. This makes Salt Lake City-Murray an attractive location for businesses in these sectors, but less ideal for those in industrial or logistics-dominant fields.

In conclusion, Salt Lake City-Murray offers businesses a strong labor market with genuine demand expansion, a growing workforce, and a deep professional talent pool. However, the relatively high cost of living and competitive housing market may pose challenges for attracting and retaining talent without offering wage premiums, making it a key consideration for decision-makers.

St. Louis

St. Louis

A+

EXCELLENT

71.2th percentile

Rank 3 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand 25% weight		78
Unemployment 20% weight		82
Wage Growth 15% weight		48
Cost of Living 12% weight		96
Labor Force YoY 10% weight		70
Bldg. Permits 10% weight		66
Days on Market 5% weight		28
Office Economy 3% weight		54

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT 3.8% of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY +3.5% avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH +0.7% nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY +0.5% civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS +18.1% residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET 45 days median, 0.0% YoY
LABOR MARKET SIGNAL STRONG Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.	

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

St. Louis boasts an overall grade of A+ with a composite score ranking at the 71.2th percentile among 50 US metros. The city's economic character is largely defined by its strong labor demand, with a composite score of 6.44, and its highly affordable cost of living, ranked at the 96th percentile. These metrics signal a city with a thriving job market and an attractive environment for talent.

Labor Demand

St. Louis exhibits a notable employment growth rate of +0.68% year-over-year, combined with a +1.193% deviation in weekly hours above its own trend. This combination signals genuine demand expansion, indicating that the city is experiencing a real increase in job opportunities and working hours. This is a positive sign for businesses looking to establish or expand operations in the area.

Unemployment

The city's unemployment rate stands at 3.80%, ranking at the 82nd percentile, which signifies a tight labor market with limited slack. For businesses, this means that hiring may be more challenging, and there may be upward pressure on wages to attract and retain top talent. However, it also suggests a skilled and engaged workforce.

Wage Growth

St. Louis has experienced a year-over-year wage growth rate of +3.51%, placing it near the median at the 48th percentile. This moderate wage growth rate implies that labor costs for employers are increasing, but at a manageable pace, while also providing workers with a degree of purchasing power. This balance can support a stable and productive workforce.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of \$164/sqft to \$38.11/hr, and a year-over-year decrease of 1.2% in PSF, St. Louis ranks at the 96th percentile in terms of affordability. This high ranking means that the city is more affordable than most of its peers, making it an attractive location for talent without the need for significant wage premiums. This can be a major advantage for businesses looking to attract and retain employees.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in St. Louis has grown by +0.54% year-over-year, indicating an expanding workforce supply. This positive growth rate suggests that the city has a structural advantage in terms of hiring capacity, as the pool of potential employees is increasing. This can be beneficial for businesses looking to scale their operations.

Building Permits

The city has seen an +18.07% year-over-year increase in residential building permits, signaling an expansion in future housing supply. This growth in permits is a positive indicator for future affordability and workforce accommodation, suggesting that the city is likely to remain an attractive and accessible location for workers.

Days on Market

Homes in St. Louis currently sit on the market for a median of 45 days, with no year-over-year change. This relatively fast pace suggests a competitive market, which may pose challenges for relocating workers. However, the stability in days on market also indicates a balanced housing market, which can support a stable and predictable environment for businesses and residents alike.

Office Economy

St. Louis has a professional and office worker share ranked at the 54th percentile, indicating a moderately deep talent pool in these sectors. This makes the city suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, although it may not be as competitive as cities with a more specialized or dominant knowledge economy.

In conclusion, St. Louis offers businesses a unique combination of strong labor demand, affordable cost of living, and a growing workforce, making it an attractive location for investment and expansion. However, the city's tight labor market and moderate wage growth rate also pose challenges for hiring and labor costs, which decision-makers should carefully consider when evaluating St. Louis as a potential business location.

Kansas City

Kansas City

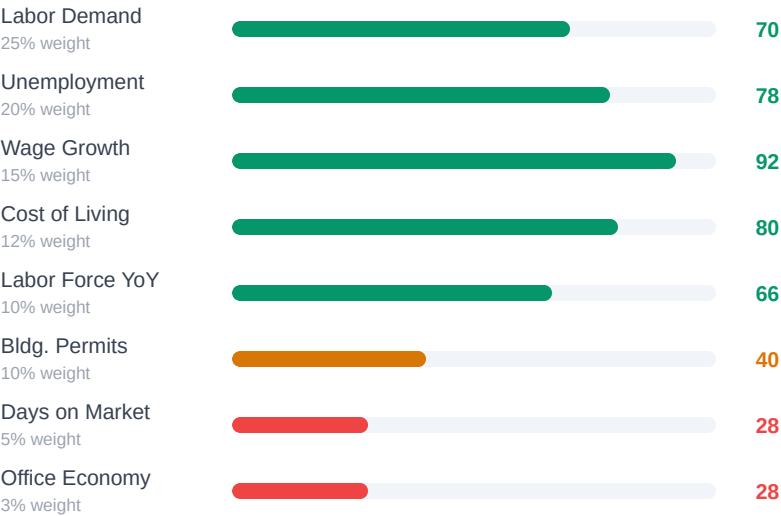
A+

EXCELLENT

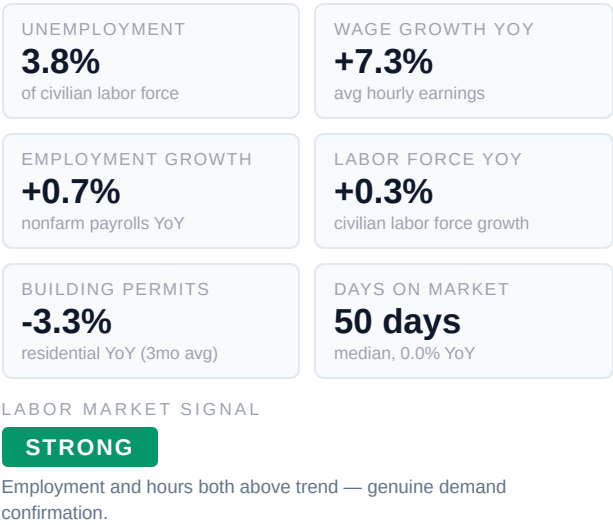
69.3th percentile

Rank 4 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Kansas City earns an overall grade of A+ with a composite score ranking at the 69.3th percentile among 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its strong labor demand, with a composite score of 5.99, and its top-tier wage growth of 7.35% year-over-year. These metrics signal a city with a robust job market and rising earnings.

Labor Demand

Kansas City's employment growth rate is 0.73% year-over-year, combined with a 0.665% deviation in weekly hours above its own trend. This combination signals genuine demand expansion, as hours are running above trend during a period of job growth. This indicates that the city's labor market is experiencing a real increase in demand for workers.

Unemployment

The city's unemployment rate is 3.80%, ranking at the 78th percentile, which means the market is relatively tight. This tightness implies that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as well as upward pressure on wages. However, it also suggests a skilled and engaged workforce.

Wage Growth

Wage growth in Kansas City is 7.35% year-over-year, placing it in the top tier at the 92nd percentile. This fast wage growth means that employer labor costs are rising, but it also translates to increased purchasing power for workers. This can be beneficial for businesses looking to attract and retain top talent.

Cost of Living

Kansas City has a cost of living score that ranks at the 80th percentile, with a price-to-salary ratio of \$196/sqft to \$36.37/hr, or 5.39. This means the city is relatively affordable compared to its peers. The affordability of Kansas City gives businesses a talent attraction advantage, as they may not need to offer wage premiums to compensate for a high cost of living.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Kansas City is growing at a rate of 0.34% year-over-year, which indicates that the workforce supply is slowly expanding. This expansion suggests that businesses will have a slightly easier time finding new hires, as the labor pool is growing, albeit slowly.

Building Permits

The city has seen a year-over-year decrease in building permits of 3.34%, ranking near the median at the 40th percentile. This decrease in permits suggests that the housing supply may be tightening, which could lead to future affordability issues and challenges in

accommodating a growing workforce.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Kansas City is 50 days, with no year-over-year change. This relatively fast market means that relocating workers may face competition when looking for housing, making it potentially tougher for businesses to attract talent from other areas.

Office Economy

Kansas City's professional and office worker share ranks at the 28th percentile, indicating a less deep talent pool in these sectors compared to other cities. This makes Kansas City less suited for businesses requiring a large number of specialized office or tech workers, but it may still be attractive for other types of industries.

In conclusion, Kansas City offers businesses a strong labor market with genuine demand expansion and top-tier wage growth, making it an attractive location for companies looking to tap into a skilled and engaged workforce. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the potential tightening of the housing supply due to decreasing building permits, which could impact future affordability and workforce accommodation.

Cincinnati

Cincinnati

A+

EXCELLENT

68.4th percentile

Rank 5 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand		32
25% weight		
Unemployment		94
20% weight		
Wage Growth		98
15% weight		
Cost of Living		90
12% weight		
Labor Force YoY		54
10% weight		
Bldg. Permits		46
10% weight		
Days on Market		98
5% weight		
Office Economy		42
3% weight		

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT 3.7% of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY +8.1% avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH +0.3% nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY -0.2% civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS -1.8% residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET 42 days median, +13.5% YoY
LABOR MARKET SIGNAL STRONG Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.	

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Cincinnati earns an overall grade of A+ with a composite score of 68.4th percentile, ranking it among the top US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its exceptionally low unemployment rate of 3.70% and high wage growth of 8.11% year-over-year. These metrics signal a highly competitive labor market with strong demand for workers.

Labor Demand

Cincinnati's employment growth rate is 0.31% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating by 0.00% from its own 12-month baseline, resulting in a labor demand composite score of 4.73. This combination signals a modest expansion of genuine demand, as hours are not significantly above trend despite job growth. However, the low labor demand score suggests that the city's job market is not as robust as its low unemployment rate might suggest.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Cincinnati is 3.70%, placing it in the top tier at the 94th percentile. This indicates a very tight labor market with little slack, making it challenging for businesses to hire new workers. As a result, companies may face upward pressure on wages to attract and retain talent.

Wage Growth

Wage growth in Cincinnati is 8.11% year-over-year, ranking it in the top tier at the 98th percentile. This rapid wage growth implies rising labor costs for employers, but it also translates to increased purchasing power for workers. Businesses should factor in higher labor costs when considering Cincinnati as a location.

Cost of Living

Cincinnati's cost of living is relatively affordable, with a PSF of \$191/sqft and a ratio of 5.26 to hourly earnings of \$36.31. The city's cost of living score is in the top tier at the 90th percentile, indicating that it is more affordable than most peer cities. This affordability advantage can help attract talent without requiring wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Cincinnati is shrinking at a rate of -0.21% year-over-year, placing it near the median at the 54th percentile. This contraction in labor supply may pose a structural headwind for hiring, as the pool of available workers is decreasing.

Building Permits

Residential building permits in Cincinnati are declining at a rate of -1.83% year-over-year, ranking it near the median at the 46th percentile. This decrease in permits suggests that housing supply is tightening, which may lead to future affordability challenges and constraints on

workforce accommodation.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Cincinnati is 42 days, with a year-over-year increase of 13.5%. This places the city in the top tier at the 98th percentile, indicating a slower market. For workers relocating to Cincinnati, this means that the housing market is more accessible, with fewer bidding wars and less pressure to act quickly.

Office Economy

Cincinnati's professional and office worker share is 2.30, ranking it near the median at the 42nd percentile. This suggests that the city has a moderate-sized talent pool, making it suitable for businesses that require a mix of professional and non-professional workers. However, it may not be the best fit for companies that rely heavily on specialized office or tech talent.

In conclusion, Cincinnati offers businesses a unique combination of low unemployment, high wage growth, and affordability, making it an attractive location for talent attraction and retention. However, the city's shrinking labor force and tightening housing supply pose significant risks that decision-makers should carefully consider when evaluating Cincinnati as a potential business location.

Hartford

Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford

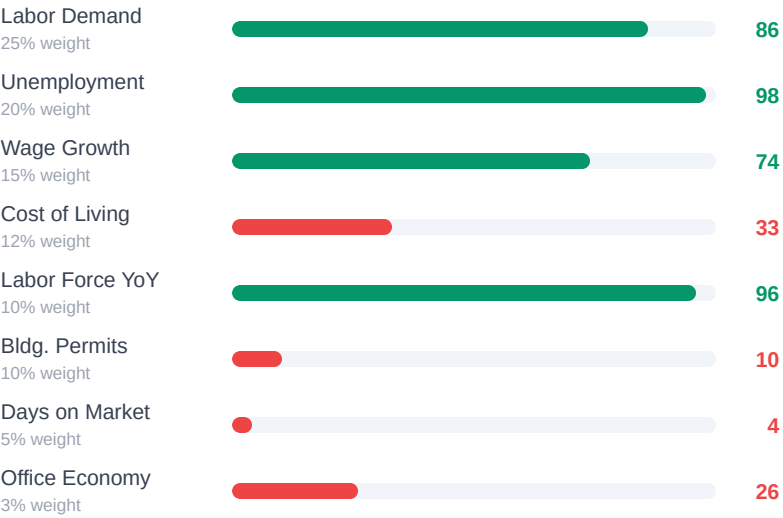
A

VERY GOOD

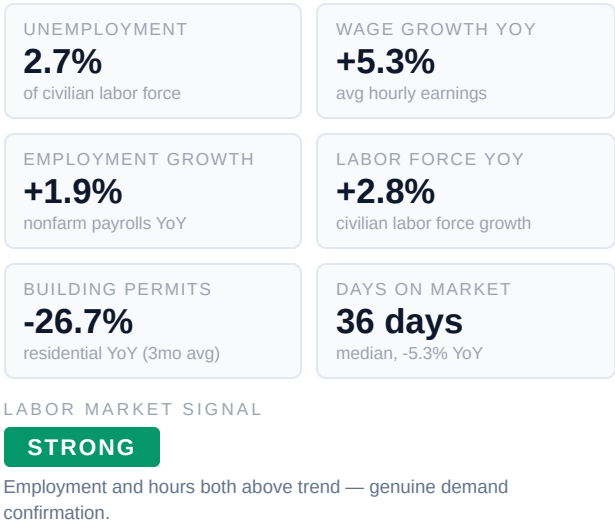
67.7th percentile

Rank 6 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford metro area has earned an overall grade of A, ranking in the 67.7th percentile among 50 US metros, with a strong labor demand and low unemployment rate being the two metrics that most define its current economic character, at 86th and 98th percentiles, respectively. The labor demand composite score of 6.96, driven by a +1.88% employment growth rate and +0.025% weekly hours deviation from trend, signals a genuine demand expansion. This combination of metrics suggests a city with a robust job market.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate of +1.88% and weekly hours deviation of +0.025% from trend indicate a strong labor market with genuine demand expansion. This combination signals that the city is adding jobs and workers are putting in more hours, suggesting a healthy and growing economy. The labor demand composite score of 6.96, at the 86th percentile, further reinforces this assessment.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate of 2.70% is extremely low, ranking in the 98th percentile, indicating a very tight labor market. This means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the pool of available workers is limited, and may need to offer competitive wages to attract talent. The low unemployment rate also suggests that workers have strong bargaining power.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate of +5.30% is above average, ranking in the 74th percentile, indicating moderate to fast wage growth. This suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but workers are also experiencing increased purchasing power. As a result, businesses may need to factor in higher labor costs, but can also benefit from a more affluent local consumer base.

Cost of Living

The cost of living in Hartford, with a PSF of \$251/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$40.19/hr, resulting in a ratio of 6.25, ranks in the 33rd percentile, indicating that the city is relatively expensive. However, the fact that the PSF is increasing by 3.3% YoY suggests that affordability may continue to decline. This could make it challenging for businesses to attract talent without offering wage premiums to offset the high cost of living.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force is growing at a rate of +2.77% year-over-year, ranking in the 96th percentile, indicating a rapidly expanding workforce supply. This suggests that businesses will have access to a growing pool of potential workers, making it easier to hire and staff their operations. The strong labor force growth also bodes well for the city's long-term economic prospects.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in building permits is -26.73%, ranking in the 10th percentile, indicating a sharp decline in housing supply. This suggests that the city may face a tightening housing market, which could lead to increased competition for housing and higher costs for workers. As a result, businesses may need to consider the potential impact on their employees' affordability and quality of life.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 36 days, with a year-over-year decline of -5.3%, ranking in the 4th percentile, indicating a very competitive housing market. This suggests that workers relocating to the city may face challenges in finding and securing housing, as homes are selling quickly. The fast-paced market may require businesses to provide relocation assistance or other incentives to attract talent.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers in the city is 1.90, ranking in the 26th percentile, indicating a relatively shallow talent pool in these sectors. This suggests that the city may be better suited for businesses in industries such as manufacturing or logistics, rather than tech, finance, or consulting. However, the city's strong labor force growth and low unemployment rate may still make it an attractive location for businesses looking to establish a presence in the region.

The Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford metro area offers businesses a strong labor market, low unemployment, and a growing workforce, making it an attractive location for companies looking to expand or establish a presence in the region. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's relatively expensive cost of living and tightening housing market, which may require businesses to offer wage premiums or relocation assistance to attract and retain talent.

Austin

Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos

A

VERY GOOD

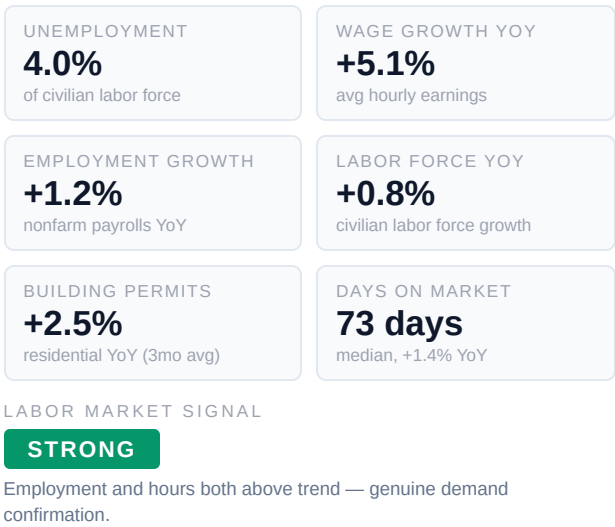
67.0th percentile

Rank 7 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos metro area has earned an overall grade of A, ranking in the 67.0th percentile among 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its strong labor demand and highly affordable cost of living, as evidenced by a top-tier percentile rank of 94th in the latter metric, with a PSF to wages ratio of 6.09 (\$231/sqft vs \$37.93/hr). The city's labor demand composite score of 6.59 and cost of living score are the two metrics that most define its current economic character. With these numbers, Austin presents a unique blend of job market vitality and affordability.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Austin is +1.16% year-over-year, combined with a +0.667% deviation in weekly hours from its own 12-month baseline, signaling genuine demand expansion as hours are running above trend during a period of job growth. This combination indicates a strong and growing job market where businesses are not only adding jobs but also requiring more work hours from their existing employees. The top-tier percentile rank of 80th for labor demand reinforces this interpretation.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Austin stands at 4.00%, placing it near the median in terms of labor market tightness, with a percentile rank of 44th. This rate suggests that while the market is not overly tight, it is also not excessively slack, implying a moderate level of competition for talent. For businesses trying to hire, this means they may face some competition, but it's still feasible to find qualified candidates without extreme wage pressure.

Wage Growth

Austin experiences a year-over-year wage growth of +5.08%, which is above average, ranking in the 70th percentile. This level of wage growth indicates that labor costs for employers are rising, but it also means that workers have increasing purchasing power. The implication is a dynamic labor market where businesses must balance the cost of attracting and retaining talent with the benefits of a growing, high-demand economy.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living percentile rank of 94th, Austin is highly affordable relative to its peers, especially considering the PSF is \$231/sqft and has been falling by -8.0% year-over-year, compared to hourly earnings of \$37.93. This affordability is a significant talent attraction advantage, as businesses can recruit without needing to offer substantial wage premiums to offset high living costs.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Austin is growing at a rate of +0.80% year-over-year, indicating an expanding workforce supply. This growth is above average, ranking in the 78th percentile, which is a positive sign for businesses looking to hire, as it suggests a structural advantage in terms of hiring capacity and access to a growing pool of potential employees.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits is +2.50%, which, while only near the median, suggests that housing supply is slowly expanding. This expansion is a positive signal for future affordability and the ability of the workforce to find accommodation, though the moderate pace may not entirely keep up with demand, potentially leading to some affordability challenges.

Days on Market

Homes in Austin are currently sitting on the market for a median of 73 days, with a year-over-year increase of +1.4%. This situation indicates a slightly slower market, which can be beneficial for relocating workers, making it more accessible for them to find housing. However, the bottom-tier percentile rank of 16th for days on market suggests that, relative to other cities, Austin's housing market is still relatively competitive.

Office Economy

Austin boasts a deep professional talent pool, with an office/professional worker share composite score ranking in the top tier at the 94th percentile. This makes the city highly suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors that rely on specialized knowledge-economy talent. Conversely, it may be less ideal for industries dominated by industrial or logistics roles.

The bottom line for businesses considering Austin is that the city offers a compelling combination of strong labor demand, affordable cost of living, and a deep talent pool in professional sectors. However, the single biggest risk or constraint to factor in is the potential for housing affordability challenges if the supply of residential units does not keep pace with demand, which could impact the ability to attract and retain talent over the long term.

Charlotte

Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia

A

VERY GOOD

66.9th percentile

Rank 8 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand 25% weight		96
Unemployment 20% weight		80
Wage Growth 15% weight		62
Cost of Living 12% weight		74
Labor Force YoY 10% weight		40
Bldg. Permits 10% weight		12
Days on Market 5% weight		20
Office Economy 3% weight		86

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT 3.7% of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY +4.2% avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH +1.5% nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY -0.7% civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS -22.8% residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET 61 days median, +7.0% YoY
LABOR MARKET SIGNAL STRONG Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.	

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia metro area has earned an overall grade of A, ranking in the 66.9th percentile among 50 US metros. This city's economic character is largely defined by its strong labor demand, with a composite score of 7.82, and its low unemployment rate of 3.70%. The combination of a 1.54% employment growth rate and a 1.361% deviation in weekly hours above trend suggests a genuine demand expansion.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate of 1.54% and weekly hours deviation of 1.361% above trend indicate a strong labor market with genuine demand expansion. This combination signals that the city is experiencing an increase in jobs and hours worked, suggesting a healthy and growing economy. The labor demand composite score of 7.82, ranking in the top tier at the 96th percentile, further reinforces this assessment.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate of 3.70% is relatively low, ranking in the top tier at the 80th percentile, indicating a tight labor market with limited slack. This means that businesses may face challenges in finding available workers, and may need to offer competitive wages to attract talent. As a result, hiring in this city may be more difficult and expensive.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate of 4.22% is above average, ranking in the 62nd percentile, indicating moderate to fast wage growth. This suggests that labor costs for employers may be rising, but workers will also have increased purchasing power. As a result, businesses may need to budget for higher labor costs, but can also expect a more affluent local consumer base.

Cost of Living

The cost of living in Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia is relatively affordable, with a percentile rank of 74th, indicating a lower cost of living compared to peer cities. The PSF to earnings ratio of \$218/sqft to \$38.91/hr, with a -0.9% year-over-year change in PSF, suggests that the city is becoming more affordable. This makes it an attractive location for talent, as workers can maintain a high standard of living without requiring excessive wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force is contracting at a rate of -0.70% year-over-year, ranking near the median at the 40th percentile, indicating a shrinking labor pool. This suggests that the supply of workers is decreasing, which may pose a structural headwind for hiring and business expansion. As a result, businesses may need to invest in training and development programs to attract and retain talent.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in building permits is -22.75%, ranking in the bottom tier at the 12th percentile, indicating a sharp decline in housing supply. This suggests that the city may be experiencing a supply squeeze, which could lead to decreased affordability and increased competition for housing. As a result, businesses may need to consider the potential impact on workforce accommodation and relocation.

Days on Market

The median days on market is 61 days, with a year-over-year increase of 7.0%, ranking below average at the 20th percentile. This suggests that the housing market is becoming less competitive, with homes taking longer to sell. However, this may still pose challenges for relocating workers, as the market is not particularly accessible or fast-moving.

Office Economy

The city has a deep professional talent pool, with an office/professional worker share of 3.66, ranking in the top tier at the 86th percentile. This makes it an attractive location for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, which require a high concentration of specialized knowledge workers. However, it may be less suited for industries with more industrial or logistics-oriented workforces.

The Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia metro area offers businesses a strong labor market with genuine demand expansion, a relatively affordable cost of living, and a deep professional talent pool. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the sharp decline in building permits, which may lead to a supply squeeze and decreased affordability, posing challenges for workforce accommodation and relocation. Overall, businesses must carefully weigh these factors when considering a location decision in this city.

Las Vegas

Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas

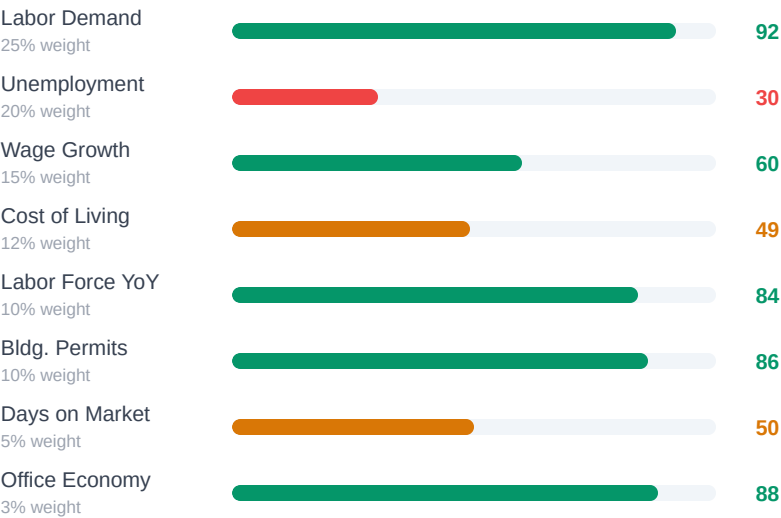
A

VERY GOOD

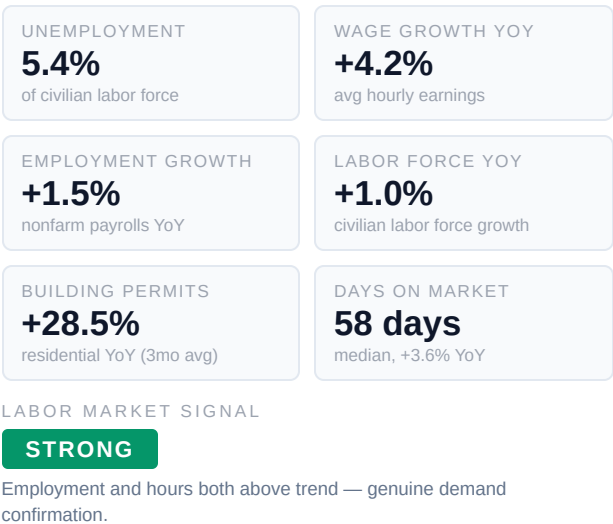
66.0th percentile

Rank 9 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas metro area has earned an overall grade of A, ranking in the 66.0th percentile among 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its strong labor demand and office economy. The city's labor demand composite score of 7.44, combining a 1.46% employment growth rate and a 1.098% weekly hours deviation above trend, signals a genuine demand expansion. This, coupled with its top-tier office economy, defines the city's current economic character.

Labor Demand

The Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas metro area is experiencing a labor demand expansion, with a 1.46% employment growth rate and weekly hours 1.098% above its own 12-month trend. This combination signals genuine demand, as hours are increasing during a period of job growth, indicating that businesses are hiring and workers are putting in more hours to meet demand. The labor demand composite score of 7.44 is in the top tier, at the 92nd percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas is 5.40%, which is below average, ranking in the 30th percentile. This indicates a relatively tight labor market, making it harder for businesses to hire, with potential upward pressure on wages. However, it also suggests that the local consumer demand is weaker compared to areas with lower unemployment rates.

Wage Growth

Wage growth in the area is above average, with a year-over-year increase of 4.21% in hourly earnings, ranking in the 60th percentile. This moderate to fast wage growth rate implies rising labor costs for employers but also stronger purchasing power for workers. As wages continue to rise, businesses may face increasing costs, but the local workforce will have more disposable income to spend.

Cost of Living

The cost of living in Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas, with a PSF of \$261/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$33.35/hr, results in a ratio of 7.83, ranking near the median at the 49th percentile. This suggests that the city is neither particularly affordable nor expensive compared to its peers. The slight decrease in PSF of -1.9% YoY is a positive sign for affordability, but overall, the city does not stand out as a talent attraction hub without wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in the Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas metro area is growing at a rate of 0.98% year-over-year, which is in the top tier, ranking in the 84th percentile. This indicates that the workforce supply is expanding, providing a positive environment for hiring, as there are more potential workers available.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in the area has increased by 28.53% year-over-year, ranking in the top tier at the 86th percentile. This significant increase signals that housing supply is expanding, which should improve affordability and accommodate a growing workforce, making it easier for businesses to attract and retain talent.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas is 58 days, with a year-over-year increase of 3.6%, ranking near the median at the 50th percentile. This suggests a relatively balanced market, neither too competitive nor too accessible for relocating workers, indicating a healthy normalization in the housing market.

Office Economy

The share of jobs in professional and office sectors in the Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas metro area is deep, ranking in the 88th percentile. This makes the city well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, offering a rich talent pool. However, it may be less ideal for industries that are more industrial or logistics-dominant.

The Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas metro area offers businesses a strong labor market with genuine demand expansion and a deep professional talent pool, making it an attractive location for certain industries. However, the relatively tight labor market and above-average wage growth rate pose a risk of increasing labor costs, which decision-makers should carefully consider when evaluating this location for their business operations.

Philadelphia

Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington

A

VERY GOOD

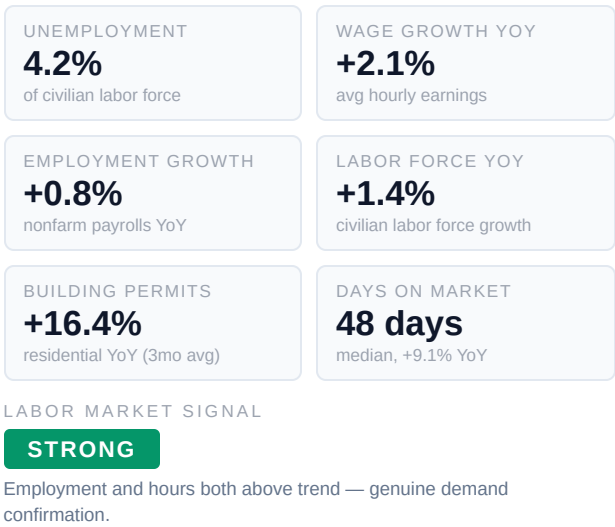
65.2th percentile

Rank 10 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington metro area has earned an overall grade of A, ranking in the 65.2th percentile among 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its strong labor demand and labor force growth, which stand at 84th and 88th percentiles, respectively. The city's employment growth rate of 0.83% and weekly hours deviation of 1.300% above its own trend are key indicators of its economic character. With these metrics, Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington presents a compelling case for businesses looking to expand or relocate.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate of 0.83% combined with weekly hours 1.300% above the city's own trend signals genuine demand expansion, indicating that jobs are being added and hours are increasing, suggesting a healthy and growing economy. This combination is a strong indicator of labor market strength, pointing to increased economic activity. The labor demand composite score of 6.76 further reinforces this, placing the city in the top tier.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate of 4.20% positions the city above average in terms of labor market tightness, ranking in the 72nd percentile. This rate suggests that while there is some slack in the market, it is not overly abundant, which can imply moderate competition for talent. For a business trying to hire in this market, the relatively low unemployment rate may lead to slightly more wage pressure and competition for skilled workers.

Wage Growth

With a year-over-year wage growth rate of 2.14%, Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington experiences below-average wage increases, ranking in the 26th percentile. This moderate wage growth environment suggests that labor costs for employers are not escalating rapidly, but it also indicates that worker purchasing power may not be increasing as quickly as in other metros. This can be seen as a relatively stable cost environment for businesses.

Cost of Living

The cost of living in Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington, with a PSF of \$228/sqft and a ratio of 7.00 when compared to hourly earnings of \$32.59, ranks below average in terms of affordability, at the 39th percentile. The fact that PSF is decreasing by 0.9% year-over-year is a positive sign for affordability. However, the current ranking suggests that the city may not offer a significant talent attraction advantage without wage premiums, as it is not particularly more affordable than its peer cities.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force is growing at a rate of 1.42% year-over-year, indicating an expanding workforce supply. This positive growth rate suggests that the city has a structural advantage in terms of hiring capacity, as more workers are available to fill positions. This is a favorable condition for businesses looking to grow their operations.

Building Permits

Residential building permits are increasing by 16.37% year-over-year, signaling an expansion in future housing supply. This growth in permits is a positive indicator for future affordability and workforce accommodation, suggesting that the city is likely to become more attractive to relocating workers and businesses over time.

Days on Market

Homes are currently sitting on the market for a median of 48 days, with a year-over-year increase of 9.1%, placing the city in the top tier for days on market. This suggests a slower, more buyer-friendly market, which can be beneficial for workers relocating to the city, as they have more time to find suitable housing without facing extreme competition.

Office Economy

With an office and professional worker share composite score of 2.86, ranking in the 60th percentile, Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington has a deep enough talent pool to support businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors. However, it may be less suited for industries that are heavily industrial or logistics-dominant, given its stronger orientation towards knowledge-economy roles.

The Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington metro area offers businesses a strong labor market with genuine demand expansion and a growing labor force, making it an attractive location for expansion or relocation. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers to factor in is the moderate to low wage growth, which, while keeping labor costs stable, may also limit the increase in worker purchasing power and potentially impact the attractiveness of the city to top talent without additional compensation incentives.

Dallas

Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington

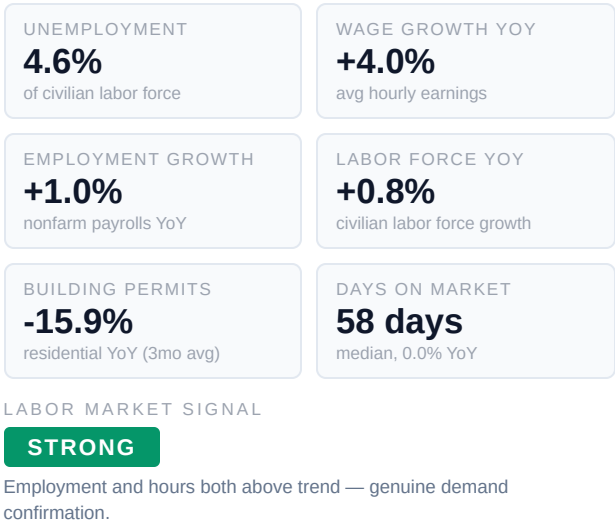
B+

ABOVE AVERAGE
58.3th percentile
Rank 11 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington metro area has an overall grade of B+ with a composite score ranking at the 58.3th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its strong labor demand, with a composite score in the top tier at the 82nd percentile, and its highly affordable cost of living, ranked at the 86th percentile. The labor demand is driven by a 1.00% year-over-year employment growth rate and a 0.903% deviation in weekly hours above its own trend.

Labor Demand

The combination of a 1.00% employment growth rate and a 0.903% increase in weekly hours above trend signals genuine demand expansion in the Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington metro area. This indicates that not only are jobs being added, but existing workers are also seeing their hours increase, suggesting a strong and growing economy. The labor demand composite score of 6.60 further reinforces this positive outlook.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington is 4.60%, which ranks at the 28th percentile, indicating a below-average performance in terms of labor market tightness. This means the market has some slack, making it somewhat easier for businesses to hire compared to tighter labor markets. However, this also implies weaker local consumer demand due to the relatively higher unemployment rate.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington is 4.03%, ranking near the median at the 54th percentile. This moderate wage growth suggests that labor costs for employers are increasing, but at a pace that is neither excessively high nor stagnant. For workers, this translates into improving purchasing power, which can contribute to local economic vitality.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living percentile rank of 86th, Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington is more affordable relative to its peers, especially considering the PSF (price per square foot) of \$199/sqft is decreasing by 2.0% year-over-year compared to hourly earnings of \$38.10/hr, resulting in a ratio of 5.22. This affordability advantage is a significant talent attraction factor, as businesses can offer competitive wages without needing large premiums to offset high living costs.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington is growing at a rate of 0.79% year-over-year, which ranks above average at the 76th percentile. This expansion in labor force supply is a positive sign for businesses looking to hire, as it indicates a growing pool of potential

workers. This can mitigate some of the pressures associated with a tightening labor market.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits is -15.89%, ranking below average at the 20th percentile. This decline suggests that housing supply is not expanding as quickly as demand, potentially leading to future affordability issues and constraints on workforce accommodation. This could become a significant challenge for attracting and retaining talent in the area.

Days on Market

The current median days on market for homes in Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington is 58 days, with a year-over-year change of 0.0%, ranking at the 28th percentile. This indicates a relatively fast-paced market that may be challenging for relocating workers, as homes are selling quickly. However, the stable year-over-year change suggests a market that is not rapidly becoming more competitive.

Office Economy

With an office/professional worker share composite score ranking at the 94th percentile, Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington has a deep and talented pool of professional workers, making it highly suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors. This city's economy is less suited for industries that are more industrial or logistics-dominant, given its strong orientation towards knowledge-economy jobs.

The Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington metro area offers businesses a strong labor market with genuine demand expansion and a highly affordable cost of living, making it an attractive location for talent. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the decline in residential building permits, which could lead to future affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce, potentially offsetting some of the city's current economic advantages.

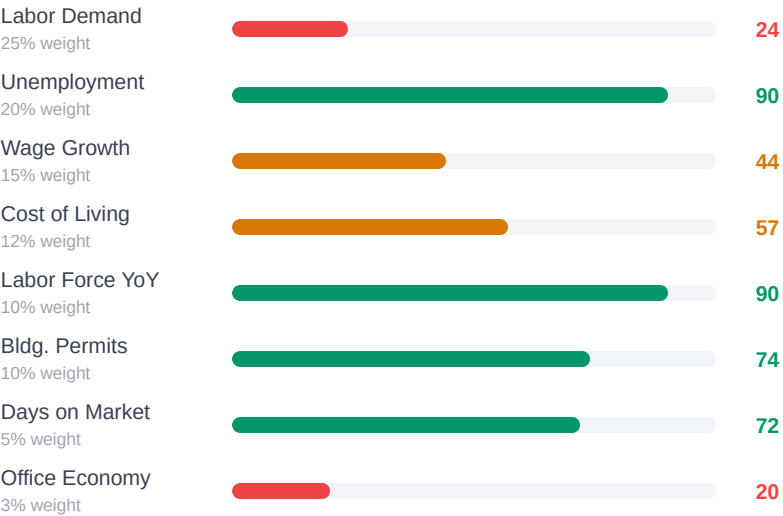
Pittsburgh

Pittsburgh

B+

ABOVE AVERAGE
58.1th percentile
Rank 12 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Pittsburgh earns an overall grade of B+ with a composite score ranking it at the 58.1th percentile among 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its low unemployment rate of 3.70% and its strong labor force growth of 1.61% YoY. These metrics suggest a tight labor market with a growing workforce.

Labor Demand

Pittsburgh's employment growth rate is -0.05% YoY, and weekly hours are deviating 0.173% above its own trend. This combination signals a survivor squeeze, where remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles, rather than genuine demand expansion. The labor demand composite score of 4.06 ranks below average at the 24th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Pittsburgh is 3.70%, ranking at the 90th percentile, indicating a very tight labor market. This means that businesses trying to hire in this city will face significant competition for talent and may need to offer higher wages to attract workers. The low unemployment rate suggests that the market has little slack.

Wage Growth

Wage growth in Pittsburgh is 3.33% YoY, ranking near the median at the 44th percentile. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not excessively, and worker purchasing power is increasing. However, the wage growth is not strong enough to significantly drive up labor costs.

Cost of Living

Pittsburgh has a cost of living score ranking at the 57th percentile, with a PSF of \$172/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$33.44/hr, resulting in a ratio of 5.14. This indicates that the city is relatively affordable compared to its peers. The stable YoY change in PSF (+0.0%) suggests that the city's affordability is not improving or deteriorating significantly. This affordability can be a talent attraction advantage, as workers may not require wage premiums to afford the cost of living.

Labor Force Growth

The labor force in Pittsburgh is growing at a rate of 1.61% YoY, ranking at the 90th percentile. This indicates that the workforce supply is expanding, which is a positive sign for businesses looking to hire in the city. The growing labor force can help alleviate some of the pressure from the tight labor market.

Building Permits

Building permits in Pittsburgh are increasing by 24.71% YoY, ranking above average at the 74th percentile. This suggests that housing supply is expanding, which can improve affordability and accommodate a growing workforce. The increase in building permits is a positive sign for future workforce attraction and retention.

Days on Market

The median days on market in Pittsburgh is 53 days, with a YoY increase of 6.0%, ranking above average at the 72nd percentile. This indicates a relatively slow market, which can be accessible for workers relocating to the city. However, the rising days on market may also suggest a normalization of the market, rather than a significant decrease in demand.

Office Economy

Pittsburgh's office economy ranks below average at the 20th percentile, with a share of professional and office workers at 1.68. This suggests that the city's talent pool is not as deep in professional and office sectors, making it less suited for tech, finance, or consulting businesses. However, the city may be more suitable for industrial or logistics-dominant businesses.

In conclusion, Pittsburgh offers a unique combination of a tight labor market, growing workforce, and relatively affordable cost of living, making it an attractive location for businesses that can adapt to these conditions. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for businesses in Pittsburgh is the tight labor market, which can drive up labor costs and make it challenging to attract and retain talent.

Orlando

Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford

B+

ABOVE AVERAGE
56.6th percentile
Rank 13 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand 25% weight		72
Unemployment 20% weight		12
Wage Growth 15% weight		90
Cost of Living 12% weight		71
Labor Force YoY 10% weight		60
Bldg. Permits 10% weight		22
Days on Market 5% weight		64
Office Economy 3% weight		90

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT of civilian labor force 4.7%	WAGE GROWTH YOY avg hourly earnings +6.1%
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH nonfarm payrolls YoY +0.8%	LABOR FORCE YOY civilian labor force growth +0.2%
BUILDING PERMITS residential YoY (3mo avg) -15.7%	DAYS ON MARKET median, -2.6% YoY 75 days
LABOR MARKET SIGNAL STRONG Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.	

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford metro area has earned an overall grade of B+ with a composite score ranking it at the 56.6th percentile among 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its strong labor demand, with a composite score in the 72nd percentile, and its top-tier wage growth of 6.12% year-over-year. The combination of these metrics suggests a city with a robust job market and increasing labor costs.

Labor Demand

The Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford metro area has seen employment growth of 0.80% year-over-year and weekly hours 0.783% above its own trend, indicating genuine demand expansion. This combination signals that the city is adding jobs and workers are putting in more hours, a positive sign for businesses looking to expand. The labor demand composite score of 6.20 further reinforces this trend, placing it in the 72nd percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford stands at 4.70%, ranking it in the 12th percentile, indicating a relatively loose labor market. This means that businesses may find it easier to hire workers, as there is less competition for talent. However, this also implies weaker local consumer demand compared to tighter labor markets.

Wage Growth

With a year-over-year wage growth rate of 6.12%, Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford is experiencing fast wage growth, ranking it in the 90th percentile. This rapid wage growth will lead to increasing labor costs for employers but also means stronger purchasing power for workers. Businesses should factor in rising labor costs when considering this location.

Cost of Living

Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford has a cost of living score in the 71st percentile, with a price-to-salary ratio of \$223/sqft to \$34.05/hr, or 6.55. The fact that PSF is falling by 2.6% year-over-year is a key driver of its above-average affordability. This makes the city more attractive for talent without requiring significant wage premiums, as the cost of living is relatively manageable compared to peer cities.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford is growing at a rate of 0.22% year-over-year, indicating a slowly expanding workforce supply. While this growth is positive, its modest pace may pose a structural headwind for hiring, especially if businesses are looking to rapidly expand their operations.

Building Permits

The city has seen a year-over-year decline in building permits of 15.65%, ranking it in the 22nd percentile. This decrease suggests that housing supply is tightening, which could lead to future affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce. Businesses should consider the potential long-term implications of a constrained housing market on their ability to attract and retain talent.

Days on Market

Homes in Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford are currently sitting on the market for 75 days, with a year-over-year decrease of 2.6%. This relatively fast pace of home sales, ranking in the 64th percentile, indicates a competitive market that may be challenging for relocating workers to find housing quickly. However, this also suggests a vibrant and dynamic local economy.

Office Economy

With an office and professional worker share composite score of 3.96, ranking it in the 90th percentile, Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford has a deep talent pool suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors. This city is less suited for industries dominated by industrial or logistics roles, making it an attractive location for knowledge-economy businesses.

In conclusion, Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford offers businesses a strong labor market with genuine demand expansion and top-tier wage growth, indicating a robust local economy. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the tightening housing supply, signaled by the sharp decline in building permits, which could lead to future affordability issues and challenges in attracting and retaining talent.

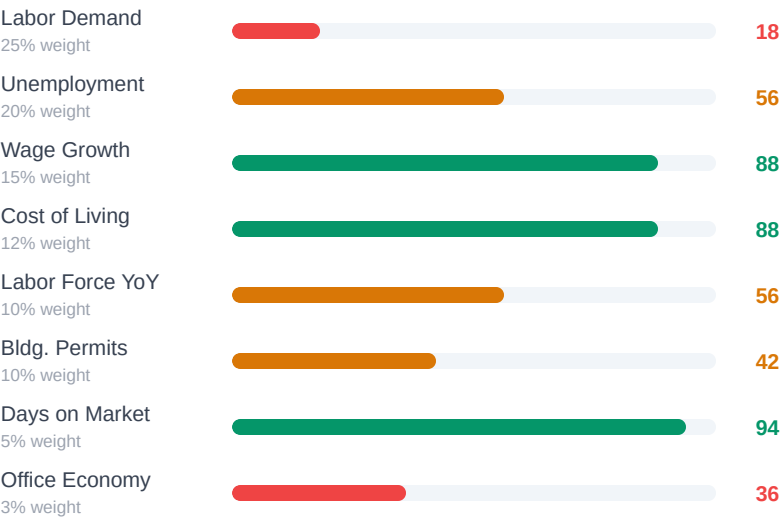
Baltimore

Baltimore-Columbia-Towson

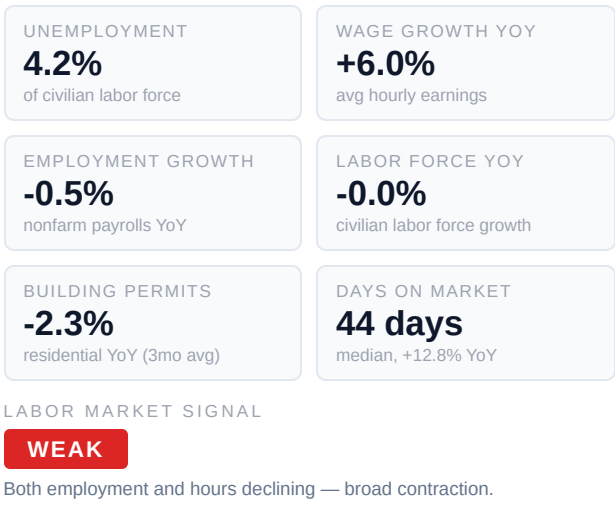
B+

ABOVE AVERAGE
55.0th percentile
Rank 14 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Baltimore-Columbia-Towson metro area has an overall grade of B+ with a composite score ranking at the 55.0th percentile among 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its strong wage growth of 5.99% year-over-year and its affordable cost of living, with a PSF to wages ratio of 5.64, ranking in the top tier at the 88th percentile. The combination of these metrics suggests a city with a competitive labor market.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Baltimore-Columbia-Towson is -0.47% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating -0.175% from the city's own 12-month baseline, indicating a contraction in labor demand. This combination signals a scenario where payrolls are contracting, and hours are below trend, suggesting a lack of genuine demand expansion. The labor demand composite score of 3.64 ranks in the bottom tier at the 18th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Baltimore-Columbia-Towson is 4.20%, ranking near the median at the 56th percentile. This rate suggests a labor market with some slack, making it relatively easier for businesses to hire compared to tighter markets. However, the practical implication for a business trying to hire here is that while it may be easier to find candidates, the local consumer demand may be weaker due to the relatively higher unemployment rate.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Baltimore-Columbia-Towson is 5.99%, ranking in the top tier at the 88th percentile. This fast wage growth rate implies rising labor costs for employers but also indicates strong worker purchasing power. Businesses should factor in the potential for increasing labor costs when considering this location.

Cost of Living

Baltimore-Columbia-Towson has a cost of living percentile rank of 88th, indicating that it is more affordable relative to its peers. The PSF to wages ratio is 5.64, with PSF at \$214/sqft and wages at \$37.96/hr, and PSF is falling by -3.2% year-over-year. This affordability advantage means that businesses can attract talent without needing to offer significant wage premiums to compensate for a high cost of living.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Baltimore-Columbia-Towson is growing at a rate of -0.04% year-over-year, ranking near the median at the 56th percentile. This slight contraction in labor force supply implies a potential structural headwind for hiring, as the workforce pool is not expanding significantly.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits in Baltimore-Columbia-Towson is -2.34%, ranking near the median at the 42nd percentile. This decline suggests that housing supply is not expanding as quickly as in other areas, which could lead to future affordability challenges and constraints on workforce accommodation.

Days on Market

The current median days on market for homes in Baltimore-Columbia-Towson is 44 days, with a year-over-year increase of 12.8%, ranking in the top tier at the 94th percentile. This slower market means that workers relocating to this city may find it more accessible to purchase or rent a home, as properties are not selling as quickly as in hotter markets.

Office Economy

The share of jobs in professional and office sectors in Baltimore-Columbia-Towson ranks below average at the 36th percentile. This suggests that the city has a less deep talent pool for businesses requiring specialized professional or office workers, making it less suited for tech, finance, or consulting headquarters decisions.

The Baltimore-Columbia-Towson metro area offers businesses a unique combination of strong wage growth and an affordable cost of living, making it an attractive location for talent acquisition without significant wage premiums. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's contracting labor demand and slightly shrinking labor force, which could pose challenges for hiring and workforce expansion in the future.

Columbus

Columbus

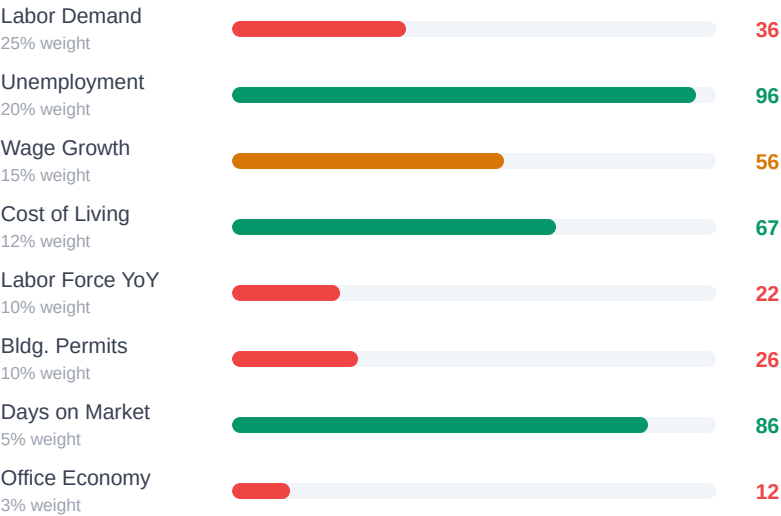
B

AVERAGE

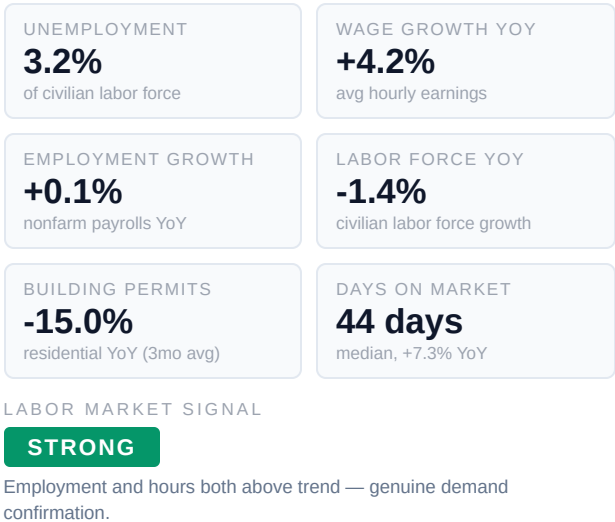
54.1th percentile

Rank 15 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Columbus, with an overall grade of B and a composite score ranking it at the 54.1th percentile among 50 US metros, is characterized by its low unemployment rate of 3.20% and a labor demand composite score of 4.88, which ranks below average at the 36th percentile. The city's economic character is most defined by its tight labor market and moderate wage growth. Specifically, the combination of a +0.06% employment growth rate and +0.492% weekly hours deviation signals a genuine demand expansion, albeit at a slow pace.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Columbus is +0.06% year-over-year, accompanied by a +0.492% deviation in weekly hours from its own 12-month baseline. This combination indicates a genuine demand expansion, as hours are running above trend during a period of job growth, suggesting that the economy is absorbing new workers. However, the pace of this expansion is slow, ranking below average at the 36th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Columbus is 3.20%, ranking at the 96th percentile, which indicates a very tight labor market with little slack. This means that businesses trying to hire in this city will face significant competition for talent, potentially leading to upward pressure on wages. The tight market implies that hiring may be challenging, but it also suggests a skilled and engaged workforce.

Wage Growth

Wage growth in Columbus is +4.15% year-over-year, ranking near the median at the 56th percentile. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not at an alarming pace. For workers, this translates into increased purchasing power, which can be beneficial for local consumer demand.

Cost of Living

Columbus has a cost of living score that ranks at the 67th percentile, with a PSF to earnings ratio of \$205/sqft to \$34.84/hr, or 5.88. This indicates that the city is relatively affordable compared to its peers, especially since the PSF is falling by -0.5% year-over-year. This affordability is a talent attraction advantage, as workers can be drawn to the city without requiring significant wage premiums to offset living costs.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Columbus is shrinking at a rate of -1.35% year-over-year, ranking below average at the 22nd percentile. This contraction in labor force supply poses a structural headwind for hiring, as the pool of available workers is decreasing. Businesses may need to adapt their recruitment strategies or consider upskilling existing employees to mitigate this challenge.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Columbus has decreased by -14.98% year-over-year, ranking below average at the 26th percentile. This sharp decline in permits suggests that housing supply is tightening, which could lead to future affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce. This trend may erode the city's attractiveness for relocating workers and businesses alike.

Days on Market

Homes in Columbus are currently sitting on the market for a median of 44 days, with a year-over-year increase of +7.3%. This ranks at the 86th percentile, indicating a slower market. For workers relocating to this city, the slower pace of home sales could make it easier to find and purchase a home, as the market is less competitive compared to faster-paced markets.

Office Economy

Columbus has a professional and office worker share that ranks at the 12th percentile, with a composite score of 0.82. This indicates a relatively shallow talent pool in professional and office sectors, making the city less suited for businesses in tech, finance, consulting, or HQ operations that require deep knowledge-economy talent. However, it may be more accommodating to industries with different workforce needs, such as logistics or manufacturing.

In conclusion, Columbus offers businesses a unique blend of a tight labor market, moderate wage growth, and relative affordability, which can be attractive for talent retention and recruitment. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the shrinking labor force and tightening housing supply, which could pose significant challenges for future hiring and workforce accommodation, potentially offsetting the city's current advantages.

San Francisco

San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont

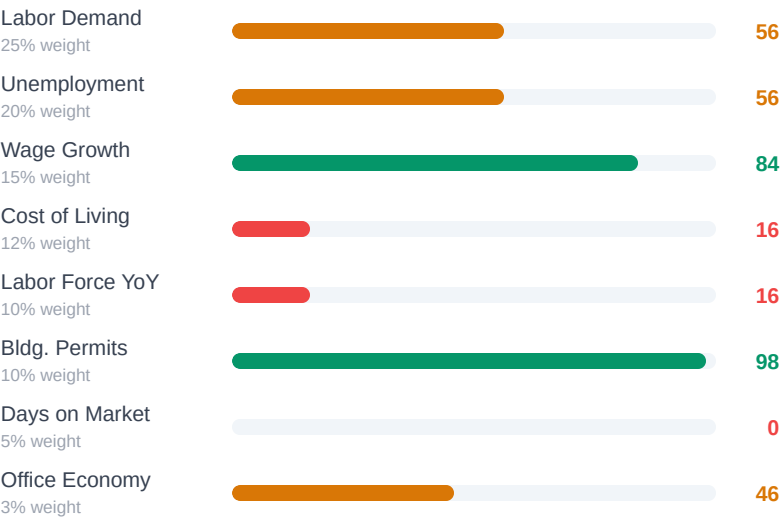
B

AVERAGE

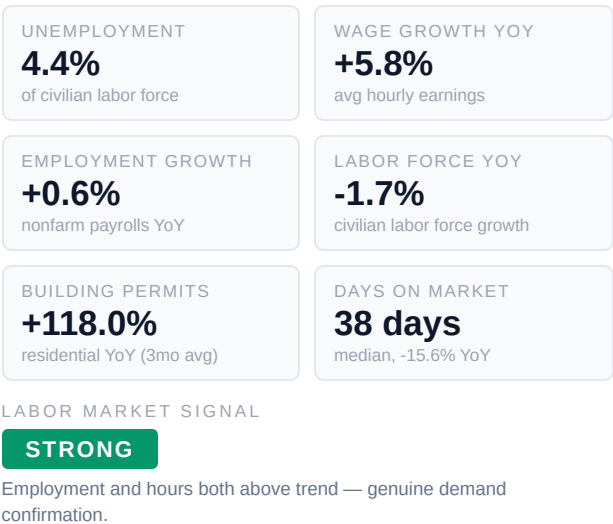
52.5th percentile

Rank 16 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont metro area has an overall grade of B, ranking at the 52.5th percentile among 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its strong wage growth and building permits expansion. The city's economic character is most defined by its top-tier wage growth of 5.78% year-over-year and its significant increase in building permits, up 118.02% year-over-year. These metrics suggest a city with a growing economy but also with specific challenges related to affordability and labor supply.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont is 0.56% year-over-year, combined with a 0.469% deviation in weekly hours above its own trend, indicating a genuine demand expansion. This combination signals that the city is experiencing an increase in jobs and hours worked, suggesting a healthy labor market. However, the near-median percentile rank of 56th suggests that this growth is not exceptionally strong compared to other metros.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont is 4.40%, which is near the median among the 50 US metros, ranking at the 56th percentile. This rate indicates a relatively balanced labor market, neither too tight nor too slack. For a business trying to hire in this city, the moderate unemployment rate suggests that finding talent may not be overly challenging, but it also may not be exceptionally easy, given the city's strong wage growth.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont is 5.78%, ranking at the 84th percentile, indicating fast and strong wage growth. This implies that employer labor costs are rising, but it also means that workers have increasing purchasing power. The high wage growth rate is a double-edged sword, benefiting workers but potentially increasing costs for businesses.

Cost of Living

San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont has a cost of living percentile rank of 16th, making it one of the more expensive cities relative to its peers, with a PSF to earnings ratio of \$619/sqft to \$50.39/hr, or 12.28. Although the PSF is falling by 3.9% year-over-year, the city remains expensive. This means that attracting talent without offering wage premiums could be challenging due to the high cost of living.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont is contracting at a rate of -1.71% year-over-year, ranking at the 16th percentile. This contraction indicates that the labor force supply is shrinking, which could pose a structural headwind for hiring and business expansion in the city. The decreasing labor force suggests that businesses may face challenges in finding the talent they need.

Building Permits

The city has seen a significant increase in residential building permits, up 118.02% year-over-year, ranking at the 98th percentile. This sharp increase signals that housing supply is expected to expand, which could improve affordability and accommodate a growing workforce. The rapid growth in building permits is a positive sign for future workforce attraction and retention.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont is 38 days, with a year-over-year decrease of 15.6%, ranking at the 0th percentile. This indicates a very competitive housing market, where homes sell quickly. For a worker relocating to this city, the fast-paced market could make finding a home challenging and competitive.

Office Economy

San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont has an office economy percentile rank of 46th, indicating a moderately deep professional talent pool. The city is suited for businesses that thrive in a knowledge-economy environment, such as tech, finance, and consulting. However, it may be less ideal for industries that require a large workforce in industrial or logistics sectors.

The San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont metro area offers businesses a strong economy with high wage growth and an expanding housing supply, which could attract a skilled workforce. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for a decision-maker is the city's high cost of living and shrinking labor force, which could make talent attraction and retention challenging without significant wage premiums.

Nashville

Nashville-Davidson--Murfreesboro--Franklin

B

AVERAGE

52.4th percentile

Rank 17 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand 25% weight		46
Unemployment 20% weight		92
Wage Growth 15% weight		52
Cost of Living 12% weight		51
Labor Force YoY 10% weight		30
Bldg. Permits 10% weight		18
Days on Market 5% weight		28
Office Economy 3% weight		78

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT 3.1% of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY +3.9% avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH +0.7% nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY -0.9% civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS -17.8% residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET 60 days median, +1.7% YoY
LABOR MARKET SIGNAL STRONG Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.	

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Nashville-Davidson--Murfreesboro--Franklin has an overall grade of B, ranking 52.4th percentile among 50 US metros, with a composite score reflecting a near median performance across key economic metrics. The city's economic character is most defined by its low unemployment rate of 3.10% and its near median labor demand composite score of 5.26, indicating a balance between job growth and labor utilization. Specifically, the combination of a 92nd percentile unemployment rate and 46th percentile labor demand score suggests a tight labor market with genuine demand expansion.

Labor Demand

The city's employment growth rate is +0.65% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating +0.047% from the 12-month baseline, signaling genuine demand expansion. This combination indicates that jobs are being added and hours are running above trend, suggesting a healthy labor market. The labor demand composite score of 5.26, ranking near the median at 46th percentile, further supports this interpretation.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Nashville-Davidson--Murfreesboro--Franklin is 3.10%, ranking in the top tier at the 92nd percentile, indicating a very tight labor market. This means that there is little slack in the market, making it harder for businesses to hire and potentially leading to upward wage pressure. For a business trying to hire in this city, the low unemployment rate implies a competitive hiring environment.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Nashville-Davidson--Murfreesboro--Franklin is +3.92%, ranking near the median at the 52nd percentile, indicating moderate wage growth. This rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not excessively, and that worker purchasing power is increasing. The moderate wage growth rate implies a relatively stable labor cost environment for businesses.

Cost of Living

Nashville-Davidson--Murfreesboro--Franklin has a cost of living score ranking near the median at the 51st percentile, with a PSF of \$259/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$35.74/hr, resulting in a ratio of 7.25. The city's cost of living is relatively affordable, with the PSF decreasing by -1.1% year-over-year, making it more attractive for talent without requiring significant wage premiums. This affordability advantage can aid in talent attraction for businesses.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Nashville-Davidson--Murfreesboro--Franklin is contracting at a rate of -0.95% year-over-year, ranking below average at the 30th percentile. This decline in labor force supply implies a structural headwind for hiring, as the pool of potential workers is

shrinking. Businesses may face challenges in finding qualified candidates due to the contracting labor force.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits is -17.83%, ranking in the bottom tier at the 18th percentile, indicating a tightening housing supply. This sharp decline in permits suggests that future affordability and workforce accommodation may be at risk, potentially limiting the city's ability to attract and retain workers. The decrease in building permits is a concern for businesses relying on a growing and accessible workforce.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Nashville-Davidson--Murfreesboro--Franklin is 60 days, with a year-over-year increase of +1.7%, ranking below average at the 28th percentile. This indicates a relatively slow market, which can be challenging for relocating workers. However, the rising days on market in a strong job market may also signal a healthy normalization, providing more options for workers.

Office Economy

Nashville-Davidson--Murfreesboro--Franklin has a deep professional talent pool, with an office/professional worker share composite score ranking above average at the 78th percentile. This makes the city well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors that rely on specialized knowledge-economy talent. Conversely, it may be less ideal for industries with more industrial or logistics-dominant economies.

The city of Nashville-Davidson--Murfreesboro--Franklin offers businesses a tight labor market with moderate wage growth and a relatively affordable cost of living, making it attractive for talent acquisition. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the contracting labor force and tightening housing supply, which may limit the city's ability to accommodate a growing workforce and attract new talent, potentially impacting businesses' hiring capacity and future growth.

Atlanta

Atlanta-Sandy Springs-Roswell

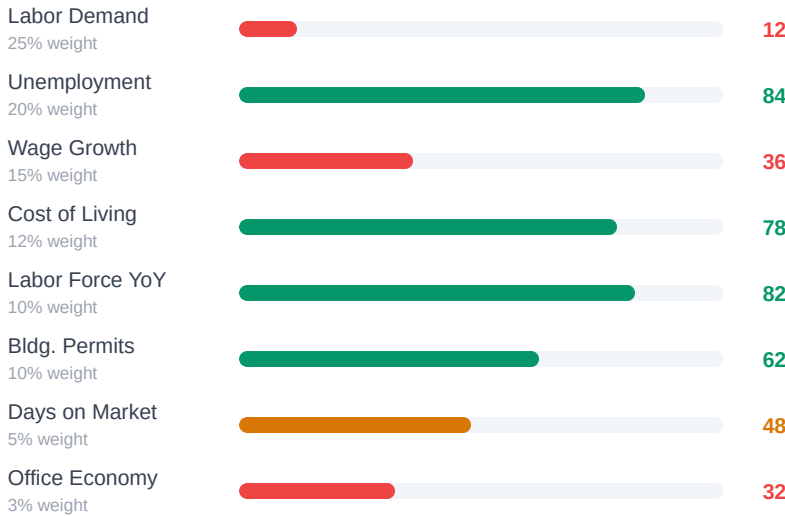
B

AVERAGE

52.3th percentile

Rank 18 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

3.2%

of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+3.1%

avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

-0.5%

nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE YOY

+0.9%

civilian labor force growth

BUILDING PERMITS

+15.2%

residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

59 days

median, +3.5% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

SQUEEZE

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Atlanta-Sandy Springs-Roswell metro area has an overall grade of B, ranking 52.3th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its low unemployment rate of 3.20% and a cost of living score that indicates relative affordability. The city's economic character is defined by these two metrics, which signal a tight labor market with moderate affordability. Specifically, the cost of living index shows a PSF of \$195/sqft, which has decreased by 0.5% YoY, combined with an average hourly wage of \$37.62, resulting in a ratio of 5.18.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Atlanta is -0.46% YoY, while weekly hours are deviating 0.595% above the city's own 12-month baseline, indicating a scenario where hours are increasing despite job losses, which suggests a survivor squeeze. This combination signals that the labor market is not expanding in terms of job numbers, but existing workers are taking on more hours. The labor demand composite score of 3.06 falls into the bottom tier, at the 12th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Atlanta is 3.20%, which places it in the top tier, at the 84th percentile, indicating a very tight labor market. This tight market means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as there are fewer unemployed individuals seeking work, leading to potential wage pressure. The low unemployment rate suggests that businesses may need to offer competitive wages to attract talent.

Wage Growth

Wage growth in Atlanta is +3.11% YoY, which ranks below average, at the 36th percentile. This moderate wage growth rate implies that labor costs for employers are increasing, but at a slower pace than in many other cities. While this may not be ideal for employers, it does mean that workers have somewhat stronger purchasing power, which can be beneficial for local consumer demand.

Cost of Living

Atlanta's cost of living score indicates that it is more affordable than many of its peer cities, with a percentile rank of 78th. The city's PSF of \$195/sqft, which has decreased by 0.5% YoY, combined with average hourly earnings of \$37.62, results in a ratio that suggests the city is relatively affordable. This affordability can be a significant advantage for talent attraction, as businesses may not need to offer wage premiums to compensate for a high cost of living.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Atlanta is growing at a rate of +0.88% YoY, which places it in the top tier, at the 82nd percentile. This positive growth rate indicates that the workforce supply is expanding, which is a favorable condition for businesses looking to hire. An expanding

labor force can reduce the challenges associated with a tight labor market, making it easier for companies to find the talent they need.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Atlanta has increased by +15.21% YoY, ranking above average, at the 62nd percentile. This increase in building permits suggests that housing supply is expanding, which can lead to improved affordability and a more accommodating environment for the workforce. As housing supply grows, it can help mitigate potential workforce attraction and retention issues.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Atlanta is 59 days, with a YoY increase of +3.5%, placing it near the median, at the 48th percentile. This indicates a relatively balanced market, neither extremely fast nor slow. For workers relocating to Atlanta, this means that the housing market is competitive but still accessible, with homes sitting on the market for nearly two months before going under contract.

Office Economy

Atlanta's professional and office worker share is below average, ranking at the 32nd percentile. This suggests that while there is a talent pool, it is not as deep as in other cities, making Atlanta less suited for businesses that require a large number of specialized, knowledge-economy workers, such as tech, finance, or consulting firms. However, it may be more suitable for businesses with less specialized labor needs.

The bottom line for businesses considering Atlanta is that the city offers a relatively affordable cost of living and an expanding labor force, which can be attractive for talent acquisition and retention. However, the single biggest risk or constraint is the tight labor market, with its low unemployment rate and potential for wage pressure, which businesses need to factor into their hiring and compensation strategies to remain competitive in this market.

Cleveland

Cleveland

B

AVERAGE

52.0th percentile

Rank 19 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand 25% weight		48
Unemployment 20% weight		66
Wage Growth 15% weight		10
Cost of Living 12% weight		50
Labor Force YoY 10% weight		94
Bldg. Permits 10% weight		48
Days on Market 5% weight		66
Office Economy 3% weight		60

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT 3.4% of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY +0.9% avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH +0.6% nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY +1.8% civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS -0.6% residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET 55 days median, +7.8% YoY
LABOR MARKET SIGNAL STRONG Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.	

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Cleveland earns an overall grade of B, ranking at the 52.0th percentile among 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its near-median labor demand and above-average unemployment rate, which stand at 5.27 and 3.40%, respectively. The city's economic character is also defined by its strong labor force growth of +1.80% YoY and its stagnant wage growth of +0.88% YoY. These metrics suggest a mixed economic environment with both opportunities and challenges for businesses.

Labor Demand

Cleveland's employment growth rate of +0.57% YoY and weekly hours deviation of +0.170% indicate a near-median labor demand composite score of 5.27, signaling a moderate expansion of genuine demand. This combination suggests that the city is experiencing a gradual increase in job creation and working hours, which is a positive sign for businesses looking to expand or relocate. However, the near-median score also implies that the demand is not exceptionally strong.

Unemployment

The city's unemployment rate of 3.40% ranks at the 66th percentile, indicating a relatively tight labor market with some slack. This means that businesses may face moderate competition for talent, and hiring could be somewhat challenging, but not extremely difficult. The tight market also implies that wage pressure may be present, potentially driving up labor costs for employers.

Wage Growth

Cleveland's year-over-year wage growth rate of +0.88% is ranked at the 10th percentile, indicating stagnant wage growth. This slow wage growth environment means that labor costs for employers are not rising rapidly, but it also implies that worker purchasing power is not increasing significantly. As a result, businesses may not need to budget for large wage increases, but they may also not benefit from a highly motivated workforce with growing disposable income.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of 4.17, based on \$143/sqft and \$34.26/hr, Cleveland ranks at the 50th percentile in terms of affordability. This near-median ranking suggests that the city is neither exceptionally affordable nor expensive compared to its peers. The relatively stable cost of living means that businesses may not need to offer significant wage premiums to attract talent, but they also may not benefit from a major cost advantage.

Labor Force Growth

The city's labor force growth rate of +1.80% YoY ranks at the 94th percentile, indicating a rapidly expanding workforce supply. This strong growth implies that businesses will have access to a growing pool of potential employees, making it easier to hire and expand operations.

The increasing labor force also suggests that the city is attractive to workers, which could be a competitive advantage for businesses.

Building Permits

Cleveland's year-over-year change in building permits is -0.61%, ranking at the 48th percentile, indicating a moderate tightening of housing supply. This decline in permits suggests that the city's housing market may become less affordable in the future, potentially making it more challenging for workers to relocate or for businesses to attract talent. The slowing housing supply growth could lead to increased competition for available housing, driving up costs.

Days on Market

The current median days on market in Cleveland is 55 days, with a year-over-year increase of +7.8%, ranking at the 66th percentile. This indicates a relatively slow market, making it more accessible for workers relocating to the city. The longer days on market suggest that buyers have more negotiating power, and the market is not extremely competitive, which could be beneficial for businesses looking to attract talent.

Office Economy

Cleveland's share of professional and office workers is 2.86, ranking at the 60th percentile, indicating a deep talent pool suited for tech, finance, consulting, and HQ decisions. The city's above-average office economy suggests that it is well-suited for businesses that require specialized knowledge workers, but it may be less suitable for industries with more industrial or logistics-oriented workforces.

In conclusion, Cleveland offers businesses a mixed economic environment with a growing labor force, moderate labor demand, and a relatively tight labor market. However, the city's stagnant wage growth and tightening housing supply are potential risks that decision-makers should factor in when considering relocation or expansion. The single biggest constraint for businesses in Cleveland may be the slow wage growth, which could impact worker motivation and purchasing power, potentially affecting the overall competitiveness of the city.

Seattle

Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue

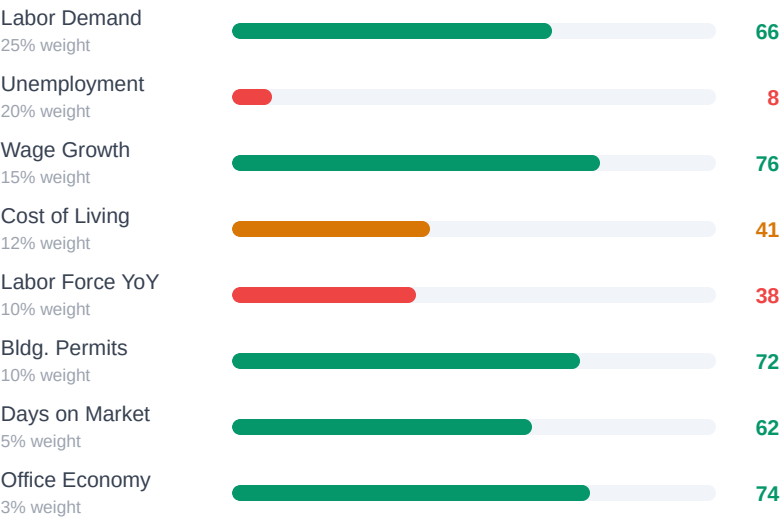
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AVERAGE

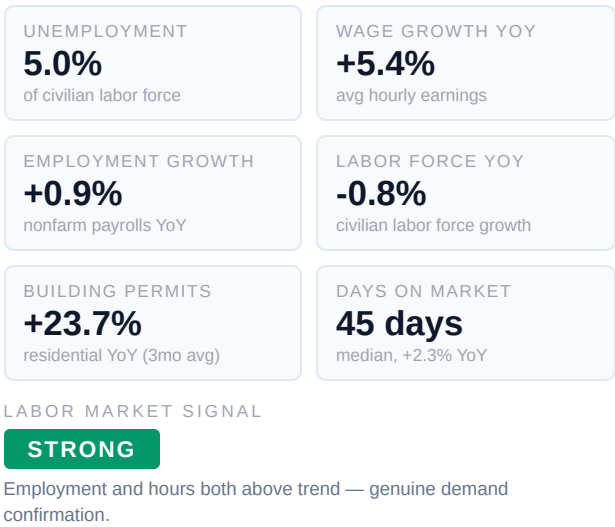
50.7th percentile

Rank 20 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue metro area has an overall grade of B, ranking in the 50.7th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its above-average labor demand and strong wage growth, at 66th and 76th percentiles, respectively. The city's economic character is defined by these two metrics, with employment growth at 0.88% year-over-year and weekly hours 0.406% above trend. This combination signals genuine demand expansion, with jobs being added and hours running above trend.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate of 0.88% and hours deviation of 0.406% above trend indicate a strong labor market, signaling genuine demand expansion. This combination suggests that the city is experiencing an increase in jobs and working hours, which is a positive sign for businesses looking to expand or establish themselves in the area. The labor demand composite score of 5.94, ranking in the 66th percentile, further supports this assessment.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue is 5.00%, ranking in the 8th percentile, indicating a tight labor market with limited slack. This means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the pool of available workers is relatively small, and may need to offer competitive wages to attract talent. The low unemployment rate also suggests that workers may have more bargaining power, potentially driving up labor costs.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate is 5.44%, ranking in the 76th percentile, indicating fast wage growth. This suggests that labor costs for employers may be rising, but workers will have increased purchasing power, which can be beneficial for businesses that rely on local consumer demand. The strong wage growth also indicates a competitive labor market, where businesses may need to offer higher wages to attract and retain talent.

Cost of Living

The cost of living in Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue, with a PSF of \$432/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$48.08/hr, resulting in a ratio of 8.99, ranks in the 41st percentile, indicating a near-median affordability level. The fact that PSF is falling by 1.8% year-over-year is a positive sign for affordability. This means that the city may not have a significant talent attraction advantage due to affordability, and businesses may need to consider wage premiums to compensate for the cost of living.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force is growing at a rate of -0.77% year-over-year, ranking in the 38th percentile, indicating a contracting labor force supply. This suggests that the pool of available workers is shrinking, which can create structural headwinds for hiring and business expansion. Businesses may need to consider strategies to attract workers from other areas or invest in workforce development programs.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in building permits is 23.71%, ranking in the 72nd percentile, indicating an expansion in housing supply. This suggests that developer confidence is high, and the future housing supply is expected to increase, which can improve affordability and accommodate a growing workforce. This is a positive sign for businesses that rely on a growing and diverse workforce.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 45 days, with a year-over-year increase of 2.3%, ranking in the 62nd percentile. This indicates a relatively slow market, which can be beneficial for workers relocating to the city, as they may have more time to find a suitable home. However, this can also be a sign of a normalization in the housing market, rather than a demand erosion.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers is 3.08, ranking in the 74th percentile, indicating a deep talent pool in these sectors. This suggests that the city is well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, but may be less suitable for industries that require a large workforce in industrial or logistics roles.

The Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue metro area offers businesses a strong labor market with genuine demand expansion and a deep talent pool in professional and office sectors. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for businesses is the tight labor market and low unemployment rate, which can drive up labor costs and create challenges in hiring and retaining talent.

Miami

Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach

B

AVERAGE

50.5th percentile

Rank 21 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand		40
25% weight		
Unemployment		60
20% weight		
Wage Growth		96
15% weight		
Cost of Living		31
12% weight		
Labor Force YoY		52
10% weight		
Bldg. Permits		4
10% weight		
Days on Market		58
5% weight		
Office Economy		64
3% weight		

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT 3.7% of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY +7.7% avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH +0.3% nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY -0.2% civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS -34.1% residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET 85 days median, -5.6% YoY
LABOR MARKET SIGNAL STRONG Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.	

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach metro area has an overall grade of B, ranking at the 50.5th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its strong wage growth and above-average office economy. The city's economic character is most defined by its top-tier wage growth of 7.68% year-over-year and its above-average share of professional and office workers, at 64th percentile. These metrics suggest a city with a strong, knowledge-based economy.

Labor Demand

The Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach metro area has an employment growth rate of 0.35% year-over-year and a weekly hours deviation of 0.285% above its own trend, indicating a near-median labor demand composite score of 5.08, which signals a genuine demand expansion. This combination suggests that the city is experiencing modest job growth, with hours worked above trend, indicating that employers are demanding more labor. However, the growth rate is not exceptionally high, suggesting a relatively stable labor market.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in the Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach metro area is 3.70%, ranking at the 60th percentile, indicating a relatively tight labor market. This means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the pool of available workers is smaller, and may need to offer competitive wages to attract talent. The tight labor market also suggests that workers may have more bargaining power.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in the Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach metro area is 7.68%, ranking at the 96th percentile, indicating fast and strong wage growth. This suggests that employer labor costs are rising rapidly, and workers have increasing purchasing power. However, this also means that businesses may need to budget for higher labor costs and consider the impact on their bottom line.

Cost of Living

The Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach metro area has a cost of living ratio of \$355/sqft to \$35.24/hr, with a year-over-year decrease of 0.8% in PSF, ranking at the 31st percentile, indicating that the city is relatively expensive. This means that businesses may need to offer wage premiums to attract talent, as the high cost of living may deter some workers. However, the decreasing PSF trend may signal some improvement in affordability.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in the Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach metro area is growing at a rate of -0.22% year-over-year, ranking near the median at the 52nd percentile, indicating a slightly contracting labor force supply. This suggests that the pool of available workers may be shrinking, making it more challenging for businesses to hire and expand their workforce.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits in the Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach metro area is -34.10%, ranking at the 4th percentile, indicating a sharp decline in housing supply. This suggests that the city may be experiencing a tightening of the housing market, which could lead to increased costs and reduced affordability for workers, making it more challenging for businesses to attract and retain talent.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in the Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach metro area is 85 days, with a year-over-year decrease of 5.6%, ranking near the median at the 58th percentile. This suggests that the housing market is relatively competitive, but the decreasing days on market trend may signal a slight normalization. For workers relocating to the city, this means that they may face a relatively fast-paced housing market.

Office Economy

The Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach metro area has a deep professional talent pool, with an office and professional worker share ranking at the 64th percentile. This makes the city well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, but less suited for industries with more industrial or logistics-oriented workforces.

The Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach metro area offers businesses a strong, knowledge-based economy with a highly skilled workforce, driven by top-tier wage growth and an above-average office economy. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's relatively expensive cost of living and tightening housing market, which may require businesses to offer wage premiums and factor in increased labor costs to attract and retain talent.

Los Angeles

Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim

B

AVERAGE

50.3th percentile

Rank 22 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand 25% weight		88
Unemployment 20% weight		48
Wage Growth 15% weight		46
Cost of Living 12% weight		4
Labor Force YoY 10% weight		8
Bldg. Permits 10% weight		78
Days on Market 5% weight		28
Office Economy 3% weight		44

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT 5.0% of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY +3.4% avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH +1.8% nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY -2.2% civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS +26.8% residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET 53 days median, 0.0% YoY
LABOR MARKET SIGNAL STRONG Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.	

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim metro area has an overall grade of B, ranking 50.3th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its strong labor demand and building permits growth. The city's economic character is defined by its top-tier labor demand composite score of 7.01, which combines a +1.83% employment growth rate and a +0.151% weekly hours deviation from its own trend. This signals a genuine demand expansion, with jobs being added and hours running above trend.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate of +1.83% and weekly hours deviation of +0.151% indicate a strong labor market with genuine demand expansion. This combination signals that the city is experiencing an increase in jobs and working hours, which is a positive indicator for businesses looking to expand or relocate. The labor demand composite score of 7.01, ranking in the 88th percentile, further reinforces this trend.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate of 5.00% ranks in the 48th percentile, indicating a near-median level of unemployment. This suggests that the market has some slack, making it relatively easier for businesses to hire compared to cities with tighter labor markets. However, this also means that local consumer demand may be weaker compared to cities with lower unemployment rates.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate of +3.39% ranks in the 46th percentile, indicating a moderate level of wage growth. This means that employer labor costs are rising, but at a pace that is not excessively high. Workers in the city are also experiencing an increase in purchasing power, which can have a positive impact on local consumer demand.

Cost of Living

The cost of living in Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim is relatively expensive, with a percentile rank of 4th, indicating that it is one of the more expensive cities in the US. The PSF of \$652/sqft, which is decreasing at a rate of -2.1% YoY, combined with an hourly earnings rate of \$41.54/hr, results in a ratio of 15.70. This makes it challenging for businesses to attract talent without offering wage premiums, as the high cost of living may offset the benefits of working in the city.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force is contracting at a rate of -2.18% year-over-year, ranking in the 8th percentile. This indicates that the labor pool is shrinking, which can create a structural headwind for hiring and may limit the city's ability to support business growth.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in building permits is +26.84%, ranking in the 78th percentile, indicating a strong expansion in housing supply. This suggests that developer confidence is high, and the city is likely to experience an increase in available housing, which can improve affordability and make it easier for workers to relocate to the area.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 53 days, with a year-over-year change of +0.0%, ranking in the 28th percentile. This indicates a relatively fast-paced market, making it challenging for relocating workers to find housing. However, the stable days on market suggests that the market is not becoming increasingly competitive.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers in the city is 2.32, ranking in the 44th percentile, indicating a near-median level of depth in the professional talent pool. This makes the city suitable for businesses that require a moderate level of specialized knowledge workers, but may not be the best fit for businesses that require a highly specialized or deep talent pool.

The Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim metro area offers businesses a strong labor demand and expanding housing supply, making it an attractive location for companies looking to grow. However, the city's high cost of living and shrinking labor force are significant constraints that decision-makers should factor in, as they may limit the city's ability to support long-term business growth and require businesses to offer wage premiums to attract talent.

Tampa

Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater

B

AVERAGE

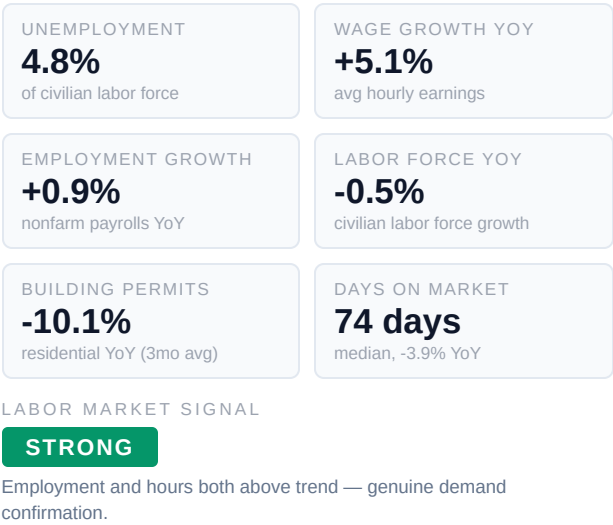
50.3th percentile

Rank 23 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater metro area has an overall grade of B, ranking 50.3th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its above-average labor demand and top-tier cost of living. The city's economic character is defined by its 60th percentile labor demand composite score, which combines a +0.92% employment growth rate and a +0.120% weekly hours deviation from its own trend. This suggests a genuine demand expansion, with jobs being added and hours running above trend.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate of +0.92% and weekly hours deviation of +0.120% signal a genuine demand expansion, indicating that the city is experiencing an increase in jobs and working hours. This combination suggests that the labor market is strong, with employers adding jobs and workers putting in more hours. The labor demand composite score of 5.71, ranking in the 60th percentile, further supports this assessment.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate of 4.80% is relatively high, ranking in the bottom tier at the 4th percentile, indicating a labor market with some slack. This means that businesses may find it easier to hire workers, but may also face weaker local consumer demand. The relatively high unemployment rate suggests that the market is not as tight as in other cities, giving employers more flexibility in hiring.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate of +5.13% is above average, ranking in the 72nd percentile, indicating fast wage growth. This suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but workers are also experiencing increased purchasing power. The strong wage growth may attract top talent, but also increases the cost burden on employers.

Cost of Living

The city's cost of living is relatively affordable, with a percentile rank of 84th, driven by a PSF of \$233/sqft that has decreased by 5.7% year-over-year, combined with an average hourly earnings of \$37.29/hr. This affordability advantage can attract talent without requiring wage premiums, making it an attractive location for businesses.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force has contracted by -0.50% year-over-year, ranking near the median at the 44th percentile, indicating a shrinking labor pool. This may pose a structural headwind for hiring, as the supply of workers is not expanding. Businesses may need to consider strategies to attract workers from other areas or invest in training and development programs.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits is -10.10%, ranking below average at the 30th percentile, indicating a tightening housing supply. This may lead to future affordability challenges and make it more difficult for workers to relocate to the city, potentially affecting workforce accommodation and attraction.

Days on Market

The median days on market is 74 days, with a year-over-year decrease of -3.9%, ranking in the 76th percentile. This suggests a relatively fast-paced market, where homes are selling quickly, making it competitive for relocating workers to find housing. However, the decreasing trend may indicate a normalization of the market.

Office Economy

The city has a deep professional talent pool, ranking in the 82nd percentile, with a share of jobs in professional and office sectors of 3.58. This makes it an attractive location for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, but less suited for industrial or logistics-dominant economies.

The Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater metro area offers businesses a unique combination of above-average labor demand and affordability, making it an attractive location for talent attraction and business growth. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the tightening housing supply, which may lead to future affordability challenges and affect workforce accommodation, making it essential to factor this into long-term business plans.

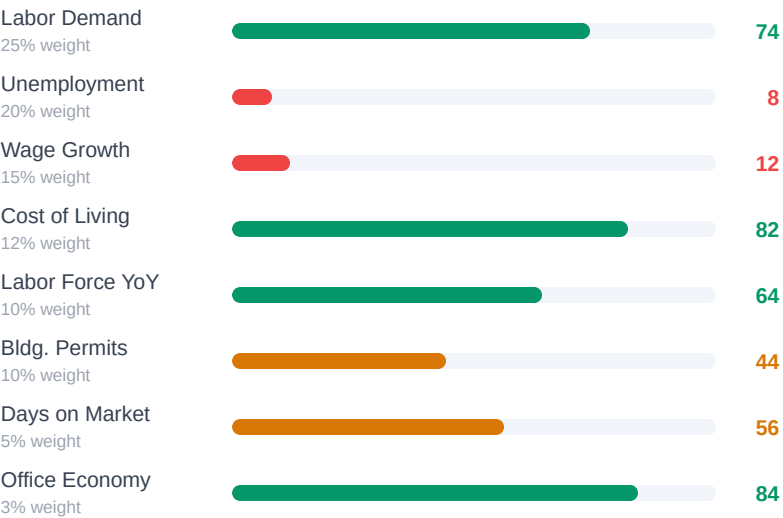
Houston

Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands

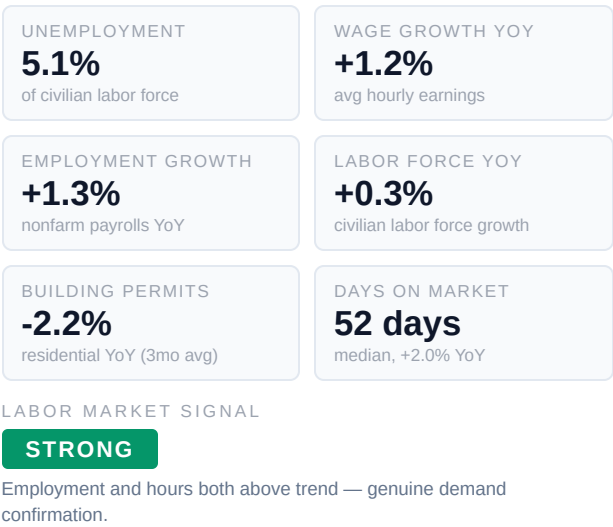
B-

BELOW AVERAGE
47.8th percentile
Rank 24 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands metro area has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking at the 47.8th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its strong labor demand, with a composite score in the 74th percentile, and its high cost of living affordability, ranked in the 82nd percentile. The labor demand is driven by a combination of employment growth and hours worked above trend, while the cost of living is influenced by a PSF to earnings ratio of \$169/sqft to \$36.92/hr, which is decreasing by 2.3% YoY.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands is 1.30% YoY, and weekly hours are deviating 0.091% above the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals genuine demand expansion, as hours are running above trend during a period of job growth. This indicates a strong labor market with increasing job opportunities.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in this metro area is 5.10%, which corresponds to a bottom-tier percentile rank of 8th. This suggests a relatively loose labor market with some slack, making it easier for businesses to hire workers without excessive wage pressure. However, this also implies weaker local consumer demand compared to tighter labor markets.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands is 1.21%, which is ranked in the bottom tier at the 12th percentile. This slow wage growth indicates a relatively flat cost environment for employers but weak bargaining power for workers. As a result, worker purchasing power is not increasing rapidly.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living percentile rank of 82nd, Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands is relatively affordable compared to its peers. The PSF to earnings ratio of \$169/sqft to \$36.92/hr, combined with a 2.3% YoY decrease in PSF, makes this city attractive for talent without requiring significant wage premiums. This affordability advantage can be a key factor in talent attraction and retention.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in this metro area is growing at a rate of 0.28% YoY, which is ranked in the 64th percentile. This positive growth indicates an expanding workforce supply, providing a favorable environment for hiring and business expansion. As the labor force grows, businesses can tap into a increasing pool of potential workers.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits is -2.18%, ranking near the median at the 44th percentile. This decline suggests that housing supply is not expanding as rapidly as in other metros, which could lead to future affordability challenges and constraints on workforce accommodation. However, the current decrease is not sharply negative, indicating a relatively stable housing market.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 52 days, with a 2.0% YoY increase. This indicates a relatively accessible market for workers relocating to the city, as homes are not selling extremely quickly. The rising days on market, despite a strong job market, may signal a healthy normalization of the housing market, rather than demand erosion.

Office Economy

With an office/professional worker share ranked in the 84th percentile, Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands has a deep talent pool suited for tech, finance, consulting, and HQ decisions. This city is well-suited for businesses requiring specialized knowledge-economy roles, but may be less ideal for industries dominated by industrial or logistics roles.

In conclusion, Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands offers businesses a unique combination of strong labor demand and affordable cost of living, making it an attractive location for talent attraction and retention. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the relatively slow wage growth, which may impact worker purchasing power and bargaining ability, potentially affecting the local consumer demand and overall economic growth.

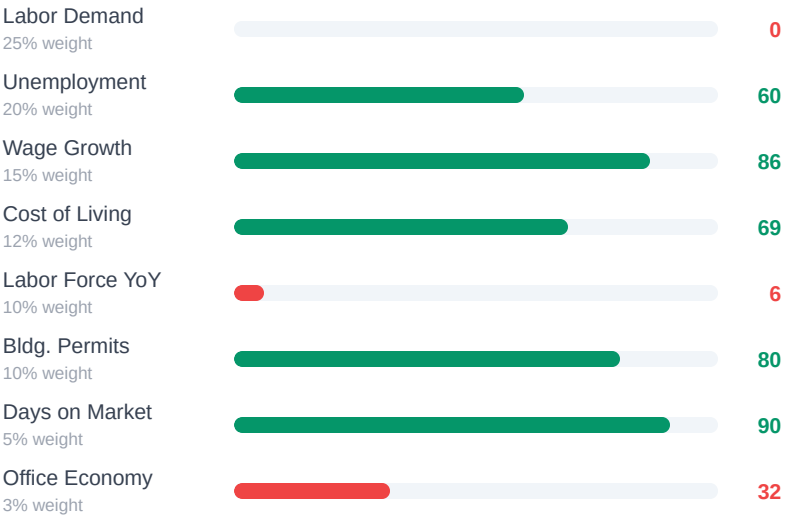
Washington DC

Washington-Arlington-Alexandria

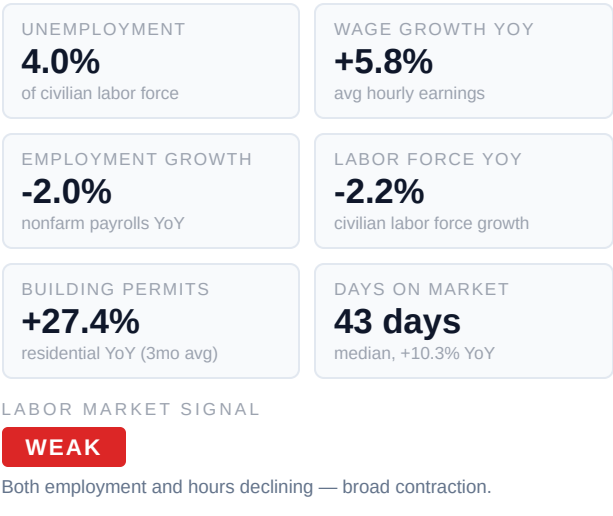
B-

BELOW AVERAGE
47.3th percentile
Rank 25 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Washington-Arlington-Alexandria metro area has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking it at the 47.3th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its strong wage growth, with a year-over-year increase of 5.85%, and its low labor demand, indicated by a -1.96% employment growth rate and a -0.606% deviation in weekly hours from its own trend. These metrics suggest a complex economic environment with both positive and negative signals.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Washington-Arlington-Alexandria is -1.96%, and weekly hours are deviating -0.606% from the city's own trend, resulting in a labor demand composite score of 1.56, which ranks in the bottom tier. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, indicating that the city is experiencing a decline in job creation and hours worked. This suggests a survivor squeeze, where remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Washington-Arlington-Alexandria is 4.00%, which corresponds to an above-average percentile rank of 60th. This indicates a relatively tight labor market with some slack, making it moderately challenging for businesses to hire new employees. As a result, businesses may face some wage pressure when trying to attract and retain talent in this market.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Washington-Arlington-Alexandria is 5.85%, ranking in the top tier at the 86th percentile. This fast wage growth rate implies rising labor costs for employers, which can be a challenge for businesses looking to control expenses. However, it also means good news for worker purchasing power, as employees are seeing significant increases in their earnings.

Cost of Living

Washington-Arlington-Alexandria has a cost of living score that ranks in the 69th percentile, with a PSF of \$298/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$45.93/hr, resulting in a ratio of 6.49. This indicates that the city is relatively affordable compared to its peers, with a PSF that is decreasing by 2.3% year-over-year. This affordability advantage can be a significant talent attraction factor for businesses, as they may not need to offer wage premiums to compensate for high living costs.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Washington-Arlington-Alexandria is shrinking at a rate of -2.20% year-over-year, ranking in the bottom tier at the 6th percentile. This contraction in labor force supply implies a structural headwind for hiring, making it challenging for businesses to find and recruit new employees. As a result, businesses may need to invest more in talent development and retention strategies.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Washington-Arlington-Alexandria is increasing by 27.36% year-over-year, ranking in the top tier at the 80th percentile. This expansion in housing supply signals improving affordability and a more accommodating environment for the workforce. As a result, businesses can expect a more stable and growing pool of potential employees in the future.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Washington-Arlington-Alexandria is currently 43 days, with a year-over-year increase of 10.3%, ranking in the top tier at the 90th percentile. This slower market means that homes are sitting longer before being sold, making it a more accessible and less competitive environment for workers relocating to the city. As a result, businesses may find it easier to attract and retain talent, as employees will have more time to find and secure housing.

Office Economy

Washington-Arlington-Alexandria has a professional and office worker share that ranks in the 32nd percentile, indicating a relatively shallow talent pool in these sectors. This city is best suited for businesses that do not require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as industrial or logistics-dominant companies. However, it may not be the ideal location for tech, finance, or consulting businesses that rely heavily on specialized office workers.

The Washington-Arlington-Alexandria metro area offers a complex economic environment with both strengths and weaknesses, making it a challenging location for businesses to navigate. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the shrinking labor force supply, which may limit the pool of potential employees and require businesses to invest more in talent development and retention strategies. Despite this, the city's strong wage growth and relatively affordable cost of living may still make it an attractive location for certain types of businesses.

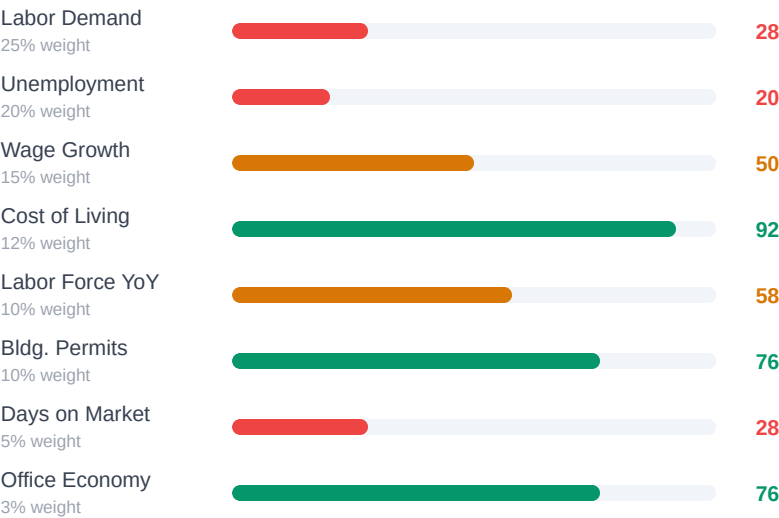
San Antonio

San Antonio-New Braunfels

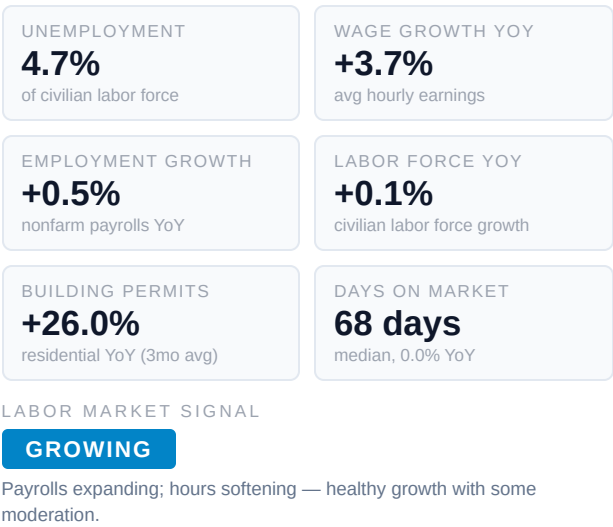
B-

BELOW AVERAGE
46.6th percentile
Rank 26 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The San Antonio-New Braunfels metro area has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking it at the 46.6th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its below-average labor demand, with a composite score of 4.36 ranking it at the 28th percentile, and its highly affordable cost of living, with a ratio of \$170/sqft to \$33.17/hr and a percentile rank of 92. The labor demand metrics, including employment growth and weekly hours, signal a contraction in genuine demand expansion.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in San Antonio-New Braunfels is +0.51% year-over-year, while weekly hours are deviating -0.651% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, rather than genuine demand expansion or survivor squeeze. The below-average labor demand composite score of 4.36, ranking at the 28th percentile, further supports this conclusion.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in San Antonio-New Braunfels is 4.70%, ranking at the 20th percentile, indicating a relatively loose labor market. This means that there is some slack in the market, making it slightly easier for businesses to hire, but also potentially leading to weaker local consumer demand. The practical implication for a business trying to hire in this city is that it may have a relatively easier time finding candidates, but may also face less competitive pressure to offer high wages.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in San Antonio-New Braunfels is +3.73%, ranking at the 50th percentile, indicating moderate wage growth. This rate is neither exceptionally fast nor stagnant, suggesting that employer labor costs are rising at a steady pace, while worker purchasing power is also increasing. The moderate wage growth implies a relatively stable labor cost environment for businesses.

Cost of Living

San Antonio-New Braunfels has a highly affordable cost of living, with a percentile rank of 92, due to its PSF of \$170/sqft decreasing by 4.0% year-over-year relative to wages of \$33.17/hr. This affordability advantage means that the city can attract talent without requiring significant wage premiums, making it an attractive location for businesses looking to relocate or expand.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in San Antonio-New Braunfels is growing at a rate of +0.10% year-over-year, ranking at the 58th percentile, indicating a slowly expanding labor supply. This modest growth rate suggests that the hiring capacity in the city is not severely constrained, but may not be rapidly expanding either. The implication for businesses is that they may need to invest in talent development and retention to support their growth plans.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in San Antonio-New Braunfels is increasing by +25.98% year-over-year, ranking at the 76th percentile, indicating an expansion in housing supply. This growth in building permits signals that the city's housing market is likely to become more affordable in the future, making it easier for workers to relocate and for businesses to attract talent.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in San Antonio-New Braunfels is 68 days, with a year-over-year change of +0.0%, ranking at the 28th percentile. This relatively slow market means that workers relocating to the city may have a more accessible and less competitive housing market, making it easier for them to find and purchase a home.

Office Economy

San Antonio-New Braunfels has a deep professional talent pool, with an office economy percentile rank of 76, indicating a strong presence of professional and office sectors. This makes the city well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, but less suited for industries with primarily industrial or logistics-based workforces.

The San Antonio-New Braunfels metro area offers businesses a unique combination of affordability, moderate wage growth, and an expanding housing supply, making it an attractive location for relocation or expansion. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's below-average labor demand, which may limit the pool of skilled workers available for hire, and require businesses to invest in talent development and retention to support their growth plans.

New York

New York Newark-Jersey City

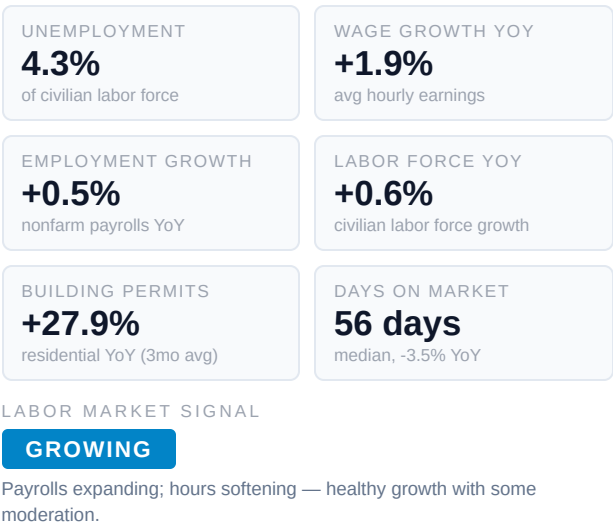
B-

BELOW AVERAGE
45.6th percentile
Rank 27 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The New York Newark-Jersey City metro area has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking it 45.6th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its low labor demand, with a composite score ranking 34th percentile, and its high cost of living, with a percentile rank of 8th. The labor demand is driven by a modest employment growth rate of 0.50% and a weekly hours deviation of -0.202% from its own trend.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate of 0.50% and weekly hours deviation of -0.202% signal a contraction in labor demand, indicating that the city is not experiencing genuine demand expansion. This combination suggests that the city's job market is not as strong as others, with hours worked being below trend. The labor demand composite score of 4.80 ranks 34th percentile, further emphasizing the city's below-average labor demand.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate of 4.30% ranks 72nd percentile, indicating a relatively tight labor market. This means that there is less slack in the market, making it harder for businesses to hire workers. As a result, businesses may face upward pressure on wages to attract and retain talent.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate of 1.91% is below average, ranking 22nd percentile. This moderate wage growth rate implies that labor costs for employers are rising, but at a slower pace than in other cities. Workers in this city will experience modest increases in purchasing power, but not as strong as in cities with faster wage growth.

Cost of Living

The city's cost of living is expensive, with a percentile rank of 8th, driven by a PSF of \$490/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$40.91/hr, resulting in a ratio of 11.98. Although the PSF is falling by 0.6% year-over-year, the city remains one of the more expensive options. This high cost of living makes it challenging for businesses to attract talent without offering wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force is growing at a rate of 0.60% year-over-year, ranking 72nd percentile. This positive growth rate indicates that the workforce supply is expanding, providing a favorable environment for businesses looking to hire. The growing labor force can help mitigate some of the hiring challenges posed by the tight labor market.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in building permits is 27.93%, ranking 82nd percentile. This significant increase in permits suggests that housing supply is expanding, which can improve affordability and accommodate a growing workforce. The rising permits signal a positive outlook for future affordability and workforce accommodation.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 56 days, with a year-over-year decrease of 3.5%. This relatively fast market makes it challenging for relocating workers to find homes, as properties are selling quickly. The competitive housing market may require businesses to offer relocation assistance or other incentives to attract talent.

Office Economy

The city's professional and office worker share ranks 72nd percentile, indicating a deep talent pool suited for tech, finance, consulting, and HQ decisions. The city is well-suited for businesses that require specialized knowledge-economy talent, but may not be the best fit for industries with more industrial or logistics-oriented workforces.

The New York Newark-Jersey City metro area offers businesses a unique combination of a growing labor force and expanding housing supply, but the high cost of living and moderate wage growth pose significant challenges. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the expensive cost of living, which may require wage premiums to attract and retain talent, ultimately affecting business profitability and competitiveness.

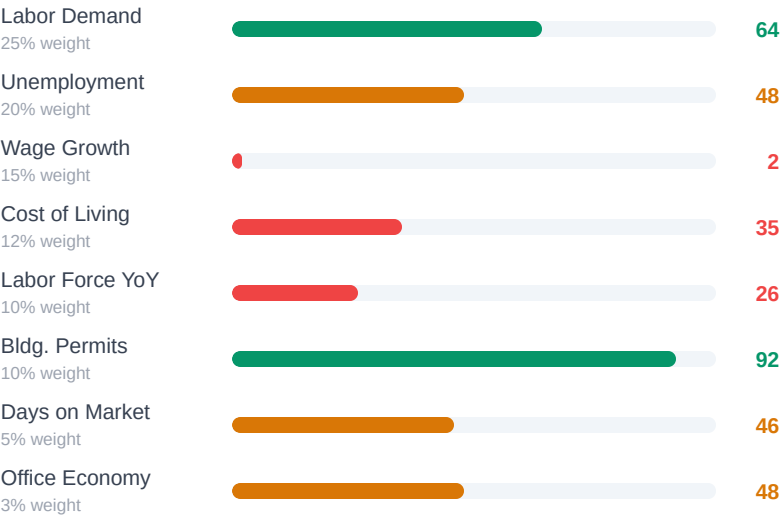
Birmingham

Birmingham

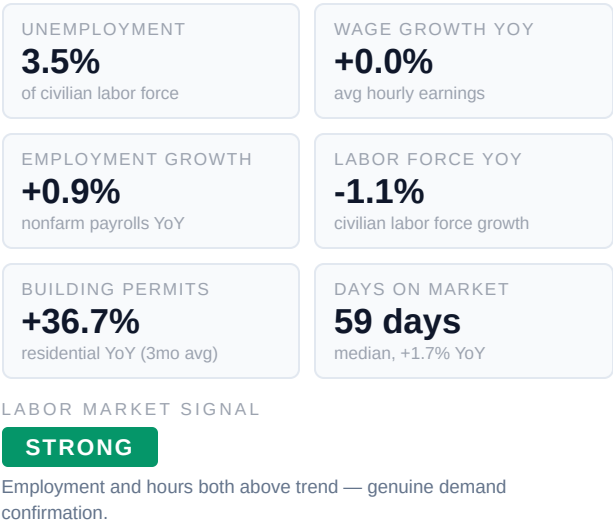
B-

BELOW AVERAGE
45.6th percentile
Rank 28 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0-100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Birmingham, with an overall grade of B- and a composite score ranking it 45.6th out of 50 US metros, is characterized by its above-average labor demand and top-tier building permit growth. The city's labor demand composite score of 5.94, driven by a +0.92% employment growth rate and +0.349% weekly hours deviation from its own trend, signals genuine demand expansion. Additionally, the +36.73% year-over-year change in building permits highlights a significant expansion in housing supply.

Labor Demand

Birmingham's employment growth rate of +0.92% and weekly hours deviation of +0.349% from its own trend indicate a genuine demand expansion, as both jobs and hours worked are increasing. This combination suggests that the city is experiencing a period of economic growth, with businesses adding jobs and workers putting in more hours. The labor demand composite score of 5.94, ranking in the 64th percentile, further supports this assessment.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Birmingham stands at 3.50%, ranking in the 48th percentile, indicating a near-median level of unemployment. This rate suggests that the labor market has some slack, making it slightly easier for businesses to hire compared to cities with tighter labor markets. However, the relatively low unemployment rate still implies some competition for talent.

Wage Growth

With a year-over-year wage growth rate of +0.03%, Birmingham's wage growth is stagnant, ranking in the 2nd percentile. This slow wage growth environment means that labor costs for employers are not increasing rapidly, but it also implies weak bargaining power for workers and potentially limited purchasing power.

Cost of Living

Birmingham's cost of living, with a PSF of \$159/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$32.71/hr, resulting in a ratio of 4.86, ranks in the 35th percentile, indicating that the city is below average in terms of affordability. The fact that PSF is decreasing by -0.6% year-over-year is a positive sign for affordability. This relatively low cost of living could be a talent attraction advantage, as workers may not require significant wage premiums to maintain their standard of living.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Birmingham is contracting at a rate of -1.10% year-over-year, indicating a shrinking labor pool. This negative growth rate presents a structural headwind for hiring, as the supply of potential workers is decreasing.

Building Permits

The +36.73% year-over-year increase in building permits signals a significant expansion in housing supply, ranking in the 92nd percentile. This growth in permits suggests that developer confidence is high, and the future housing supply is likely to increase, which could improve affordability and accommodate a growing workforce.

Days on Market

Homes in Birmingham are currently sitting on the market for a median of 59 days, with a year-over-year increase of +1.7%. This moderate days on market suggests a relatively balanced market, neither extremely competitive nor overly accessible for relocating workers.

Office Economy

With an office and professional worker share ranking in the 48th percentile, Birmingham has a near-median depth of professional talent pool. This suggests that the city is suited for a variety of businesses but may not have the deepest pool of specialized knowledge-economy talent, making it less ideal for tech, finance, or consulting headquarters decisions.

In conclusion, Birmingham offers a unique combination of above-average labor demand and expanding housing supply, making it an attractive location for businesses looking to tap into a growing workforce. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the stagnant wage growth, which could limit worker purchasing power and bargaining ability, potentially affecting the overall economic vitality of the city.

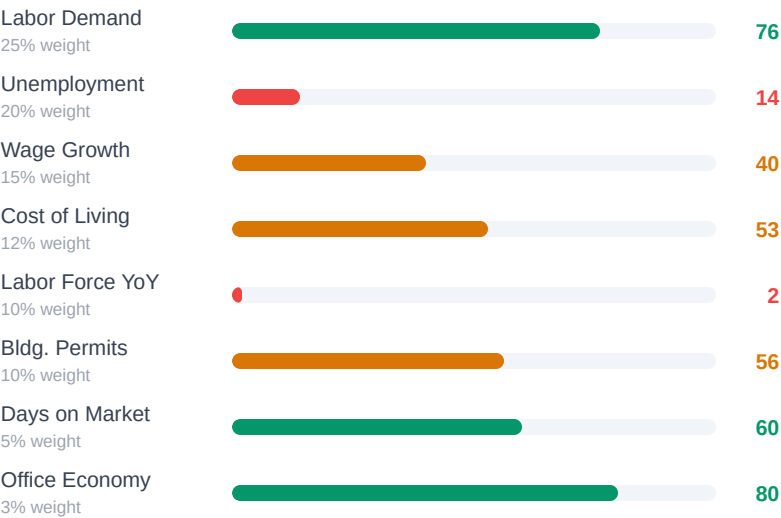
Phoenix

Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler

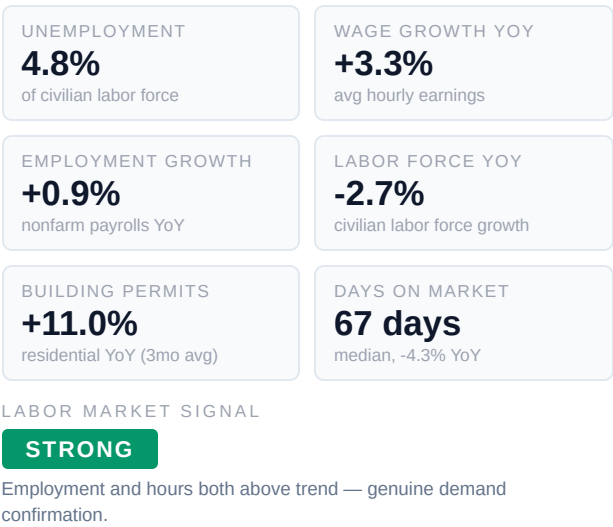
B-

BELOW AVERAGE
45.4th percentile
Rank 29 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler metro area has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking it 45.4th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its strong labor demand, with a composite score in the 76th percentile, and its low unemployment rate, which is in the 14th percentile. The labor demand is driven by a 0.91% year-over-year employment growth rate and a 0.771% deviation in weekly hours above its own trend.

Labor Demand

The Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler metro area has a labor demand composite score of 6.34, driven by a 0.91% year-over-year employment growth rate and a 0.771% deviation in weekly hours above its own trend. This combination signals genuine demand expansion, as hours are running above trend during a period of job growth. The strong labor demand indicates a competitive market for workers.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler is 4.80%, which is in the 14th percentile, indicating a tight labor market with little slack. This means that businesses trying to hire in this city may face challenges in finding available workers, leading to potential wage pressure. The low unemployment rate suggests that workers have more bargaining power.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler is 3.28%, which is near the median, ranking in the 40th percentile. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not excessively, and worker purchasing power is increasing. The wage growth rate is not stagnant, but it is not exceptionally high either.

Cost of Living

The cost of living in Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler is near the median, with a percentile rank of 53, and a price-to-salary ratio of \$264/sqft to \$38.11/hr, or 6.93. The city's cost of living is relatively affordable, with the price per square foot decreasing by 1.5% year-over-year. This affordability makes it easier for businesses to attract talent without needing to offer significant wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler is contracting at a rate of -2.70% year-over-year, which is in the 2nd percentile. This decline in labor force supply indicates a structural headwind for hiring, making it challenging for businesses to find workers. The shrinking labor pool may limit the city's ability to support rapid business growth.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler is increasing by 10.99% year-over-year, which is near the median, ranking in the 56th percentile. This growth in building permits suggests that housing supply is expanding, which may improve affordability and accommodate a growing workforce. The increase in permits is a positive sign for future workforce attraction and retention.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler is 67 days, with a year-over-year decrease of 4.3%. This relatively fast market, with a percentile rank of 60, may make it challenging for relocating workers to find homes. However, the decreasing days on market suggests a normalization of the housing market, which could become more accessible to workers in the future.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers in Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler is 3.36, ranking in the 80th percentile, indicating a deep talent pool. This city is well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, but may not be as suitable for industrial or logistics-dominant businesses. The strong office economy makes it an attractive location for knowledge-based businesses.

The Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler metro area offers businesses a strong labor demand and a relatively affordable cost of living, making it an attractive location for talent attraction and retention. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for businesses in this city is the shrinking labor force, which may limit the city's ability to support rapid business growth and create challenges for hiring and workforce expansion.

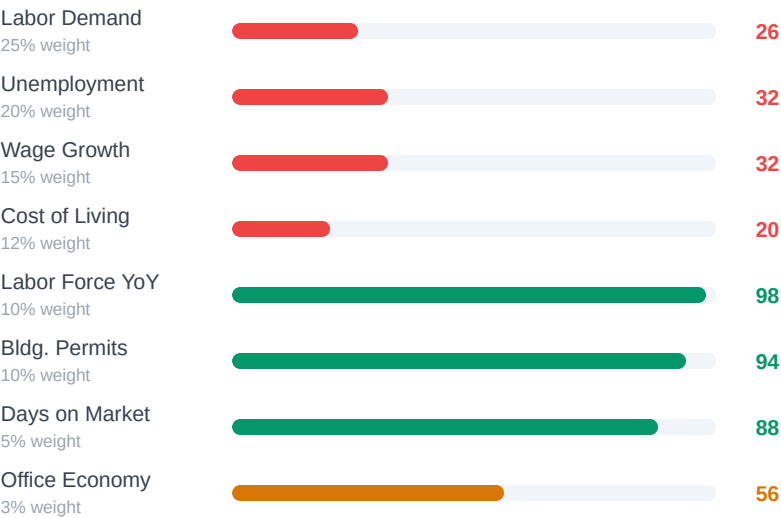
Boston

Boston-Cambridge-Newton

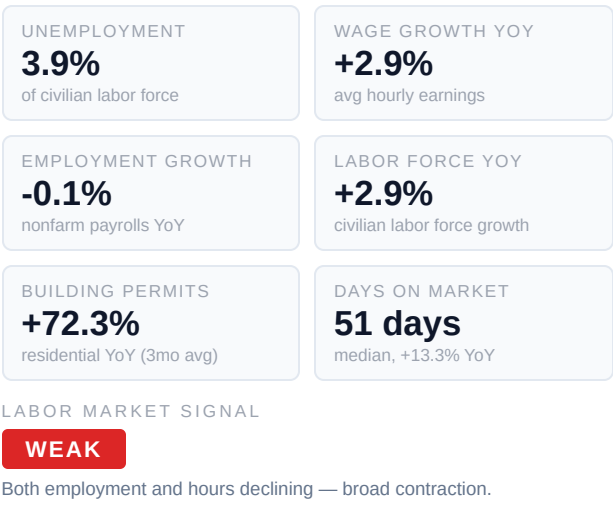
B-

BELOW AVERAGE
45.4th percentile
Rank 30 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Boston-Cambridge-Newton metro area has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking it 45.4th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its strong labor force growth, with a 2.87% year-over-year increase, and its high cost of living, with a PSF to earnings ratio of 9.99. The labor demand composite score of 4.13, ranking in the 26th percentile, also plays a significant role in shaping the city's economic landscape.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Boston-Cambridge-Newton is -0.12% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating -0.351% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, indicating that the city is not experiencing genuine demand expansion. The negative employment growth rate and below-trend hours suggest that the city's labor market is experiencing a slowdown.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Boston-Cambridge-Newton is 3.90%, ranking in the 32nd percentile. This indicates a moderate level of slack in the labor market, making it neither extremely tight nor very loose. For a business trying to hire in this city, the moderate unemployment rate means that there is a pool of available workers, but it may not be as large as in cities with higher unemployment rates.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Boston-Cambridge-Newton is +2.93%, ranking in the 32nd percentile. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not extremely quickly. As a result, worker purchasing power is increasing, but not at a rapid pace, which may have implications for local consumer demand.

Cost of Living

Boston-Cambridge-Newton has a cost of living percentile rank of 20th, indicating that it is relatively expensive compared to its peers. The PSF to earnings ratio of 9.99, with PSF at \$458/sqft and decreasing by 1.5% year-over-year, suggests that the city may struggle to attract talent without offering wage premiums. The high cost of living may be a challenge for businesses looking to relocate or expand in this city.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Boston-Cambridge-Newton is growing at a rate of 2.87% year-over-year, ranking in the 98th percentile. This rapid expansion of the labor force supply means that businesses in this city have a growing pool of potential workers to draw from, making it easier to hire and staff new positions.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Boston-Cambridge-Newton has increased by 72.27% year-over-year, ranking in the 94th percentile. This significant expansion of housing supply suggests that the city is experiencing an increase in developer confidence and a future improvement in affordability. As a result, the city may become more attractive to relocating workers and businesses in the long term.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Boston-Cambridge-Newton is currently 51 days, with a year-over-year increase of 13.3%. This ranks in the 88th percentile, indicating a relatively slow market. For a worker relocating to this city, the slower market means that they may have more time to find a home and negotiate a better price, making the city more accessible to newcomers.

Office Economy

Boston-Cambridge-Newton has an office economy percentile rank of 56th, indicating a near-median depth of professional talent pool. This suggests that the city is suited for a variety of businesses, but may not have the same level of specialization as cities with a deeper talent pool. The city is likely well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, and consulting sectors, but may not be the best fit for industries that require a highly specialized workforce.

The Boston-Cambridge-Newton metro area offers businesses a unique combination of a growing labor force and expanding housing supply, making it an attractive location for companies looking to relocate or expand. However, the city's high cost of living and moderate wage growth rate may pose challenges for businesses trying to attract and retain talent, and the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers to factor in is the potential need to offer wage premiums to compete in this market.

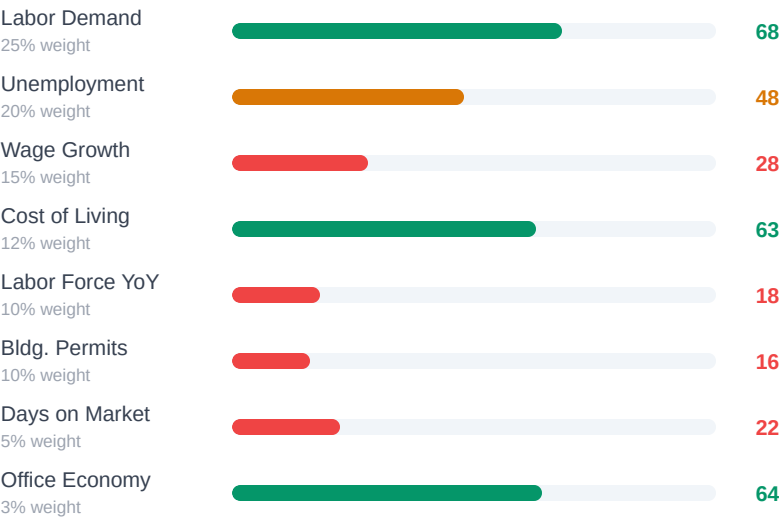
Denver

Denver-Aurora-Centennial

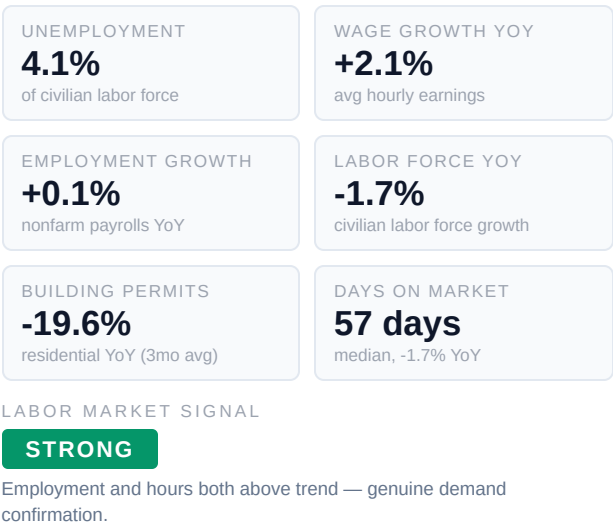
B-

BELOW AVERAGE
44.8th percentile
Rank 31 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Denver-Aurora-Centennial metro area has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking at the 44.8th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its labor demand, with a composite score at the 68th percentile, and its cost of living, which ranks at the 63rd percentile, indicating a relatively affordable environment. The labor demand and cost of living metrics are crucial in understanding the city's economic landscape, with employment growth at +0.10% and weekly hours deviation at +1.564%.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate of +0.10% and weekly hours deviation of +1.564% signal genuine demand expansion, as hours are running above trend during a period of job growth. This combination indicates that the city is experiencing a real increase in labor demand, rather than just a survivor squeeze where remaining workers absorb the load of eliminated roles. The labor demand composite score of 5.94 further supports this conclusion, ranking at the 68th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Denver-Aurora-Centennial is 4.10%, which is near the median, ranking at the 48th percentile. This rate suggests that the labor market has some slack, making it slightly easier for businesses to hire compared to extremely tight markets. However, the relatively low unemployment rate still implies some competition for talent, and businesses may need to offer competitive wages to attract workers.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate is +2.15%, which is below average, ranking at the 28th percentile. This moderate wage growth rate implies that labor costs for employers are rising, but not extremely rapidly. For workers, this wage growth rate translates to modest increases in purchasing power, which may not be sufficient to keep pace with cost of living increases in other cities.

Cost of Living

Denver-Aurora-Centennial has a cost of living percentile rank of 63, indicating that it is relatively affordable compared to its peers. The city's PSF of \$280/sqft, which is decreasing at a rate of -3.5% YoY, combined with an average hourly earnings of \$43.51/hr, results in a ratio of 6.44. This affordability advantage can be a significant talent attraction factor, as businesses may not need to offer substantial wage premiums to compensate for a high cost of living.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Denver-Aurora-Centennial is contracting at a rate of -1.67% year-over-year, ranking at the 18th percentile. This decline in labor force supply implies that the city's hiring capacity may be constrained, making it more challenging for businesses to find

and attract talent. The shrinking labor pool can be a structural headwind for companies looking to expand or establish operations in the area.

Building Permits

The city is experiencing a sharp decline in residential building permits, with a year-over-year change of -19.62%, ranking at the 16th percentile. This decrease in permits suggests that the housing supply is tightening, which may lead to future affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce. The decline in building permits is a concern for businesses that rely on a steady supply of housing for their employees.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 57 days, with a year-over-year decrease of -1.7%. This relatively fast market, ranking at the 22nd percentile, implies that homes are selling quickly, which can make it challenging for relocating workers to find housing. The fast-paced market may require workers to act rapidly when finding a home, which can be stressful and competitive.

Office Economy

Denver-Aurora-Centennial has a deep professional talent pool, with an office economy percentile rank of 64. This suggests that the city is well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, which require a high concentration of specialized knowledge workers. However, the city may be less suitable for industries that are more industrial or logistics-dominant, which require a different type of workforce.

The Denver-Aurora-Centennial metro area offers businesses a relatively affordable environment and a deep professional talent pool, making it an attractive location for certain types of companies. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's shrinking labor force and tightening housing supply, which may limit hiring capacity and create future affordability issues.

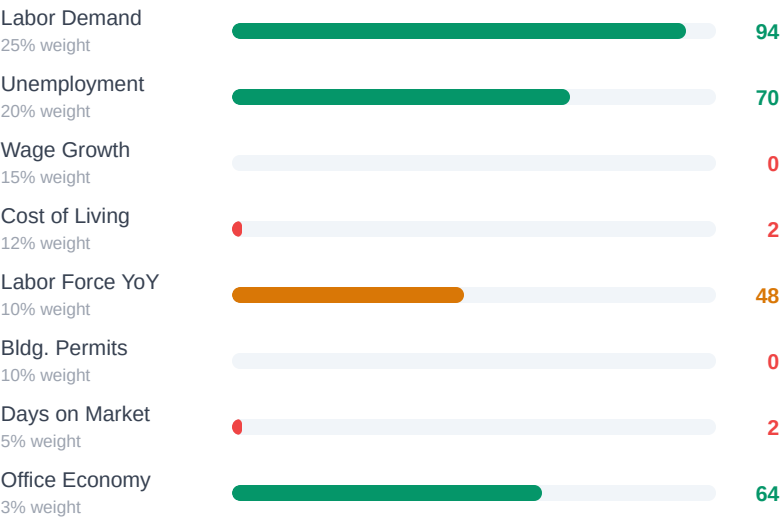
San Jose

San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara

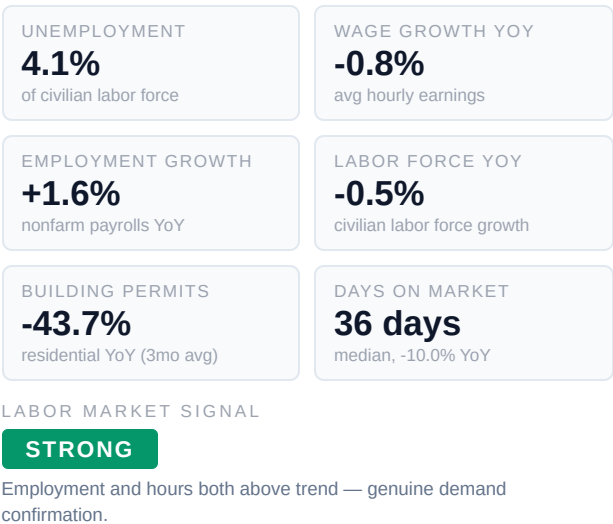
B-

BELOW AVERAGE
44.6th percentile
Rank 32 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara metro area has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking at the 44.6th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its strong labor demand, with a top-tier composite score of 94th percentile, and its extremely low wage growth, ranking at the 0th percentile with a -0.78% year-over-year change. The combination of these two metrics suggests a complex economic environment.

Labor Demand

The San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara metro area has an employment growth rate of +1.59% year-over-year and a weekly hours deviation of +1.289% from its own trend, indicating genuine demand expansion. This combination signals that the city is experiencing a period of job growth, with hours worked above the trend, suggesting that businesses are hiring and workers are in high demand. The labor demand composite score of 7.81 further reinforces this notion, ranking in the top tier at the 94th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in the San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara metro area is 4.10%, ranking at the 70th percentile, indicating a relatively tight labor market. This means that businesses may face challenges in finding available workers, and wage pressure may be higher due to the limited supply of labor. As a result, companies may need to offer competitive salaries to attract top talent in this market.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in the San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara metro area is -0.78%, ranking at the 0th percentile, indicating stagnant wage growth. This slow wage growth environment means that labor costs for employers are not rising rapidly, but it also implies that workers may have weaker bargaining power and lower purchasing power. As a result, businesses may not face significant pressure to increase wages, but workers may not have the same level of disposable income to drive local consumer demand.

Cost of Living

The San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara metro area has a cost of living ratio of \$811/sqft to \$54.03/hr, with a ratio of 15.01, ranking at the 2nd percentile, indicating that the city is extremely expensive relative to peers. With a year-over-year decrease in PSF of -1.3%, the city's affordability is not improving. This means that the city is at a significant disadvantage in terms of talent attraction, as workers may require wage premiums to afford the high cost of living, making it challenging for businesses to attract and retain top talent without offering significant compensation packages.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in the San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara metro area is growing at a rate of -0.48% year-over-year, ranking near the median at the 48th percentile, indicating a slightly contracting labor pool. This means that the supply of available workers is not expanding, which may pose a structural headwind for hiring and business growth in the area. As a result, companies may need to be more competitive in their hiring practices to attract the limited available talent.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in building permits in the San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara metro area is -43.67%, ranking at the 0th percentile, indicating a significant tightening of housing supply. This sharp decline in permits suggests that the city's housing supply is not expanding, which may lead to future affordability challenges and make it more difficult for workers to relocate to the area. As a result, businesses may face increased competition for a limited pool of available housing, driving up costs and making it harder to attract talent.

Days on Market

The current median days on market in the San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara metro area is 36 days, with a year-over-year decrease of -10.0%, ranking at the 2nd percentile, indicating a very competitive market. This means that homes are selling quickly, making it challenging for relocating workers to find available housing. As a result, businesses may need to offer relocation assistance or other incentives to help workers navigate this fast-paced and competitive housing market.

Office Economy

The San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara metro area has a deep professional talent pool, with an office/professional worker share of 2.92, ranking at the 64th percentile, indicating a strong presence of specialized roles. This makes the city well-suited for tech, finance, consulting, and HQ decisions, but less suited for industrial or logistics-dominant businesses. As a result, companies in these sectors may find it easier to attract and retain top talent in this city.

The San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara metro area offers businesses a strong labor demand environment, with a top-tier composite score, but also poses significant challenges, including extremely low wage growth, a high cost of living, and a tightening housing supply. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's extremely high cost of living, which may require businesses to offer significant wage premiums to attract and retain top talent, making it challenging to maintain a competitive edge in this market.

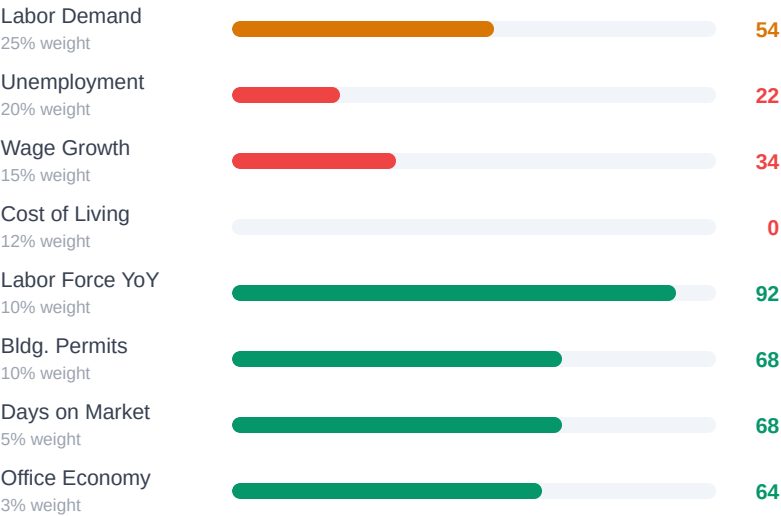
Providence

Providence-Warwick

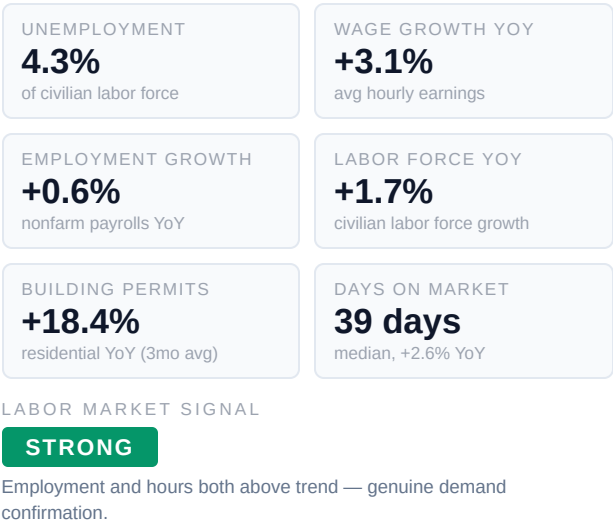
B-

BELOW AVERAGE
44.3th percentile
Rank 33 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Providence-Warwick metro area has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking it 44.3th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its high labor force growth rate of +1.69% YoY and its extremely low affordability score, with a cost of living ratio of 9.94, ranking it at the 0th percentile. The labor demand composite score of 5.47 also suggests a near median performance.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Providence-Warwick is +0.60% YoY, combined with a weekly hours deviation of +0.326% from its own trend, indicating a genuine demand expansion. This combination signals that the city is experiencing a moderate increase in jobs and hours worked, suggesting a growing economy. The near median percentile rank of 54th for labor demand composite score further supports this assessment.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Providence-Warwick is 4.30%, ranking it at the 22nd percentile, indicating a below average performance. This suggests that the labor market has some slack, making it relatively easier for businesses to hire workers. However, the practical implication is that the local consumer demand may be weaker compared to cities with lower unemployment rates.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Providence-Warwick is +3.09%, ranking it at the 34th percentile, indicating a below average performance. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but at a slower pace, and worker purchasing power is increasing, but not rapidly. This may lead to a relatively stable labor cost environment for businesses.

Cost of Living

Providence-Warwick has a cost of living ratio of 9.94, with PSF at \$362/sqft and hourly earnings at \$36.41/hr, ranking it at the 0th percentile, making it one of the most expensive cities relative to peers. This means that the city has a significant disadvantage in terms of talent attraction, as businesses may need to offer wage premiums to compensate for the high cost of living.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Providence-Warwick is growing at a rate of +1.69% YoY, ranking it at the 92nd percentile, indicating a top-tier performance. This suggests that the workforce supply is expanding rapidly, making it easier for businesses to find and hire workers. The implication is that the city has a strong hiring capacity, which can support business growth.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Providence-Warwick has increased by +18.42% YoY, ranking it at the 68th percentile, indicating an above average performance. This suggests that housing supply is expanding, which may lead to improved affordability and easier workforce accommodation in the future. This is a positive signal for businesses considering relocation or expansion.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Providence-Warwick is 39 days, with a YoY increase of +2.6%, ranking it at the 68th percentile. This suggests that the housing market is relatively accessible for workers relocating to the city, as homes are not selling extremely quickly. However, the rising days on market may indicate a normalization of the market, rather than a demand erosion.

Office Economy

Providence-Warwick has an office economy percentile rank of 64th, indicating an above average performance, with a share of professional and office workers at 2.92. This suggests that the city has a deep talent pool suited for tech, finance, consulting, and HQ decisions. However, it may be less suitable for industrial or logistics-dominant businesses.

The Providence-Warwick metro area offers businesses a unique combination of a growing labor force and expanding housing supply, making it an attractive location for companies looking to relocate or expand. However, the single biggest risk or constraint is the extremely high cost of living, which may require businesses to offer wage premiums to attract and retain talent, potentially increasing labor costs and affecting profitability.

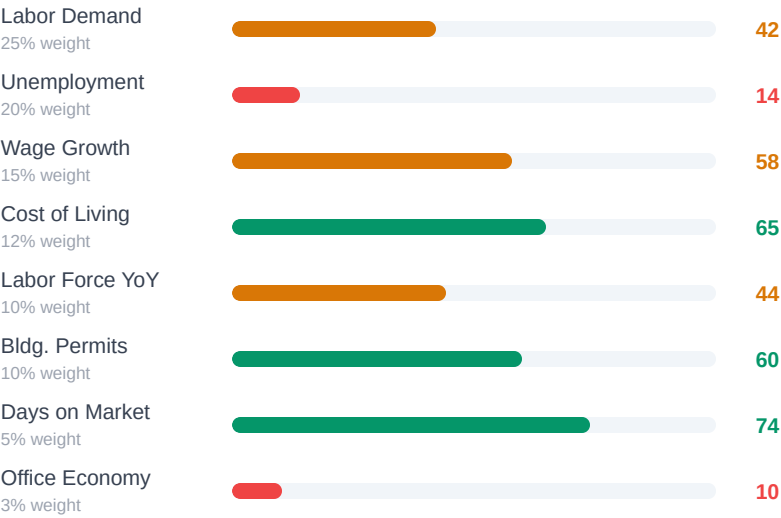
Oklahoma City

Oklahoma City

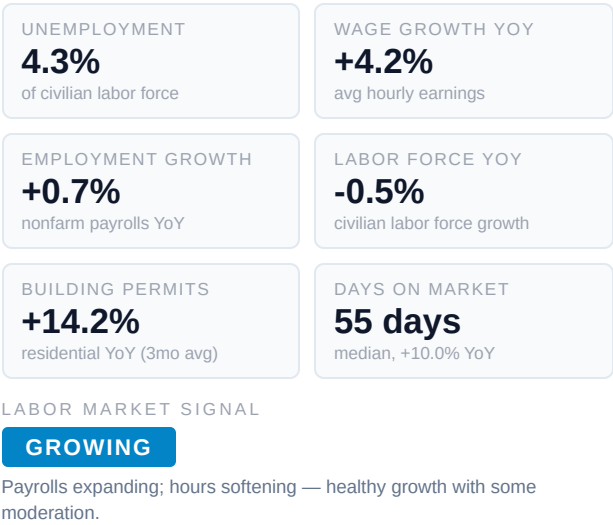
B-

BELOW AVERAGE
44.2th percentile
Rank 34 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0-100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Oklahoma City has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking it at the 44.2th percentile out of 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its near-median labor demand composite score of 5.17 and its bottom-tier unemployment rate of 4.30%, which signals a mix of modest job growth and significant labor market tightness. Specifically, the labor demand is driven by a +0.74% employment growth rate and a -0.163% weekly hours deviation from its own trend.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate of +0.74% and weekly hours deviation of -0.163% suggest a modest expansion in labor demand, but the combination of these metrics indicates that the city is experiencing a genuine demand expansion rather than a survivor squeeze. This is because the hours deviation is slightly negative, which means that the remaining workers are not absorbing a significantly increased load. The labor demand composite score of 5.17 ranks at the 42nd percentile, indicating a near-median performance.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate of 4.30% is relatively low, ranking at the 14th percentile, which means that the labor market is tight. This tightness implies that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the pool of available workers is smaller, and wage pressure may be higher. As a result, companies may need to offer competitive salaries to attract talent in this market.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate of +4.20% is moderate, ranking at the 58th percentile. This rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not excessively so. At the same time, workers are experiencing an increase in purchasing power, which can contribute to local consumer demand.

Cost of Living

Oklahoma City has a cost of living score that ranks at the 65th percentile, indicating that it is more affordable than many of its peer cities. The PSF to earnings ratio is \$171/sqft vs \$34.33/hr, resulting in a ratio of 4.98. This affordability can be a significant advantage for talent attraction, as workers may not require wage premiums to maintain their standard of living.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force is contracting at a rate of -0.50% year-over-year, which ranks at the 44th percentile. This contraction implies that the workforce supply is shrinking, presenting a structural headwind for hiring. Businesses may need to consider strategies to attract workers from other areas or invest in training and development programs.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits is +14.19%, ranking at the 60th percentile. This increase suggests that housing supply is expanding, which can improve affordability and accommodate a growing workforce. As a result, the city may become more attractive to workers and businesses alike.

Days on Market

The median days on market is 55 days, with a year-over-year increase of +10.0%, ranking at the 74th percentile. This indicates a slower market, where homes are sitting longer before being sold. For workers relocating to this city, this can be a competitive advantage, as they may have more time to find a suitable home.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers is 0.80, ranking at the 10th percentile, indicating a relatively shallow talent pool in these sectors. This suggests that Oklahoma City is less suited for businesses that require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as tech, finance, or consulting firms, but may be more suitable for industries with different workforce requirements.

In conclusion, Oklahoma City offers a mix of modest job growth, tight labor market, and affordable cost of living, making it an attractive location for businesses that can navigate its workforce challenges. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's shrinking labor force supply, which may require innovative strategies to attract and retain talent.

Portland

Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro

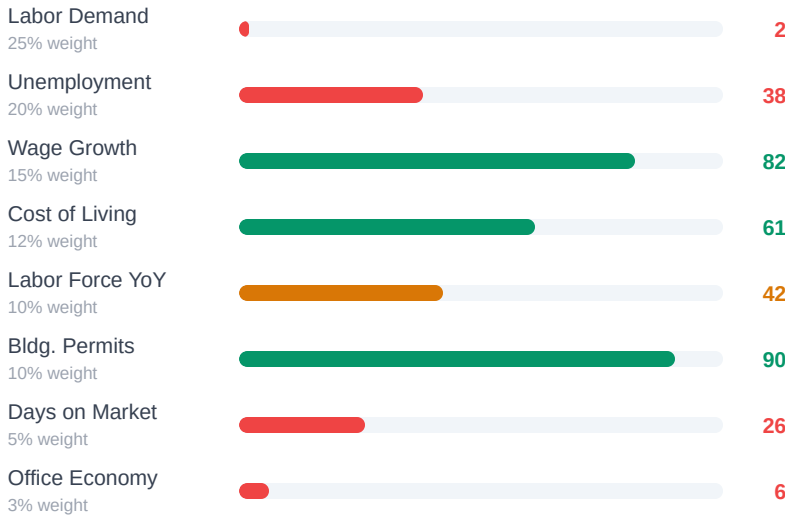
C+

POOR

42.4th percentile

Rank 35 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

4.9%

of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+5.7%

avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

-1.5%

nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE YOY

-0.6%

civilian labor force growth

BUILDING PERMITS

+32.3%

residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

61 days

median, +1.7% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

SQUEEZE

6 Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro metro area has an overall grade of C+ with a composite score ranking it 42.4th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its weak labor demand, with a labor demand composite score in the bottom tier, and strong wage growth, with a year-over-year increase of 5.68%. The combination of these metrics suggests a challenging environment for businesses looking to hire and expand.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro is -1.52% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating from the trend by +0.368%. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, indicating that the city is experiencing a decline in job creation. The positive deviation in weekly hours may suggest a survivor squeeze, where remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro is 4.90%, ranking it in the 38th percentile, indicating a below-average level of slack in the labor market. This means that the market is relatively tight, making it harder for businesses to hire new employees. As a result, businesses may face upward pressure on wages to attract and retain talent.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro is 5.68%, ranking it in the 82nd percentile, indicating fast wage growth. This rapid increase in wages implies rising labor costs for employers, but also stronger purchasing power for workers. Businesses should factor in the potential for higher labor costs when considering this location.

Cost of Living

Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro has a cost of living score ranking it in the 61st percentile, with a price-to-salary ratio of \$304/sqft to \$42.52/hr, resulting in a ratio of 7.15. This indicates that the city is relatively affordable compared to its peers. The fact that PSF is falling by 2.2% year-over-year further supports this assessment. This affordability can be a talent attraction advantage, as businesses may not need to offer wage premiums to compensate for high living costs.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro is growing at a rate of -0.58% year-over-year, indicating a contracting labor pool. This decline in labor force growth poses a structural headwind for hiring, making it more challenging for businesses to find and recruit new employees.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro is increasing by 32.26% year-over-year, indicating an expansion in housing supply. This growth in building permits suggests that developer confidence is strong, and future housing supply is likely to improve, which can lead to better affordability and accommodation for the workforce.

Days on Market

The current median days on market in Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro is 61 days, with a year-over-year increase of 1.7%. This indicates a relatively slow market, making it more accessible for workers relocating to the city. However, the rising days on market may also signal a normalization of the housing market, rather than a demand erosion.

Office Economy

Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro has a professional and office worker share ranking it in the 6th percentile, indicating a relatively shallow talent pool in these sectors. This city is best suited for businesses that do not require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as industrial or logistics-dominant companies, and less suited for tech, finance, or consulting firms.

The Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro metro area offers a unique combination of strong wage growth and relatively affordable cost of living, making it an attractive location for businesses that can navigate its tight labor market. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the weak labor demand and contracting labor force, which may limit the city's ability to support long-term business expansion and growth.

San Diego

San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad

C+

POOR

41.6th percentile

Rank 36 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand 25% weight		52
Unemployment 20% weight		42
Wage Growth 15% weight		94
Cost of Living 12% weight		14
Labor Force YoY 10% weight		12
Bldg. Permits 10% weight		2
Days on Market 5% weight		28
Office Economy 3% weight		52

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT of civilian labor force 4.7%	WAGE GROWTH YOY +7.5% avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH nonfarm payrolls YoY +0.7%	LABOR FORCE YOY -1.8% civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS residential YoY (3mo avg) -36.4%	DAYS ON MARKET median, 0.0% YoY 45 days
LABOR MARKET SIGNAL STRONG Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.	

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad metro area has an overall grade of C+ with a composite score ranking it 41.6th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its high wage growth rate of 7.50% year-over-year and its low cost of living affordability score, ranking it in the 14th percentile. The combination of these two metrics suggests a city with rising labor costs but a challenging environment for attracting talent due to high costs.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad is 0.70% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating 0.152% above the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a genuine demand expansion, as both jobs and hours are increasing, indicating a growing economy. However, the near-median percentile rank of 52nd suggests that this growth is not exceptionally strong compared to other metros.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad is 4.70%, ranking it in the 42nd percentile, which indicates a near-median level of slack in the labor market. This rate suggests that the market is not overly tight, but it is also not extremely slack, making it moderately challenging for businesses to hire. The practical implication is that businesses may face some competition for talent, but it is still possible to find qualified workers.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad is 7.50%, ranking it in the 94th percentile, indicating fast and rising labor costs. This implies that employers will face increasing costs, but workers will have strong purchasing power, which can be beneficial for businesses relying on local consumer demand. The high wage growth rate suggests that businesses may need to adjust their compensation packages to remain competitive.

Cost of Living

San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad has a cost of living score ranking it in the 14th percentile, with a PSF of \$594/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$44.28/hr, resulting in a ratio of 13.41. This indicates that the city is relatively expensive, making it challenging to attract talent without offering wage premiums. The -2.8% year-over-year change in PSF suggests that housing costs are decreasing, but the city's overall affordability remains low.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad is contracting at a rate of -1.75% year-over-year, ranking it in the 12th percentile. This indicates that the labor force supply is shrinking, which can create a structural headwind for hiring and may limit the city's ability to support business growth. The implication is that businesses may face increasing competition for a decreasing pool of workers.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits in San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad is -36.38%, ranking it in the 2nd percentile. This suggests that housing supply is tightening, which can lead to decreased affordability and increased competition for workforce accommodation. The sharp decline in building permits signals a potential supply squeeze, making it essential for businesses to consider the long-term implications for their workforce.

Days on Market

The current median days on market in San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad is 45 days, with a 0.0% year-over-year change, ranking it in the 28th percentile. This indicates a moderately competitive market, neither extremely fast nor slow. For a worker relocating to this city, the market is relatively accessible, but the lack of change in days on market suggests a stable, rather than improving, environment.

Office Economy

San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad has an office economy score ranking it in the 52nd percentile, with a share of professional and office workers indicating a moderately deep talent pool. This city is best suited for businesses that can leverage its existing professional workforce, such as tech, finance, or consulting firms, but may not be ideal for industries requiring a large, unskilled labor force.

The San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad metro area offers businesses a unique combination of high wage growth and a challenging cost of living environment. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's shrinking labor force supply, which can limit business growth and create competition for talent. This factor should be carefully considered when evaluating the city as a potential location for business operations.

Sacramento

Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom

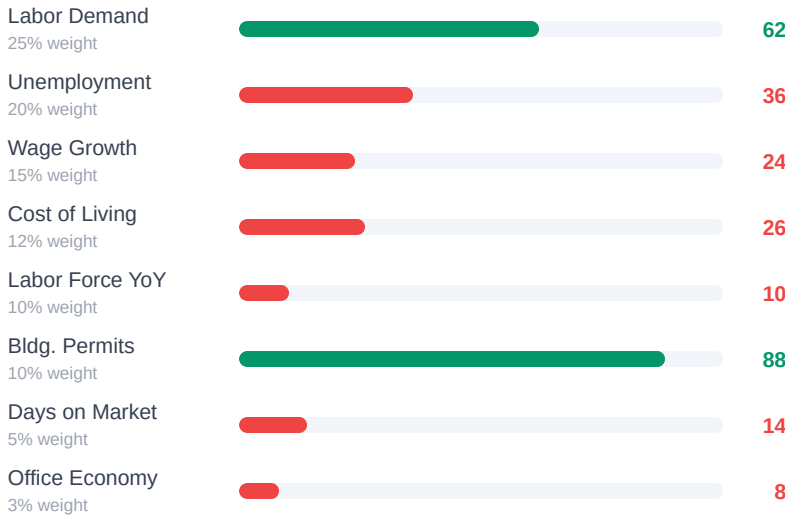
C+

POOR

40.2th percentile

Rank 37 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

5.0%

of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+2.0%

avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

+0.8%

nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE YOY

-1.9%

civilian labor force growth

BUILDING PERMITS

+30.2%

residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

50 days

median, -2.0% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom metro area has an overall grade of C+ with a composite score ranking it 40.2th percentile out of 50 metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its labor demand, with a composite score of 5.87 ranking it in the 62nd percentile, and its cost of living, which is in the 26th percentile due to a PSF to wages ratio of 8.82. The labor demand and cost of living metrics suggest a city with genuine demand expansion but limited affordability.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom is +0.76% year-over-year, combined with a +0.508% deviation in weekly hours from its own trend, signaling genuine demand expansion. This combination indicates that the city is adding jobs and workers are putting in more hours, suggesting a strong labor market. The labor demand composite score of 5.87 further supports this, ranking the city in the 62nd percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom is 5.00%, ranking it in the 36th percentile, indicating a market with some slack. This means that businesses may find it relatively easier to hire workers, but the local consumer demand may be weaker due to the higher unemployment rate. The practical implication for a business trying to hire here is that it may have a larger pool of potential candidates to choose from.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom is +2.02%, ranking it in the 24th percentile, indicating stagnant wage growth. This slow wage growth means that employer labor costs are not rising rapidly, but worker purchasing power is also not increasing significantly. As a result, businesses may not face significant pressure to increase wages, but workers may not have strong bargaining power.

Cost of Living

Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom has a cost of living percentile rank of 26, with a PSF to wages ratio of 8.82, indicating that the city is relatively expensive. The PSF is \$339/sqft, which has decreased by 0.9% year-over-year, but the city's affordability is still a concern. This means that businesses may need to offer wage premiums to attract talent, as the high cost of living may be a deterrent for some workers.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom is contracting at a rate of -1.92% year-over-year, ranking it in the 10th percentile. This decline in labor force supply means that businesses may face structural headwinds when trying to hire, as the pool of potential

workers is shrinking. The implication for hiring capacity is that businesses may need to be more competitive in their recruitment efforts.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom has increased by 30.25% year-over-year, ranking it in the 88th percentile. This rapid expansion of housing supply suggests that the city is experiencing a surge in developer confidence, which may lead to improved affordability and a more attractive environment for workers. As a result, businesses may find it easier to accommodate a growing workforce in the future.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom is 50 days, with a year-over-year decrease of 2.0%. This relatively fast pace of home sales suggests that the market is competitive, and workers relocating to the city may face challenges in finding a home. The low percentile rank of 14 indicates that the market is hot, and businesses may need to consider this when recruiting workers from other areas.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers in Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom is 0.78, ranking it in the 8th percentile. This indicates that the city has a relatively shallow talent pool in these sectors, making it less suited for businesses that require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as tech or finance companies. However, the city may be more attractive to businesses in industries that are less dependent on specialized office workers.

The Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom metro area offers businesses a labor market with genuine demand expansion, but its high cost of living and limited affordability may require wage premiums to attract talent. The single biggest risk or constraint for businesses in this city is the declining labor force supply, which may lead to structural headwinds in hiring and recruitment efforts.

Memphis

Memphis

C+

POOR

40.1th percentile

Rank 38 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand 25% weight		4
Unemployment 20% weight		40
Wage Growth 15% weight		68
Cost of Living 12% weight		98
Labor Force YoY 10% weight		34
Bldg. Permits 10% weight		52
Days on Market 5% weight		8
Office Economy 3% weight		4

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT of civilian labor force 4.7%	WAGE GROWTH YOY avg hourly earnings +4.5%
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH nonfarm payrolls YoY -0.5%	LABOR FORCE YOY civilian labor force growth -0.9%
BUILDING PERMITS residential YoY (3mo avg) +5.4%	DAYS ON MARKET median, +6.2% YoY 68 days
LABOR MARKET SIGNAL SQUEEZE Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.	

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The city of Memphis has an overall grade of C+ with a composite score ranking it 40.1th percentile out of 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its low labor demand, with a composite score of 2.11, and its high cost of living affordability, with a ratio of \$153/sqft to \$33.22/hr, ranking in the top tier at the 98th percentile. The labor demand and cost of living metrics are crucial in understanding the city's current economic state, with the labor demand indicating a contraction and the cost of living suggesting an attractive environment for talent.

Labor Demand

Memphis has an employment growth rate of -0.49% and a weekly hours deviation of +1.586% from its own trend. This combination signals a survivor squeeze, where remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles, rather than genuine demand expansion. The low labor demand composite score of 2.11, ranking in the bottom tier at the 4th percentile, further supports this conclusion.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Memphis is 4.70%, ranking near the median at the 40th percentile. This indicates a relatively balanced market with some slack, making it easier for businesses to hire compared to extremely tight markets. However, the practical implication for a business trying to hire in Memphis is that it may not face extreme wage pressure, but it still needs to compete for talent.

Wage Growth

Memphis has a year-over-year wage growth rate of +4.52%, ranking above average at the 68th percentile. This indicates moderate to fast wage growth, which implies rising labor costs for employers but increased purchasing power for workers. As a result, businesses in Memphis may need to adjust their compensation packages to remain competitive.

Cost of Living

Memphis has a cost of living ratio of \$153/sqft to \$33.22/hr, with the price per square foot falling by -4.4% year-over-year. With a top-tier ranking at the 98th percentile, the city is highly affordable relative to its peers. This means that Memphis has a significant talent attraction advantage, as it can offer a lower cost of living without requiring wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Memphis is contracting at a rate of -0.92% year-over-year, ranking below average at the 34th percentile. This indicates a shrinking labor pool, which poses a structural headwind for hiring and may limit the city's ability to support rapid business growth.

Building Permits

Memphis has a year-over-year change in building permits of +5.41%, ranking near the median at the 52nd percentile. This suggests that housing supply is expanding, which may improve affordability and support workforce accommodation in the future. However, the current pace of growth is moderate, and it remains to be seen whether it will be sufficient to meet demand.

Days on Market

The current median days on market in Memphis is 68 days, with a year-over-year increase of +6.2%. This indicates a slower market, ranking in the bottom tier at the 8th percentile. For a worker relocating to Memphis, this means that the housing market is relatively accessible, with fewer bidding wars and more time to find a suitable home.

Office Economy

Memphis has a professional and office worker share of 0.50, ranking in the bottom tier at the 4th percentile. This indicates a relatively shallow talent pool, making the city less suited for businesses that require a deep knowledge-economy workforce, such as tech or finance companies. However, Memphis may be more suitable for industries with fewer specialized roles, such as logistics or manufacturing.

The city of Memphis offers businesses an attractive cost of living and a relatively balanced labor market, but it is constrained by low labor demand and a shrinking labor force. The single biggest risk or constraint for a decision-maker is the limited capacity for rapid business growth due to the contracting labor pool, which may require businesses to invest in talent development or relocation incentives to attract and retain workers.

Minneapolis

Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington

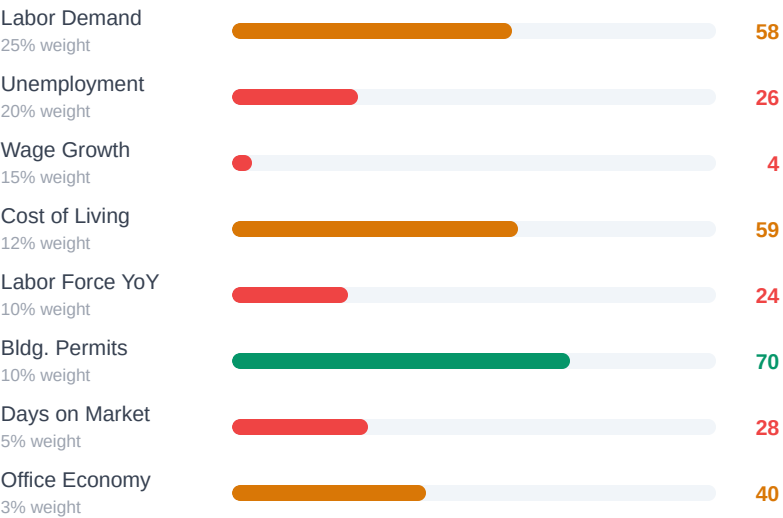
C+

POOR

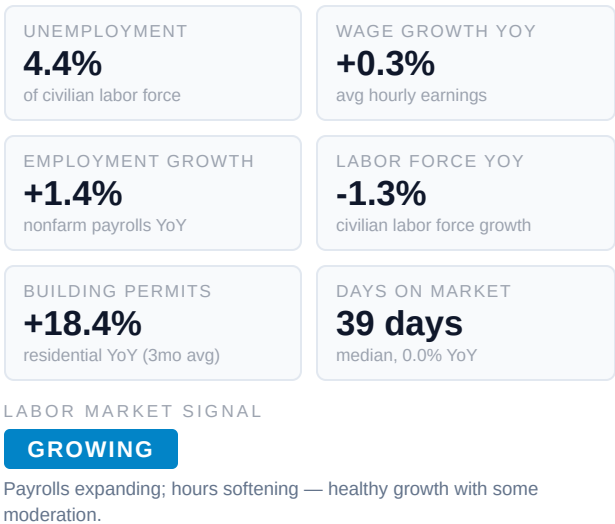
39.4th percentile

Rank 39 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington metro area has an overall grade of C+ with a composite score ranking it at the 39.4th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its near-median labor demand composite score of 5.57 and its bottom-tier wage growth of +0.27% year-over-year. The combination of these metrics suggests a mixed economic environment, with labor demand driven more by hours worked than job growth.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington is +1.39% year-over-year, while weekly hours are -0.671% below the city's own 12-month trend. This combination signals a labor market that is not experiencing genuine demand expansion, as the growth in jobs is not accompanied by an increase in hours worked, indicating some level of survivor squeeze where remaining workers may be absorbing the load of eliminated roles.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington is 4.40%, ranking it at the 26th percentile, indicating a market with some slack. This means that while it may not be extremely difficult for a business to hire here, the labor market is not as tight as in other cities, potentially leading to less wage pressure but also weaker local consumer demand.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington is +0.27%, placing it in the bottom tier at the 4th percentile. This stagnant wage growth environment suggests that labor costs for employers are not rising quickly, but it also means that worker purchasing power is not increasing significantly, which could impact consumer demand and the overall attractiveness of the area for talent.

Cost of Living

Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington has a cost of living score that ranks it at the 59th percentile, with a PSF of \$208/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$40.75, resulting in a ratio of 5.10. The fact that PSF is falling by -1.9% year-over-year contributes to the city being relatively more affordable compared to its peers. This affordability could be a talent attraction advantage, as workers may not require significant wage premiums to maintain their standard of living.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington is shrinking at a rate of -1.32% year-over-year, indicating a contracting labor supply. This contraction poses a structural headwind for hiring, as the pool of available workers is decreasing, which could challenge businesses looking to expand their workforce in the area.

Building Permits

The city has seen an increase of +18.45% year-over-year in residential building permits, ranking it at the 70th percentile. This rise in permits suggests that housing supply is expanding, which could lead to improved affordability and a more accommodating environment for the workforce in the future.

Days on Market

Homes in Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington are currently sitting on the market for a median of 39 days, with no year-over-year change. This relatively fast market, ranking at the 28th percentile, indicates that homes are selling quickly, which could make it challenging for relocating workers to find housing, potentially affecting a business's ability to attract talent.

Office Economy

The share of jobs in professional and office sectors in Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington ranks at the 40th percentile, indicating a moderately deep talent pool in these areas. This makes the city more suited for businesses in tech, finance, consulting, and HQ operations, but less ideal for those in industrial or logistics-dominant sectors.

The Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington metro offers a mixed bag for businesses, with affordability and expanding housing supply as positives, but stagnant wage growth, a shrinking labor force, and a relatively slow pace of labor demand growth as negatives. The single biggest risk or constraint for a decision-maker to factor in is the challenge posed by the contracting labor supply, which could significantly impact hiring capacity and business expansion plans.

Milwaukee

Milwaukee-Waukesha

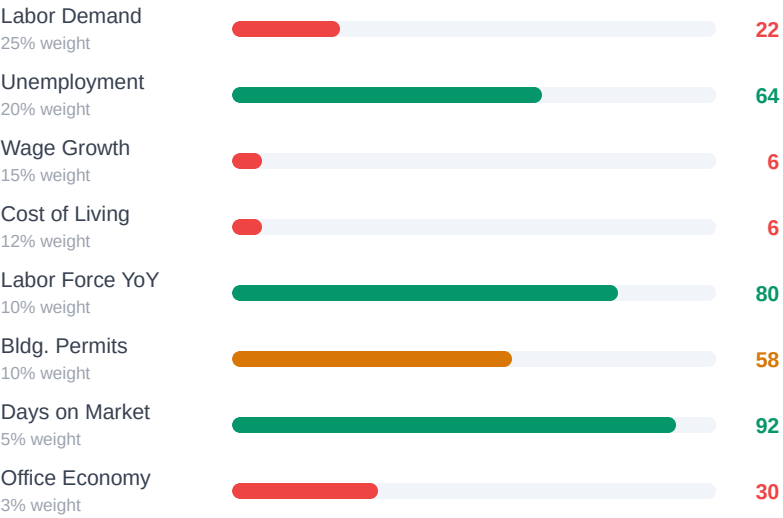
C+

POOR

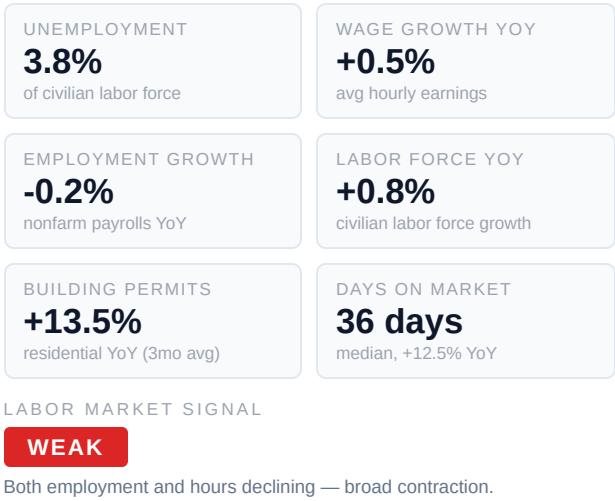
39.2th percentile

Rank 40 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Milwaukee-Waukesha metro area has an overall grade of C+ with a composite score ranking it 39.2th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its low labor demand, with a composite score of 3.95, and its stagnant wage growth, at +0.52% year-over-year. These metrics signal a challenging environment for businesses looking to expand or relocate.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Milwaukee-Waukesha is -0.25% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating -1.588% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, indicating that the city is not adding jobs at a significant rate and existing workers are seeing reduced hours. This scenario suggests a lack of genuine demand expansion.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Milwaukee-Waukesha is 3.80%, ranking it 64th percentile, which means the market has some slack. This rate implies that while it may not be extremely difficult to hire, there is still a pool of available workers, and businesses may not face intense wage pressure. However, the relatively low unemployment rate compared to other metrics suggests a nuanced labor market.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Milwaukee-Waukesha is +0.52%, placing it in the bottom tier at the 6th percentile. This stagnant wage growth indicates that labor costs for employers are not rising significantly, but it also means workers have weak bargaining power and limited purchasing power. This could affect the overall attractiveness of the city for talent.

Cost of Living

Milwaukee-Waukesha has a cost of living score that ranks it in the bottom tier at the 6th percentile, with a PSF to earnings ratio of \$227/sqft to \$35.76/hr, or 6.35. This indicates that the city is relatively expensive compared to its peers, which could make it challenging to attract talent without offering wage premiums. The 2.2% year-over-year increase in PSF further exacerbates the affordability issue.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Milwaukee-Waukesha is growing at a rate of +0.85% year-over-year, placing it in the top tier at the 80th percentile. This expansion in labor force supply is a positive sign for businesses looking to hire, as it indicates a growing pool of potential workers. However, the city's other labor market challenges may still pose hurdles.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Milwaukee-Waukesha has increased by +13.52% year-over-year, ranking near the median at the 58th percentile. This growth in permits suggests that housing supply is expanding, which could improve affordability and accommodate

a growing workforce. However, the pace of growth is not exceptionally high, which may not fully address the city's affordability challenges.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Milwaukee-Waukesha is 36 days, with a year-over-year increase of +12.5%, placing it in the top tier at the 92nd percentile. This indicates a slower market where homes are sitting longer before being sold, which could make it more accessible for relocating workers to find housing. However, this also signals a less competitive market, which may have implications for the local economy.

Office Economy

Milwaukee-Waukesha has an office economy score that ranks it below average at the 30th percentile, with a share of professional and office workers indicating a less deep talent pool. This suggests that the city is less suited for businesses requiring a high concentration of tech, finance, or consulting talent but may be more appropriate for industries with different workforce needs.

The Milwaukee-Waukesha metro area offers businesses a growing labor force and an expanding housing supply, but it is constrained by low labor demand, stagnant wage growth, and a relatively high cost of living. The single biggest risk or constraint for a decision-maker is the city's challenging labor market conditions, which could make it difficult to attract and retain talent without significant wage premiums.

Virginia Beach

Virginia Beach-Chesapeake-Norfolk

C

VERY POOR

37.8th percentile

Rank 41 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand		14
25% weight		
Unemployment		46
20% weight		
Wage Growth		78
15% weight		
Cost of Living		47
12% weight		
Labor Force YoY		36
10% weight		
Bldg. Permits		28
10% weight		
Days on Market		12
5% weight		
Office Economy		24
3% weight		

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT of civilian labor force 3.9%	WAGE GROWTH YOY avg hourly earnings +5.5%
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH nonfarm payrolls YoY -0.6%	LABOR FORCE YOY civilian labor force growth -0.9%
BUILDING PERMITS residential YoY (3mo avg) -10.4%	DAYS ON MARKET median, -2.4% YoY 40 days
LABOR MARKET SIGNAL SQUEEZE Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.	

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Virginia Beach-Chesapeake-Norfolk metro area has an overall grade of C, ranking 37.8th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a labor demand composite score of 3.36, placing it in the bottom tier. The city's economic character is most defined by its weak labor demand, with a -0.55% employment growth rate, and moderate wage growth of 5.51% year-over-year. These metrics signal a challenging environment for businesses looking to expand or relocate.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Virginia Beach-Chesapeake-Norfolk is -0.55% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating from the trend by +0.174%. This combination signals a survivor squeeze, where remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles, rather than genuine demand expansion. This indicates a contraction in the labor market, which may lead to difficulties in finding skilled workers.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Virginia Beach-Chesapeake-Norfolk is 3.90%, placing it near the median at the 46th percentile. This suggests that the labor market has some slack, making it slightly easier for businesses to hire workers. However, the relatively low unemployment rate may still lead to some wage pressure, as workers have more bargaining power.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Virginia Beach-Chesapeake-Norfolk is 5.51%, which is above average, ranking at the 78th percentile. This signals strong wage growth, leading to rising labor costs for employers, but also increasing worker purchasing power. Businesses may need to factor in higher labor costs when considering relocation or expansion in this area.

Cost of Living

The cost of living in Virginia Beach-Chesapeake-Norfolk is near the median, with a percentile rank of 47th, and a PSF to earnings ratio of \$224/sqft to \$35.71/hr, resulting in a ratio of 6.27. The city's cost of living is not particularly affordable, as the PSF is rising by 3.2% year-over-year. This may make it challenging for businesses to attract talent without offering wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Virginia Beach-Chesapeake-Norfolk is contracting at a rate of -0.91% year-over-year, indicating a shrinking labor pool. This signals a structural headwind for hiring, as the supply of workers is decreasing, making it more difficult for businesses to find skilled workers.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Virginia Beach-Chesapeake-Norfolk is decreasing by 10.45% year-over-year, indicating a tightening of the housing supply. This signals a potential supply squeeze, which may lead to decreased affordability and make it more challenging for workers to relocate to the area.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Virginia Beach-Chesapeake-Norfolk is 40 days, with a year-over-year decrease of 2.4%. This suggests a relatively fast-paced market, which may make it challenging for relocating workers to find housing. The low days on market percentile rank of 12th indicates a competitive market, where homes are selling quickly.

Office Economy

The professional and office worker share in Virginia Beach-Chesapeake-Norfolk is below average, ranking at the 24th percentile. This indicates a relatively shallow talent pool, making the city less suited for businesses that require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as tech or finance companies. However, the city may be more suitable for industrial or logistics-dominant businesses.

The Virginia Beach-Chesapeake-Norfolk metro area offers businesses a mix of moderate wage growth and a relatively low unemployment rate, but is constrained by weak labor demand and a tightening housing supply. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the challenging labor market, which may lead to difficulties in finding skilled workers and increasing labor costs.

Riverside

Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario

C

VERY POOR

34.2th percentile

Rank 42 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand		44
25% weight		
Unemployment		14
20% weight		
Wage Growth		78
15% weight		
Cost of Living		29
12% weight		
Labor Force YoY		12
10% weight		
Bldg. Permits		14
10% weight		
Days on Market		54
5% weight		
Office Economy		0
3% weight		

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT 5.7% of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY +5.5% avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH +0.8% nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY -1.8% civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS -20.0% residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET 63 days median, -4.5% YoY
LABOR MARKET SIGNAL GROWING Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.	

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario metro area has an overall grade of C, ranking 34.2th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a labor demand composite score of 5.20. This city's economic character is most defined by its high wage growth rate of +5.51% year-over-year and its low unemployment rate of 5.70%, which signals a tight labor market. The combination of these metrics suggests a challenging hiring environment for businesses.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario is +0.75% year-over-year, while weekly hours are deviating -0.149% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a moderate labor demand expansion, with some genuine demand for jobs but not excessively high. The labor demand composite score of 5.20 is near the median, indicating a balanced job market.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario is 5.70%, which is relatively high and ranks in the bottom tier at the 14th percentile. This suggests that the labor market has some slack, making it easier for businesses to hire workers. However, the practical implication is that local consumer demand may be weaker due to the higher unemployment rate.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario is +5.51%, which is above average and ranks in the 78th percentile. This indicates fast wage growth, which will lead to rising labor costs for employers but also increase worker purchasing power. Businesses should factor in higher labor costs when considering this location.

Cost of Living

Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario has a cost of living ratio of \$332/sqft to \$35.45/hr, with a percentile rank of 29th, indicating that the city is relatively expensive. The PSF is falling -1.2% year-over-year, but this is not enough to offset the high cost of living. This means that businesses may need to offer wage premiums to attract talent, as the city's affordability is below average.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario is contracting at a rate of -1.75% year-over-year, which is in the bottom tier at the 12th percentile. This indicates that the labor force supply is shrinking, creating a structural headwind for hiring and business expansion. Businesses should be cautious when considering this location due to the limited labor pool.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario is falling -19.99% year-over-year, which is in the bottom tier at the 14th percentile. This suggests that housing supply is tightening, which may lead to future affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce. Businesses should consider the potential impact on employee relocation and retention.

Days on Market

The median days on market in Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario is 63 days, with a year-over-year decrease of -4.5%. This indicates a relatively fast-paced market, making it challenging for relocating workers to find housing. The near-median percentile rank of 54th suggests that the market is competitive, but not excessively so.

Office Economy

Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario has a very low share of professional and office workers, ranking in the 0th percentile. This indicates a shallow talent pool for businesses requiring specialized knowledge-economy workers, making it less suitable for tech, finance, or consulting companies. However, it may be more suitable for industrial or logistics-dominant businesses.

The Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario metro area offers businesses a unique combination of high wage growth and a relatively tight labor market, but the single biggest risk or constraint is the shrinking labor force supply and tightening housing market. Decision-makers should carefully consider these factors when evaluating this location for business expansion or relocation, as they may impact hiring capacity and employee retention. Overall, the city's economic character is complex, and businesses should weigh the pros and cons carefully before making a decision.

Richmond

Richmond

C

VERY POOR

33.8th percentile

Rank 43 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand 25% weight		8
Unemployment 20% weight		54
Wage Growth 15% weight		30
Cost of Living 12% weight		22
Labor Force YoY 10% weight		32
Bldg. Permits 10% weight		96
Days on Market 5% weight		6
Office Economy 3% weight		22

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT 3.8% of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY +2.4% avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH -0.8% nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY -0.9% civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS +83.8% residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET 44 days median, -4.3% YoY
LABOR MARKET SIGNAL SQUEEZE Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.	

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Richmond metro area has an overall grade of C, ranking 33.8th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a labor demand composite score of 2.93, placing it in the bottom tier. The city's economic character is most defined by its low labor demand and high building permit growth, with employment growth at -0.82% year-over-year and building permits increasing by 83.77% year-over-year. These metrics signal a complex economic environment, with both challenges and opportunities for businesses.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Richmond is -0.82% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating from the trend by +0.219%. This combination signals a survivor squeeze, where remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles, rather than genuine demand expansion. This indicates a challenging labor market for businesses looking to hire and expand.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Richmond is 3.80%, placing it near the median at the 54th percentile. This suggests a relatively balanced labor market, neither extremely tight nor slack. For businesses trying to hire, this means they may face moderate competition for talent, but not extreme wage pressure.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Richmond is +2.40%, which is below average, ranking at the 30th percentile. This moderate wage growth rate implies that labor costs for employers are rising, but not rapidly, and worker purchasing power is increasing, but not strongly. This may impact businesses' ability to attract and retain talent.

Cost of Living

Richmond has a cost of living score that places it at the 22nd percentile, with a PSF of \$228/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$35.92, resulting in a ratio of 6.35. This indicates that the city is relatively expensive, making it challenging for businesses to attract talent without offering wage premiums. The fact that PSF is increasing by 1.8% year-over-year further exacerbates this issue.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Richmond is contracting at a rate of -0.94% year-over-year. This means that the workforce supply is shrinking, creating a structural headwind for hiring and business expansion. Businesses may need to consider strategies to attract talent from other areas or invest in workforce development programs.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Richmond is increasing by 83.77% year-over-year, which is a top-tier growth rate. This signals that housing supply is expanding, which may improve affordability and accommodation for the workforce in the future. However, this growth may also lead to increased construction costs and potential disruptions to the local economy.

Days on Market

The median days on market in Richmond is currently 44 days, with a year-over-year decrease of -4.3%. This indicates a relatively fast-paced market, making it challenging for relocating workers to find housing. Businesses may need to consider offering relocation assistance or flexible housing options to attract talent.

Office Economy

Richmond's professional and office worker share is below average, ranking at the 22nd percentile. This suggests that the city has a relatively shallow talent pool for businesses in the tech, finance, or consulting sectors. However, the city may be more suitable for businesses in industrial or logistics sectors, which can leverage the local workforce's skills and expertise.

The Richmond metro area presents a mixed bag of opportunities and challenges for businesses, with a growing housing supply and relatively balanced labor market, but also a shrinking workforce and moderate wage growth. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's relatively expensive cost of living, which may require businesses to offer wage premiums to attract and retain talent.

Indianapolis

Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood

C

VERY POOR

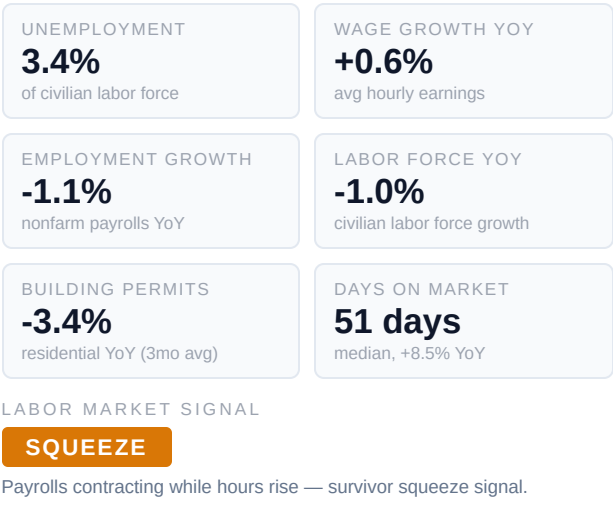
32.8th percentile

Rank 44 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

SQUEEZE

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood metro area has an overall grade of C, ranking 32.8th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its low labor demand and stagnant wage growth. The city's labor demand composite score of 2.36, combining a -1.05% employment growth rate and a +0.471% weekly hours deviation, signals a contraction in labor demand. This, coupled with a low wage growth rate of +0.58%, defines the city's current economic character.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood is -1.05% year-over-year, while weekly hours are running +0.471% above the city's own 12-month trend. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, rather than genuine demand expansion or survivor squeeze, indicating that the city is not adding jobs at a pace that would suggest strong labor market health. The labor demand composite score of 2.36 falls in the bottom tier, at the 6th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood is 3.40%, which ranks in the top tier at the 88th percentile, indicating a tight labor market with low unemployment. This means that businesses trying to hire in this city may face challenges in finding available workers, leading to potential wage pressure. The low unemployment rate suggests that the labor market has slack, but not as much as other cities.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood is +0.58%, which is relatively stagnant and falls in the bottom tier at the 8th percentile. This slow wage growth implies that labor costs for employers are not rising quickly, but it also means that workers have weak bargaining power and limited purchasing power growth. As a result, businesses may not face significant labor cost increases, but workers may not have the disposable income to drive local consumer demand.

Cost of Living

Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood has a cost of living score that ranks in the bottom tier at the 12th percentile, with a PSF of \$165/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$33.86/hr, resulting in a ratio of 4.87. This indicates that the city is relatively expensive compared to its peers, which could make it challenging to attract talent without offering wage premiums. The fact that PSF is rising +4.4% year-over-year relative to wages further exacerbates the affordability issue.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood is shrinking at a rate of -0.99% year-over-year, which falls below average at the 28th percentile. This contraction in labor force supply implies that the hiring capacity for businesses in this city may be structurally constrained, making it harder to find and recruit new workers. The declining labor force growth rate is a significant headwind for businesses looking to expand their workforce.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood is decreasing at a rate of -3.35% year-over-year, ranking below average at the 38th percentile. This decline in building permits suggests that the housing supply is tightening, which could lead to future affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce. The reduction in permits may signal a supply squeeze building ahead, potentially limiting the city's ability to attract and retain workers.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood is currently 51 days, with a year-over-year increase of +8.5%, ranking in the top tier at the 80th percentile. This indicates a slower market, where homes are sitting longer before being sold, which could make it more accessible for workers relocating to this city. However, in the context of a strong job market, a rising days on market could signal a healthy normalization, but given the weak job market, it may indicate demand erosion.

Office Economy

The share of jobs in professional and office sectors in Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood ranks in the bottom tier at the 14th percentile, indicating a relatively shallow talent pool in these areas. This city is less suited for businesses that require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as tech, finance, or consulting firms, but may be more appropriate for industries with different workforce requirements.

The Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood metro area offers businesses a relatively low-wage and low-unemployment environment, but its slow labor force growth, tightening housing supply, and expensive cost of living relative to peers pose significant challenges. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's limited labor market dynamism, characterized by low labor demand and stagnant wage growth, which may hinder businesses' ability to attract, retain, and grow their workforce.

Grand Rapids

Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood

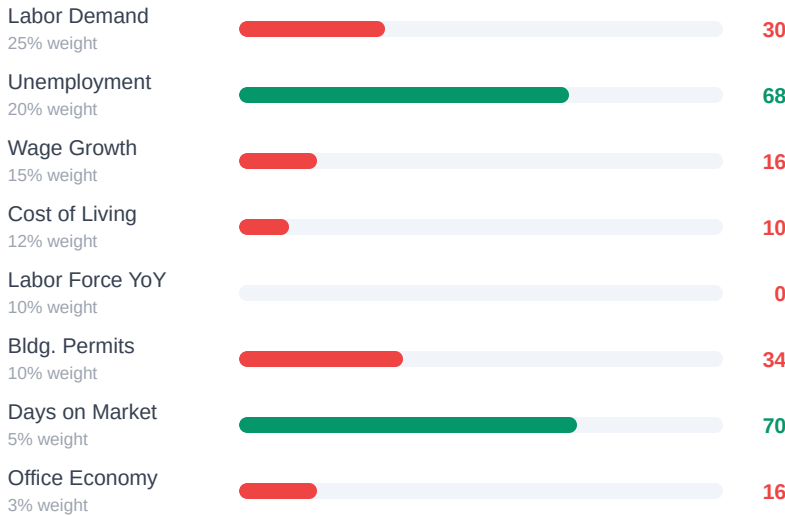
C

VERY POOR

32.1th percentile

Rank 45 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

4.3%

of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+1.4%

avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

+0.7%

nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE YOY

-7.5%

civilian labor force growth

BUILDING PERMITS

-5.7%

residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

38 days

median, +2.7% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood metro area has an overall grade of C, ranking 32.1th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its low labor demand and stagnant wage growth. The labor demand composite score of 4.59, combining a +0.68% employment growth rate and a -0.658% weekly hours deviation, signals a contraction in genuine demand expansion. This, coupled with the bottom-tier wage growth, defines the city's current economic character.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate of +0.68% and weekly hours deviation of -0.658% indicate a lack of genuine demand expansion, suggesting that while there is some job growth, it is not being accompanied by increased hours worked, which could signal a survivor squeeze where remaining workers absorb the load of eliminated roles. This combination does not bode well for businesses looking to expand or relocate, as it may indicate a lack of momentum in the labor market. The labor demand composite score of 4.59 further reinforces this notion, ranking below average at the 30th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate of 4.30% is relatively low, ranking above average at the 68th percentile, indicating a tight labor market with some slack. For businesses trying to hire in this market, the practical implication is that it may be harder to find and retain talent, potentially leading to upward pressure on wages. However, the relatively low unemployment rate also suggests that there is still some availability of labor, albeit with potential competition for skilled workers.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate of +1.41% is stagnant, ranking in the bottom tier at the 16th percentile, indicating slow labor cost increases for employers but weak bargaining power for workers. This slow wage growth may attract businesses looking for a flat cost environment, but it also suggests that worker purchasing power is not increasing significantly, which could impact local consumer demand. As a result, businesses may need to consider offering competitive wages to attract and retain top talent.

Cost of Living

The city's cost of living, with a PSF of \$217/sqft and an earnings ratio of \$32.58/hr, resulting in a ratio of 6.66, ranks in the bottom tier at the 10th percentile, indicating that the city is relatively expensive. This means that the city may struggle to attract talent without offering wage premiums, as the high cost of living could offset any potential benefits of relocating to the area. The 2.8% year-over-year increase in PSF further exacerbates this issue, making the city less competitive in terms of affordability.

Labor Force Growth

The year-over-year growth rate of the civilian labor force is -7.49%, ranking in the bottom tier at the 0th percentile, indicating a significant contraction in the labor force supply. This implies that the hiring capacity for businesses is structurally constrained, making it challenging to find and retain workers, especially in a tight labor market. The shrinking labor pool poses a significant risk for businesses looking to expand or relocate to the area.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in building permits is -5.72%, ranking below average at the 34th percentile, indicating a tightening of the housing supply. This signals that future affordability and workforce accommodation may be at risk, as the lack of new housing developments could exacerbate the existing affordability issues and make it harder for workers to relocate to the area. The decline in building permits suggests that the city may struggle to provide adequate housing for its workforce, further constraining labor market growth.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 38 days, with a year-over-year increase of 2.7%, ranking above average at the 70th percentile, indicating a slower market. For workers relocating to this city, the slower market means that they may have more time to find a suitable home, making the city more accessible in terms of housing. However, the rising days on market could also signal a normalization of the market, potentially indicating a shift away from a seller's market.

Office Economy

The share of jobs in professional and office sectors is relatively low, ranking in the bottom tier at the 16th percentile, indicating a shallow talent pool for businesses requiring specialized office workers. This city is best suited for businesses that do not require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as industrial or logistics-dominant economies, but may not be ideal for tech, finance, or consulting firms that rely on a highly skilled workforce.

The Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood metro area offers businesses a relatively tight labor market with slow wage growth, but the significant contraction in the labor force supply and high cost of living pose significant risks for businesses looking to expand or relocate. The single biggest constraint for decision-makers is the shrinking labor pool, which could limit the city's ability to support business growth and expansion, making it essential for businesses to carefully consider these factors when evaluating the area as a potential location.

Fresno

Fresno

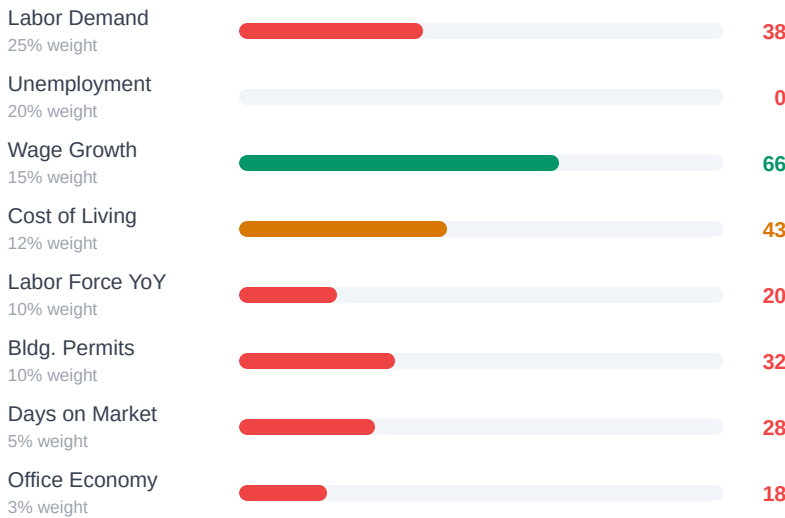
C-

CRITICAL

31.7th percentile

Rank 46 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

7.7%

of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+4.5%

avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

+0.8%

nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE YOY

-1.4%

civilian labor force growth

BUILDING PERMITS

-6.9%

residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

57 days

median, 0.0% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The city of Fresno has an overall grade of C- with a composite score ranking it 31.7th percentile out of 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its low unemployment rate of 7.70% and its above-average wage growth of 4.51% year-over-year. These metrics suggest a complex labor market with both strengths and weaknesses.

Labor Demand

Fresno's employment growth rate is 0.79% year-over-year, while weekly hours are deviating -0.503% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a labor demand contraction, as the city is not adding jobs at a significant rate and hours are below trend. This suggests that the labor market is not experiencing genuine demand expansion.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Fresno is 7.70%, which is the lowest percentile rank, indicating a very tight labor market. This means that businesses trying to hire in this city will face significant competition for workers and may need to offer higher wages to attract talent. The tight labor market will make it harder for companies to staff their operations.

Wage Growth

Wage growth in Fresno is 4.51% year-over-year, which is above average, ranking in the 66th percentile. This fast wage growth signals rising labor costs for employers, but it also means that workers have strong purchasing power. Companies operating in Fresno should be prepared for increasing labor costs, but they can also benefit from a workforce with strong disposable income.

Cost of Living

Fresno has a cost of living score ranking it in the 43rd percentile, with a price-to-salary ratio of \$263/sqft to \$34.06/hr, resulting in a ratio of 7.72. This indicates that the city is near the median in terms of affordability. The fact that PSF is rising 0.4% year-over-year relative to wages means that affordability is not improving. This neutral affordability score means that businesses may not have a significant talent attraction advantage due to cost of living.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Fresno is shrinking at a rate of -1.42% year-over-year. This contraction in labor force supply means that businesses may face structural headwinds when trying to hire, as the pool of available workers is decreasing. This will make it even harder for companies to find the talent they need.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Fresno is decreasing by 6.89% year-over-year. This decline in permits signals that housing supply is tightening, which may lead to future affordability issues and make it harder for workers to relocate to the city. This is a concern for businesses that rely on a mobile workforce.

Days on Market

The median days on market in Fresno is 57 days, with no year-over-year change. This indicates a relatively slow market, which can make it more accessible for workers relocating to the city. However, the lack of change in days on market may also signal a stable but unremarkable housing market.

Office Economy

Fresno has a professional and office worker share ranking it in the 18th percentile, indicating a relatively shallow talent pool in these sectors. This means that the city is less suited for businesses that require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as tech, finance, or consulting companies. Instead, Fresno may be more suitable for industries with fewer specialized roles, such as logistics or manufacturing.

The city of Fresno presents a mixed bag for businesses, with above-average wage growth and a tight labor market, but also a shrinking labor force and tightening housing supply. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's limited labor force growth, which may hinder a company's ability to hire and expand operations in the long term.

Jacksonville

Jacksonville

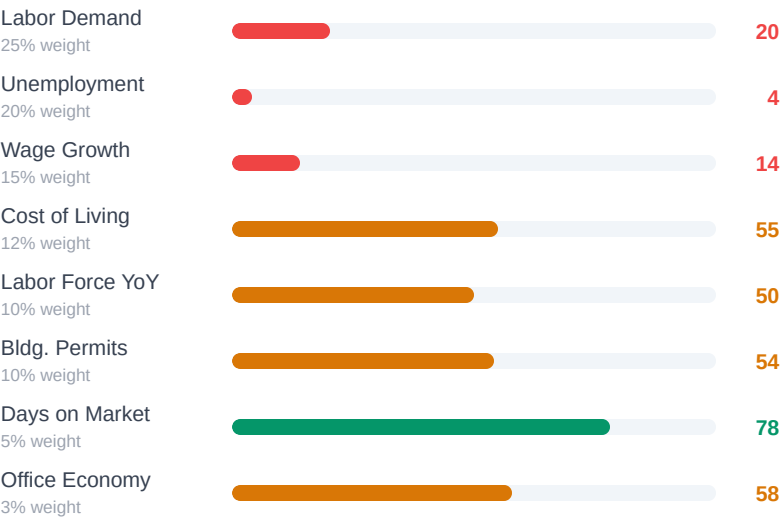
C-

CRITICAL

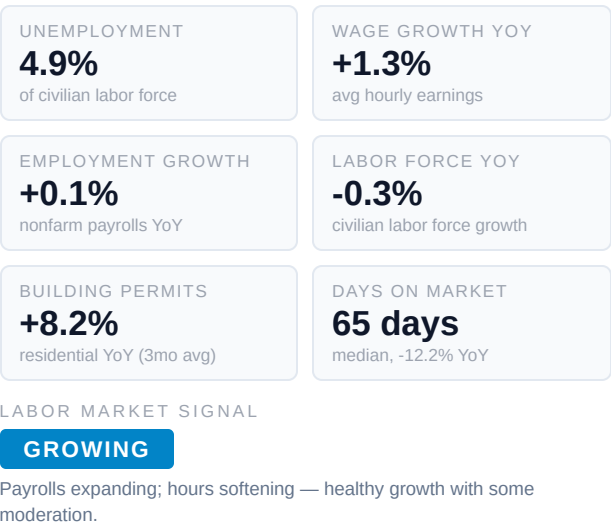
30.6th percentile

Rank 47 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0-100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The city of Jacksonville has an overall grade of C- with a composite score ranking it 30.6th percentile out of 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its low labor demand, with a composite score of 3.86, and its high unemployment rate of 4.90%, which ranks in the bottom tier at the 4th percentile. These metrics signal a challenging environment for businesses looking to expand or relocate.

Labor Demand

Jacksonville's employment growth rate is a modest +0.06% year-over-year, while weekly hours are deviating -0.520% from the city's own 12-month trend. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, indicating that the city is not experiencing genuine demand expansion. The low labor demand composite score of 3.86, ranking in the 20th percentile, further supports this assessment.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Jacksonville is 4.90%, ranking in the bottom tier at the 4th percentile. This high unemployment rate indicates a slack market, making it easier for businesses to hire workers. However, this also implies weaker local consumer demand, which could impact businesses that rely on local spending.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Jacksonville is +1.34%, ranking in the bottom tier at the 14th percentile. This slow wage growth rate suggests a relatively flat cost environment for employers, but it also means that workers have weak bargaining power. As a result, businesses may not face significant pressure to increase wages, but workers may not have the purchasing power to drive local economic growth.

Cost of Living

Jacksonville has a cost of living score ranking in the 55th percentile, with a price-to-salary ratio of \$214/sqft to \$37.45/hr, or 5.71. The fact that PSF is falling -2.3% year-over-year relative to wages is a key driver of this near-median affordability score. This means that the city is relatively affordable compared to its peers, which could be a talent attraction advantage for businesses without needing to offer significant wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Jacksonville is shrinking at a rate of -0.29% year-over-year, ranking near the median at the 50th percentile. This contraction in labor force supply implies a structural headwind for hiring, making it more challenging for businesses to find and recruit workers.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Jacksonville is increasing by +8.24% year-over-year, ranking near the median at the 54th percentile. This expansion in housing supply signals that developer confidence is growing, and future affordability and workforce accommodation may improve. However, the current pace of growth is not exceptionally strong, so businesses should not expect significant relief from affordability pressures in the short term.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Jacksonville is currently 65 days, with a year-over-year decrease of -12.2%. This relatively fast market, ranking in the 78th percentile, means that homes are selling quickly, which could make it challenging for relocating workers to find housing. Businesses may need to offer relocation assistance or other incentives to attract talent to the area.

Office Economy

Jacksonville's professional and office worker share ranks near the median at the 58th percentile, with a composite score of 2.80. This indicates a moderately deep talent pool, making the city suited for businesses that require specialized office or professional roles, but it may not be the best fit for companies that need a highly specialized or abundant tech/finance/consulting workforce.

The city of Jacksonville offers businesses a relatively affordable cost of living and a slack labor market, making it easier to hire workers. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the low labor demand and slow wage growth, which could limit the city's ability to attract and retain top talent. Businesses should carefully consider these factors when evaluating Jacksonville as a potential location for expansion or relocation.

Chicago

Chicago-Naperville-Elgin

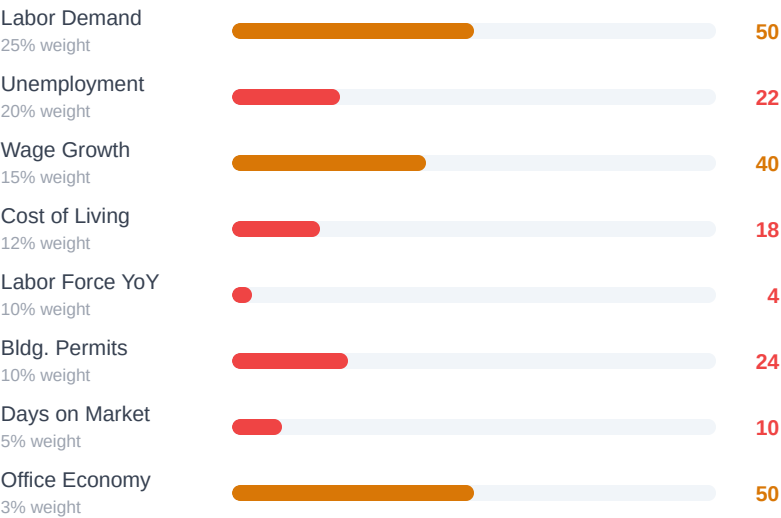
C-

CRITICAL

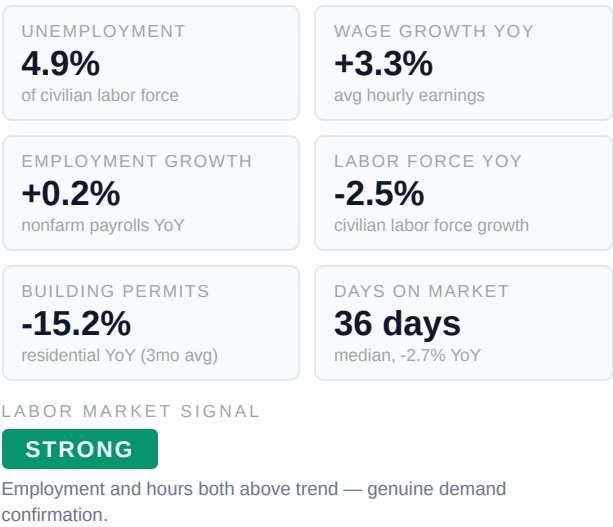
29.9th percentile

Rank 48 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0-100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Chicago-Naperville-Elgin metro area has an overall grade of C- with a composite score ranking it at the 29.9th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its low labor force growth rate of -2.46% YoY and its high cost of living, with a PSF to earnings ratio of 5.87, ranking it in the 18th percentile for affordability. The combination of these metrics suggests a challenging environment for businesses looking to hire and expand.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Chicago-Naperville-Elgin is +0.22% YoY, and weekly hours are deviating from the trend by +0.823%, indicating a near median labor demand composite score of 5.43. This combination signals a genuine demand expansion, albeit a modest one. The city's labor market is growing, but not at a rapid pace.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Chicago-Naperville-Elgin is 4.90%, ranking it in the 22nd percentile, indicating a below-average labor market with some slack. This means that businesses may find it slightly easier to hire in this city compared to others, but may not face significant wage pressure. However, the relatively high unemployment rate also suggests weaker local consumer demand.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Chicago-Naperville-Elgin is +3.28%, ranking it in the 40th percentile, indicating moderate wage growth. This implies that employer labor costs are rising, but not at an alarming rate, and worker purchasing power is increasing. Businesses should factor in moderate wage increases when planning for labor costs.

Cost of Living

Chicago-Naperville-Elgin has a cost of living percentile rank of 18, indicating that it is an expensive city relative to its peers, with a PSF to earnings ratio of 5.87 and a YoY increase of 3.8% in PSF. This means that the city may struggle to attract talent without offering wage premiums, as the high cost of living may offset higher salaries.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Chicago-Naperville-Elgin is contracting at a rate of -2.46% YoY, indicating a shrinking labor pool. This implies a structural headwind for hiring, as the supply of workers is decreasing, making it more challenging for businesses to find and recruit talent.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits in Chicago-Naperville-Elgin is -15.18%, indicating a tightening housing supply. This signals that future affordability and workforce accommodation may be at risk, as the city's housing stock is not expanding to meet

demand.

Days on Market

The current median days on market in Chicago-Naperville-Elgin is 36 days, with a YoY decrease of -2.7%, ranking it in the 10th percentile. This indicates a relatively fast-paced market, making it challenging for relocating workers to find housing, as homes are selling quickly.

Office Economy

Chicago-Naperville-Elgin has a professional and office worker share ranking it in the 50th percentile, indicating a deep but not exceptional talent pool. This city is well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, and consulting sectors, but may not be the best fit for industrial or logistics-dominant economies.

The Chicago-Naperville-Elgin metro area offers businesses a moderate labor market with some slack, but also presents significant challenges, including a high cost of living and a shrinking labor force. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's limited labor pool, which may hinder hiring and expansion plans, making it essential to factor in strategies to attract and retain talent.

Louisville

Louisville-Jefferson County

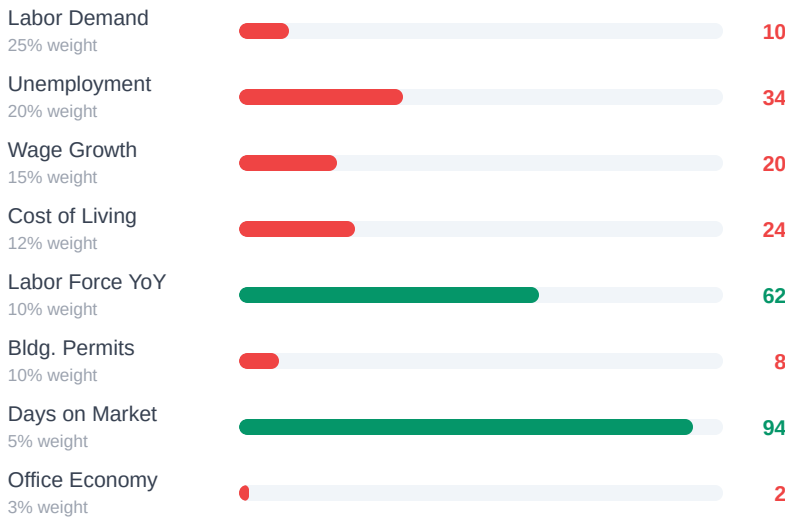
C-

CRITICAL

27.0th percentile

Rank 49 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

4.8%
of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+1.7%
avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

-0.1%
nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE YOY

+0.2%
civilian labor force growth

BUILDING PERMITS

-31.1%
residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

44 days
median, +12.8% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

SQUEEZE

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Louisville-Jefferson County metro area has an overall grade of C- with a composite score ranking it at the 27.0th percentile out of 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its low labor demand, with a composite score in the bottom tier, and its slow wage growth, at +1.74% year-over-year. These metrics signal a challenging environment for businesses looking to expand or relocate.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Louisville-Jefferson County is -0.13% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating from the trend by +1.140%. This combination signals a survivor squeeze, where remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles, rather than genuine demand expansion. The labor demand composite score of 2.98 is in the bottom tier, indicating a weak job market.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Louisville-Jefferson County is 4.80%, which is below average, ranking at the 34th percentile. This indicates a relatively tight market, making it harder for businesses to hire, with potential upward pressure on wages. Companies looking to staff up may face challenges in finding available talent.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Louisville-Jefferson County is +1.74%, which is below average, ranking at the 20th percentile. This slow wage growth signals a relatively flat cost environment for employers, but also weak bargaining power for workers. As a result, worker purchasing power may not be increasing significantly.

Cost of Living

Louisville-Jefferson County has a cost of living score that ranks at the 24th percentile, with a PSF of \$178/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$31.41, resulting in a ratio of 5.67. This indicates that the city is relatively expensive compared to its peers. The lack of affordability may make it challenging for businesses to attract talent without offering wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Louisville-Jefferson County is growing at a rate of +0.25% year-over-year, which is above average, ranking at the 62nd percentile. This expansion in labor force supply is a positive sign for businesses looking to hire, as it indicates a growing pool of potential workers.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Louisville-Jefferson County has decreased by -31.05% year-over-year, which is in the bottom tier. This sharp decline signals a tightening of housing supply, which may lead to decreased affordability and challenges in accommodating

a growing workforce.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Louisville-Jefferson County is 44 days, with a year-over-year increase of +12.8%, ranking at the 94th percentile. This indicates a slower market, which may be more accessible for workers relocating to the city, as they have more time to find a home.

Office Economy

The professional and office worker share in Louisville-Jefferson County is 0.32, ranking at the 2nd percentile. This indicates a relatively shallow talent pool, making the city less suited for businesses that require a deep knowledge-economy workforce, such as tech or finance companies.

The Louisville-Jefferson County metro area presents a mixed bag for businesses, with some positive signs such as labor force growth, but also significant challenges like low labor demand and slow wage growth. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the potential for a tightening housing supply, which could lead to decreased affordability and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce, making it essential to carefully consider these factors when evaluating the city as a potential location.

Detroit

Detroit-Warren-Dearborn

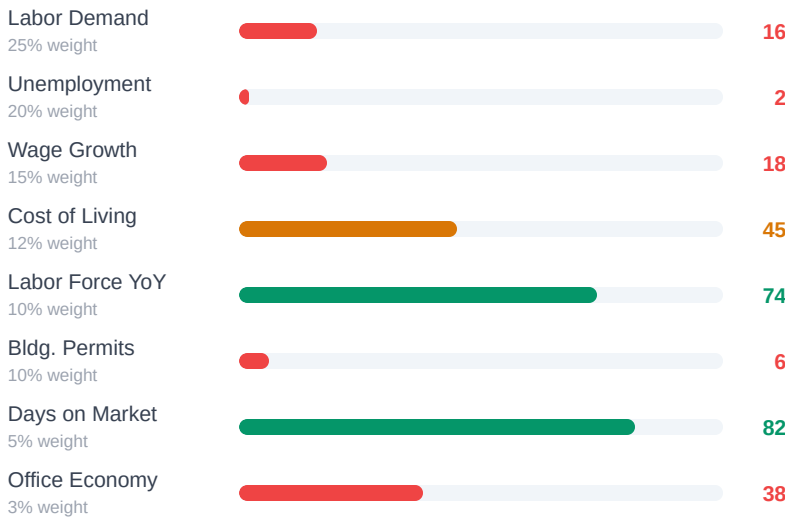
D

EMERGENCY

25.7th percentile

Rank 50 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

6.0%

of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+1.5%

avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

-0.2%

nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE YOY

+0.7%

civilian labor force growth

BUILDING PERMITS

-33.0%

residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

40 days

median, +5.3% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

SQUEEZE

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Detroit-Warren-Dearborn metro area has an overall grade of D, ranking in the 25.7th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a labor demand composite score of 3.58. This city's economic character is most defined by its low unemployment rate of 6.00% and its negative employment growth rate of -0.20%. The combination of these metrics, along with a weekly hours deviation of +0.439%, signals a survivor squeeze, where remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Detroit-Warren-Dearborn is -0.20% year-over-year, while weekly hours are deviating +0.439% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, rather than genuine demand expansion. The labor demand composite score of 3.58 falls in the bottom tier, at the 16th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Detroit-Warren-Dearborn is 6.00%, which is relatively high, indicating a labor market with some slack. This means that businesses trying to hire in this city may have an easier time finding candidates, but may also face weaker local consumer demand. The unemployment rate ranks in the bottom tier, at the 2nd percentile.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Detroit-Warren-Dearborn is +1.48%, which is relatively slow. This moderate wage growth rate implies that employer labor costs are not rising too quickly, but worker purchasing power is also not increasing rapidly. The wage growth rate ranks in the bottom tier, at the 18th percentile.

Cost of Living

Detroit-Warren-Dearborn has a cost of living ratio of \$186/sqft to \$37.53/hr, with a year-over-year increase of +1.6% in PSF. The city's cost of living ranks in the 45th percentile, indicating a near-median affordability level. This means that the city is neither particularly attractive nor unattractive for talent without wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Detroit-Warren-Dearborn is growing at a rate of +0.69% year-over-year, indicating an expanding workforce supply. This positive growth rate implies that the city has a growing pool of potential employees, which can support hiring capacity. The labor force growth rate ranks above average, at the 74th percentile.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Detroit-Warren-Dearborn has decreased by -32.95% year-over-year, indicating a tightening housing supply. This sharp decline in permits signals a potential supply squeeze building ahead, which could negatively impact future affordability and workforce accommodation. The building permits growth rate ranks in the bottom tier, at the 6th percentile.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Detroit-Warren-Dearborn is currently 40 days, with a year-over-year increase of +5.3%. This increase in days on market, combined with the top-tier percentile rank of 82, indicates a slower market, which can make it more accessible for workers relocating to the city.

Office Economy

The share of jobs in professional and office sectors in Detroit-Warren-Dearborn is relatively low, ranking below average at the 38th percentile. This indicates a less deep talent pool for businesses requiring specialized office workers, making the city less suited for tech, finance, or consulting businesses, but potentially more suitable for industrial or logistics-dominant economies.

The Detroit-Warren-Dearborn metro area offers businesses a labor market with some slack and moderate wage growth, but also faces challenges such as a tightening housing supply and a relatively low share of professional and office jobs. The single biggest risk or constraint for a decision-maker to factor in is the potential supply squeeze in housing, which could negatively impact future affordability and workforce accommodation, making it essential to carefully consider the city's overall economic character and potential challenges before making a location decision.